



Hindustan Times

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Apex court to hear plea against CEC next week

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday agreed to hear next week a petition seeking the suspension of chief election commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on the grounds that he unilaterally took several decisions, despite these being opposed by the two other election commissioners.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and justices Joymalaya Bagchi and V Mohana agreed for listing the matter next week on a mentioning by senior advocate Vikas Singh.

Terming this as a "serious" issue, the petition filed as a public interest litigation (PIL) also sought a direction from the court to call for the complete records of the decisions taken during the period from October last year to verify the allegations. It further stated that if the allegations are found true, an independent commission headed by a former Supreme Court judge or a special investigation team (SIT) be set up for a thorough probe for fixing responsibility.

The senior counsel said, "The decisions of the Election Commission of India have to be unanimous or by majority. But the way ECI has functioned raises doubts. If ECI has not taken a unanimous decision, it is a serious issue."

The plea is based on an investigation by the Indian Express, which said election commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu

The CEC in the Supreme Court

1995 TN Seshan (then CEC) vs Union of India

Seshan, the then CEC, challenged the validity of the CEC & Other ECs (Condition of Service) Amendment Ordinance that amended the 1991 Act. It stipulated the panel would be comprised of two election commissioners, apart from the CEC. The Supreme Court dismissed Seshan's petition. The decision is hailed as having upheld the multi-member composition of ECI.

1996 ECI and others vs Dr Subramanian Swamy

The Election Commission filed an appeal with then CEC TN Seshan against a Madras high court order directing him to refrain from deciding a disqualification petition filed by Janata Party chief Subramanian Swamy against then Tamil Nadu CM J Jayalalithaa. She, however, alleged that Seshan was biased towards Swamy. The Supreme Court held in her favour and restrained Seshan from deciding the matter.

2023 Anoop Baranwal vs Union of India

In 2015, lawyer Anoop Baranwal filed a petition challenging the process of appointing CECs and ECs. More petitions came to be filed on this issue. A five-judge Supreme Court bench laid down the law on appointment of CEC and ECs by directing a committee headed by the Prime Minister and comprising the Chief Justice of India and Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition to appoint the CEC and ECs till Parliament promulgates a law.



and Vivek Joshi recorded at least 14 objections between October last year and this August over the functioning of ECI, including several policy measures. The report also claimed that local election officers tasked with adding and deleting names from the electoral rolls were shut out from the database on account of a new IT protocol/system, and that illegal

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more stories

Will back motion to remove Gyanesh as CEC: DMK →P8

Curative petition filed over CEC appointment law →P8

168K VOTERS MAY BE CUT FROM FINAL ANDHRA POLL ROLL

Around 168,000 voters in the Andhra Pradesh electoral rolls were "ineligible" for inclusion in the final list after the special intensive revision, officials said on Tuesday, after the window to dispose of claims and objections ended. An EC official said these included voters who did not furnish verification documents or did not appear for hearings. "Of 44.28 lakh (4.428 million) notices delivered, hearings with regard to 44.27 lakh (4.427 million) were completed. Only 1,665 electors did not reply to notices," said a statement from chief electoral officer Vivek Yadav. →P8

CWC SEEKS RESTORATION OF NAMES OF DELETED VOTERS, S.I.R. HALT

The Congress Working Committee (CWC) demanded restoration of 130 million deleted voters in the electoral rolls and a halt to the special intensive revision (SIR). It also called for PM Narendra Modi's resignation. After a CWC meeting on Tuesday, general secretary KC Venugopal announced a massive agitation at state, district and booth levels with INDIA-bloc allies, and said the party will reach out to voters who have had their names struck off the list. "This is not the game of Gyanesh Kumar. He is only a tool... (SIR) could not happen without the concurrence of Modi and Amit Shah," he said. →P5

GOVT EXPLORING ROUTE OVER CHINA TO BYPASS PAK AIRSPACE BAN

Neha LM Tripathi

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NEW DELHI: India is exploring an alternative air route over China's Xinjiang to reduce the impact of the continued closure of Pakistani airspace, civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu said.

"We are looking at other alternatives. Discussions on the Hotan route are going on between the two countries. Our external affairs ministry is engaging with their country [China]... let us see how it goes, but we are trying alternatives," Naidu told reporters.

Naidu did not indicate a timeline for the route's opening, nor did he suggest an agreement had been reached with China. →P5

PROPOSED FCRA RULES POSE OPERATIONAL CHALLENGES: SBI

Saubhadra Chatterji

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NEW DELHI: The State Bank of India, which receives all foreign donations, and the Union law ministry support the objectives of proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, but the bank told the Joint Parliamentary Committee on the bill on Tuesday that it poses challenges from a banker's perspective.

SBI said the bill does not specify whether a frozen account keeps operating or who authorises payments. It warned small and rural associations could lose control of funds immediately on automatic cessation of registration, and ongoing programmes might suffer during vesting. →P8

Can't detain under NSA based on confession: SC

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NEW DELHI: Observing that a preventive detention cannot become punitive, the Supreme Court on Tuesday slapped a cost of ₹10 lakh on the Uttar Pradesh government for passing an order under the National Security Act (NSA) against an accused in the Sambhal mosque violence in November 2024.

Setting aside the detention order issued in October 2025 by the District Magistrate, Sambhal, a bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Naidu held that it was based on a confessional statement made by the accused while in custody and the same could not have served as the sole basis for curtailing the liberty of the

What the top court said

"The appellant has already suffered considerable loss of liberty, even while being granted bail in all the cases relating to the incident in which he featured as an accused. In such circumstances, the process was made the punishment..."

— BENCH OF JUSTICES DIPANKAR DATTA AND SHEEL NAU



accused.

The order was passed on a petition filed by one Mulla Afroz, who was an accused in the violence that followed an order of survey of the Sambhal mosque by a district court on November 24, 2024.

The survey order was passed in a suit filed by Hindu parties seeking access to the Sambhal mosque claiming that the site used to be a temple.

Four deaths were reported during the violence. The police arrested Afroz nearly two months after the incident. The detention order under NSA was passed on October 13, 2025 and was again confirmed on November 28, 2025 for a period of one year, expiring two months later.

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→NO HOOKAH BARS IN SMOKING AREAS OF U.P. RESTAURANTS: HIGH COURT, P7

Pak terror concerns can cloud ties with US: EAM

Shashank Mattoo

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WASHINGTON: India's concerns over terrorism emanating from Pakistan and a lack of sufficient understanding of those concerns in the US can affect the India-US relationship, external affairs minister S Jaishankar said in New York on Monday, identifying the issue as one of the challenges facing the partnership.

"What for us in India is particularly important is the issue of terrorism. There are very few countries that have been

subjected to the kind of terrorism that we have from a neighbour as part of a deliberate, conscious policy over many, many decades," he said at a conversation hosted by the Asia Society. "Now, if something that matters so deeply to us — there isn't enough understanding or appreciation or empathy of that — that creates a problem too," he said. "If one of my primary concerns is not fully appreciated by my partner, then that can have an impact on the relationship." →P7

→CONCERNS OVER TARIFF LAW CONVEYED TO U.S. TEAM, P7

HC JUNKS FSSAI ORDER TO STOP USE OF 'ENERGY DRINK' PHRASE

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Tuesday set aside Food Safety and Standards Authority of India's (FSSAI) order directing Red Bull to discontinue using the descriptor "Energy Drink" for its products, observing the order was given without allowing the beverage maker the opportunity for an explanation. A bench of justice Amit Mahajan directed FSSAI to consider the matter afresh after giving the company an opportunity of being heard. →P7

SHAH INAUGURATES BARAPULLAH PH-3, KEY INFRA PROJECTS

Snehil Sinha

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NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Tuesday unveiled the Barapullah Phase 3 corridor and the Mukarba Chowk underpass and laid foundation stones for Modi Mill-Savitri Cinema flyover and Loni Road underpass.

NIA COURT GRANTS SACHIN WAZE BAIL IN ANTILIA CASE

MUMBAI: A special NIA court Tuesday granted bail to former Mumbai police officer Sachin Waze in the Antilia explosives case and the related murder of a Thane trader in 2021. The court said there was not an "iota of material" to suggest Waze had "terrorised" anyone in the case. NIA has appealed the bail. →P11

ASSAM RIFLES JAWAN KILLED IN ATTACK ON MYANMAR BORDER

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ITANAGAR: One Assam Rifles personnel was killed and four others were injured after a patrol team came under a suspected militant attack along the India-Myanmar border in Arunachal Pradesh's Changlang on Tuesday. →P10

CISF jawan kills 4 colleagues in J&K

HT Correspondents

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NEW DELHI/JAMMU: A head constable of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) shot dead four of his colleagues after an altercation in Kathua district of Jammu & Kashmir on Tuesday, officers aware of the matter said.

The deceased were identified as assistant commandant Ankur Kumar Pandey, constables Rafiq Ahmed and Sandeep Kumar, and sub-inspector Lakshman Singh.

They were posted at the Sewa Hydel Power Project in Mashka, Basohli, along with the accused head constable Avdesh Kumar.

An officer aware of the matter said, "Prima facie, the probe revealed the incident took place just before the change of guard on Tuesday evening. An argument broke out between the accused CISF head constable and the other four. The accused man has been arrested and handed over to the police. He used his service weapon, which has been seized."

Kathua senior superintendent of police Mohita Sharma confirmed the incident and the arrest.

The police are questioning Kumar, even as the CISF is conducting an internal inquiry into the circumstances that led to the incident. →P6

US forces to leave Iraq after 2+ decades today

Reuters

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BAGHDAD: US forces are set to pull out from their last bases in Iraq by Wednesday, a departure celebrated as a victory by Iran and its allies who now have deep influence in the country where 4,500 Americans died during more than two decades of war.

Iraqi security experts say the withdrawal, agreed in 2024 under President Joe Biden and carried out by Donald Trump's administration could give Tehran and its

powerful allies free rein, while also allowing other US enemies to stage a comeback, including Islamic State. Abu Mojtaba al-Yasiri, a commander in the Islamic Resistance in Iraq, an umbrella group of Iran-backed armed factions, described the US withdrawal as "a historic victory for Iraqi Islamic resistance groups" and a "crushing defeat for the American project".

US forces invaded Iraq in 2003 to topple Sunni Muslim leader Saddam Hussein. →P11

→IRAN THREATENS STRIKES, AWAITS U.S. RESPONSE ON HORMUZ PLAN, P11

HC GRANTS BAIL TO CONG NANDIGRAM BYPOLL CANDIDATE

KOLKATA: The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday granted interim bail to Congress candidate for the Nandigram bypoll in West Bengal, Milan Pradhan, till October 20 in all six cases registered against him in 2007, enabling him to campaign for the by-election scheduled to be held on October 6. →P5

'PROBE EVIDENCE DESTRUCTION IN DELHI EXEC KILLING'

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NEW DELHI: A court on Tuesday directed a probe into the role of officials at Badshahpur police station and the autopsy surgeon for potential "destruction of evidence" in the murder of Delhi executive Yuvraj Singh Manchanda.

CAPITAL TO HOST INDIA BIENNALE FROM DEC-MAR

Dhamini Ratnam

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NEW DELHI: After a successful exhibition at the Venice Biennale, the ministry of culture plans to showcase the works of the five artists it displayed there at the India Biennale slated to begin in Delhi on December 4. →P2

{ A TALE OF TWO FIRSTS }

The wonder women: 2 more golds as relay team stuns track, Dhanda breaks records in trap win



The Indian women's 4x400m relay team and shooter Neeru Dhanda (inset) pose with their Asian Games gold medals on Tuesday.

P11

NEW DELHI: India's gold medal tally at the 2026 Asian Games rose to six on Tuesday, with the women's 4x400m relay team winning the country's first athletics gold at Aichi-Nagoya and Neeru Dhanda making history with an individual women's trap title at the continental event.

The quartet of Kiran Pahal, MR Poovamma, Prachi Chaudhary and Vithya Ramraj clocked 3:29.69 to win gold, ahead of Bahrain and



ASIAN GAMES

China. The men's 4x400m and mixed 4x100m relay teams also made the podium, adding bronze medals.

Gulveer Singh clinched a hat-trick of medals at the Games as he finished third in the 5,000m final.

Dhanda shot 28 out of 30 targets in the trap final to break the Asian and the Games record. Earlier in the day, she helped the women's trap team win silver. →P13, 14

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{ MY INDIA } AIIB MEETING

Doha: Nirmala holds talks on trade, UPI



Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday met Qatari ministers of finance and foreign trade in Doha and discussed completing the Bilateral Investment Treaty and engagement for a free trade agreement. On the sidelines of the annual meeting of the Asian Infrastructure and Investment Bank (AIIB), Qatar FM Ali bin Ahmed Al Kuwari and Sitharaman discussed expansion of the UPI system in Qatar and sought finalisation of BIT. They also discussed the Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement as a strengthened framework for trade, investment and tax certainty, the Indian finance ministry said. **PTI**

{ MY INDIA } OVER EL NINO FEARS

FY27 grain output target cut by 2.63mt



The Centre has set a 373.93 million tonne foodgrain production target for 2026-27, 2.63 million tonnes below the estimated output for the previous year, citing the impact of El Nino conditions on water availability and soil moisture. The target includes a 177.72 million tonne rabi crop, Union agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said on Tuesday. "In view of the situation created by El Nino, the production target has been fixed at 373.93 million tonnes for the year 2026-27," Chouhan said. **HTC**

{ BUSINESS } ADVANCED MODELS

Anthropic warns AI's 'risks to humanity' in IPO filing



Anthropic plans to caution potential investors in its IPO that advanced AI could pose "catastrophic or existential risks to humanity," an extraordinary warning by a company seeking to profit from the same technology. Its IPO prospectus highlights risks associated with its AI models, which it said could exhibit "self-preserving behaviours," including attempts to "resist shutdown," and "conceal or manipulate information." "Our development of highly advanced models...could further increase the risk that our models cause harm," Anthropic said in the filing. **REUTERS**

{ SPORT } PHASED ACQUISITION

UAE-based company buys Kerala Blasters



UAE-based sports and sports-tech consortium Al Fursan, led by Sheikh Ahmad bin Faisal Al Qasbi, on Tuesday announced the acquisition of ISL club Kerala Blasters FC from Magnum Group. Al Fursan will acquire 100% ownership of the club in phases over eight months, with the process expected to be completed at the end of the 2026-27 season. Kerala Blasters CEO Abhik Chatterjee described the transition as an important moment in the club's history and sought the continued support of its fans. **PTI**

{ MY INDIA } 'UNWARRANTED'

India rejects Turkey prez remarks on J&K



India on Tuesday rejected references to Jammu & Kashmir in Turkey President Recep Tayyip Erdogan's address at the UN General Assembly, calling them "unwarranted" and asserting that no external party has any locus standi on the issue. MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal was asked how India looked at Erdogan's address, in which he said that in South Asia, all disputes, including the Kashmir issue, should be addressed through dialogue within the framework of the UN Charter. "India rejects unwarranted references to India and the UT of J&K made by the president of Turkey during his UNGA address," Jaiswal said. **PTI**

Delhi as its canvas: Biennale to spread out across Capital

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NEW DELHI: After a successful exhibition at the Venice Biennale, the ministry of culture plans to showcase the works of the five artists it displayed there at the India Biennale slated to begin in Delhi on December 4 and go on well into March next year.

The art, architecture and design festival will take place across the city, including in the lawns of the Lodhi Gardens, the Qutub Minar complex, the Agra-ken ki Baoli, the Red Fort and the Safdarjung Tomb, as well as other galleries, embassy precincts and private cultural venues.

The ministry's own exhibition is expected to come up at the 16th-century Purana Qila, which will serve as the hub or focal point of the Biennale.

Participants include architecture and design firms as well as public and private art and cultural institutions such as the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA), the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre, the JSW Foundation, and DAG (formerly Delhi Art Gallery). "We should make our monuments into live cultural spaces and open them up so that [visitors] can not only enjoy history but also get a glimpse of the contemporary art scene of India," Vivek Aggarwal, secretary, ministry of culture said. "The whole of Delhi will be a stage."

"We are looking at state pavilions and representation from states and Union Territories, and we will also have international exhibitors," he added.

The government will provide the "core and shell", an official stated, referring to the infrastructure, electricity, and other requirements of exhibitors at site. However, each participant is expected to bear the costs of exhibiting at the Biennale.

The 108-day event (the Biennale ends on March 21, 2027) will also have a students' biennale, populated by works of students from participating colleges and institutions, as well as talks, workshops and daily performance art programming. "We will also organise conversations on various aspects of art and artists, the use of Artificial Intelligence, and the impact of emerging technology on various aspects of art," Aggarwal said.

A curatorium comprising a team culled from different public



The whole of Delhi will be a stage during the Biennale, says Vivek Aggarwal, secretary, ministry of culture.

and private institutions, including the director general of NGMA, Dr Sanjeev Kishor Gautam, and the director of Apparao Galleries, Sharan Apparao, has been appointed.

The theme of the edition is Tat Twam Asi — Sanskrit for "You Are That" — and exhibitors have been asked to respond to the theme using the lens of the five senses.

"The idea is that if we can go internationally and participate, why can't we curate an event in India where Indian art is centre-stage? We have to bring the world to India as well. So the idea is that we scale up the initiative to such a level where India becomes a host," Aggarwal said.

The idea of such a biennale arose after Aggarwal and his team of officials helped set up the India Pavilion at the 61st International Art Exhibition of La Biennale di Venezia (Venice Biennale) in partnership with Serendipity Arts and NMACC, in May.

Curated by Amin Jaffer, the pavilion in Venice features the works of five artists — Alwar Balasubramanian, Ranjani Shettar, Sumakshi Singh, Skarma Sonam Tashi and Asim Waqif — which is unusual for a national pavilion that typically features only one or two artists. The five Indian artists, who hail from different parts of the country, worked across a range of materials to create large-scale installations based on Jaffer's curatorial prompt, "geographies of distance: remembering home."

"We will erect the same exhibition at NGMA, so that people in India can see what we had depicted in Venice," Aggarwal said. The inaugural edition of the India Biennale was held in 2023, albeit at a smaller scale. The India Art, Architecture and Design Biennale was held at the Red Fort, and comprised seven themed pavilions. A parallel students' biennale was also held at the Lalit Kala Akademi.

Khairlanji: Between the persistence of caste and the insistence on justice

The September 29, 2006 Dalit massacre at Khairlanji shocked the nation. Twenty years later, HT reinvestigates the case

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Around 7.30pm on September 29, 2006, the lone telephone at Andhalgaon police station rang. Constable Rajkumar Dongare picked up. Across the crackling line came the panicked voice of Sidharth Gajbiye, a resident of Dhusala village 3.5km away. His cousin Bhaiyyalal Bhotmange, Gajbiye said, had just burst in, having fled through the rice fields from a mob of 60-70 villagers — on tractors, armed with rods, stones and bicycle chains — bearing down on his mud-and-brick home. "Maaro Saalon Ko (kill the b*****)", rose the cry that sent Bhaiyyalal scampering out of Khairlanji, and which Gajbiye repeated over the phone. Dongare listened, set the receiver down and, according to two former officials, did nothing.

Tensions had been building up for weeks in Khairlanji, a village of 800 in Maharashtra's Bhandara district — 750 of them OBCs and just 20 Dalits in three households. Matriarch Surekha Bhotmange's acumen had made her family relatively prosperous despite irritants such as being stopped from building a pucca house or getting an electricity connection. Keen on education, Surekha bought her daughter Priyanka a bicycle to commute to college, inadvertently stoking caste resentment. "There was a feeling in the village that the Mahar family needed to be straightened out," said one of the two officials cited above. A dispute over Bhaiyyalal's land soured ties further.

On September 3, 2006, it erupted. Gajbiye — who helped the Bhotmanges win their land dispute in court — was thrashed in front of Surekha and Priyanka, who later testified. Andhalgaon police station took 13 days to register an FIR and refused to invoke the SC/ST Act. Then station in-charge, Sureshwar Bhanare, arrested no one quickly. "The police were hand in glove with the accused in weakening the case," said advocate Sashibhushan Wahane, later a government-appointed prosecutor.

On September 29, the police finally charged 12 people under IPC sections 324 (voluntarily causing hurt), 147 (rioting), 148 (rioting with deadly weapons) and 149 (unlawful assembly) — but not the SC/ST Act. Within three hours, the accused secured bail. Trundling through the fields on tractors, about 70 people stopped at the panchayat office where, according to the first official, the plot to attack the Bhotmanges was hatched.

Dark clouds were hovering over the Dalit family. Priyanka was drawing water from the well when she overheard village women say *Dheds* — a slur for Dalits — needed to be shown their place. At 5pm, Surekha called her nephew Rashtrapal Narnaware. "Something bad is happening," she said. Narnaware urged her to leave. Surekha demurred, unsure what was coming.

Around 6pm, the villagers returned drunk and triumphant, and broke into the Bhotmange house. "You Mahars, Dheds, you think too much of yourselves," they shouted as they thrashed Surekha, 44, her two sons Roshan, 23, and Sudhir, 21, and daughter Priyanka, 17, before dragging their

limp bodies to the village square.

The Khairlanji massacre, considered among India's most macabre episodes, exposed the grisly realities of caste. Yet police inaction, procedural violations and social hostility marked every step of the investigation, warped the trial, and left one of India's worst caste atrocities unrecognised as such by the judiciary. Drawing on court transcripts, government records, fact-finding reports, field visits and interviews with 20-odd villagers, witnesses, officers, lawyers and police officers, HT reinvestigates the case.

Women gangraped, men's genitals mutilated

Between 6pm and 8pm, carnage raged at the Bhotmange house. Surekha and Priyanka were thrashed, gangraped and dragged out. Sudhir and Roshan were beaten, their genitals mutilated. The villagers loaded the bodies onto a bullock cart and dumped them in a canal four kilometres away. Beside it, they met to seal their silence forever, according to a former investigator in the case. At 8.30pm — roughly an hour after Gajbiye's call — beat constable Baban Meshram visited the village, reported everything "normal", and left. "The deputy superintendent of police at Andhalgaon did not take any further action on the matter," found a report by the Yashwant Chavan Academy of Development Administration (Yashada).

At 5am the next morning, Bhaiyyalal returned to Khairlanji. His home lay wrecked, their meagre possessions smashed. Shaking with fear, he walked to the police station at 7am. For about three hours, according to the former investigator cited above, the police kept him waiting, until a call from Bhanare confirmed Surekha's naked body had been found. At 10am, the First Information Report (FIR) was finally lodged — under the mildest clause of the SC/ST Act (insult or intimidation in public), with no mention of rape, criminal assault or outraging the modesty of a woman. "When CBI took over the case, it had to conduct a fresh probe," said Ejaz Khan, the federal agency's prosecutor in the case.

At 12pm, Surekha's body — not yet identified in writing — was sent to Mohadi Rural Hospital, where Manisha Banthe was the officiating medical superintendent. Yet Banthe took a call and left before the post-mortem, which fell to Avinash Shende, a junior doctor on a one-year contract. Chaos ensued. The hospital had no latex gloves, delaying the procedure. The doctor took no blood samples and no vaginal, rectal or pubic swabs, ignored conspicuous swellings and took no photographs. Shende later told a panel he didn't check for sexual assault because the FIR didn't mention it, according to Anand Telumbde's book *The Persistence of Caste*. Priyanka's post-mortem showed similar lapses, the government probe later found. A former official quoted above said Tumsar lawmaker Madhukar Kukde was present during the first post-mortem. "When asked about the purpose of the call, the civil surgeon gave evasive replies...this points to a strong possibility that under political pressure the civil surgeon instructed Dr Shende to fabricate the post-mortem in a way that the



Police personnel at Khairlanji village in 2010. A string of lapses by the police hobbled the prosecution's case repeatedly; (inset) Bhaiyyalal Bhotmange, the lone survivor of the attack.

ANSHUMAN POYREKAR/HT PHOTO

crucial evidence, especially on the possibility of rape on victims, is lost," the Yashada report said.

The post-mortem was over by 3.30pm. Though Banthe was at the hospital the next day, only Shende examined the other bodies. By midnight, police had pushed Bhaiyyalal to bury his kin.

Gaffes and slips galore in police investigation

On October 1, superintendent of police Suresh Sagar visited the village for the first time. The same day, police arrested 28 people. Pressure mounted on local authorities as news spread. On October 5, the women's bodies were exhumed for a second autopsy. "It remains unclear just who ordered this because the family didn't ask for it," said the former investigator cited above. The second examination proved inconclusive.

Two weeks after the massacre, Nagpur special inspector general of police Pankaj Gupta visited Khairlanji. His statement that rape was not involved sparked an outcry, eventually forcing the government to hand the case to CBI.

"An FIR was never registered under IPC 302 and 376. It was hidden for days by local and state police. Only after the agitation was it handed to CBI," said Wahane.

"The state police didn't even have an eyewitness," CBI found a prime eyewitness," said Khan.

There was another hitch. The police had rounded up 46 people, but 35 were discharged when CBI filed its charge sheet in December, setting off protests.

"The police strategy was simple. Take everybody inside, make them accused, nothing will be proven and everyone will be out. CBI found it very difficult to find evidence nearly two months after the crime. Police had kept all the accused in a single cell. Their cohesion was remarkable," said Milind Pakhale of the Khairlanji Action Committee.

The trial began in Nagpur in May 2007.



The Bhotmange family's house.

SOURCED

Dominant-caste landholders had imposed a code of silence. Farm labourers and cattle grazers were warned that testifying would bring economic boycott and eviction. Many told investigators they were inside their homes, doors bolted, and saw nothing. At least two witnesses wrote to the collector, alleging death threats and social ostracisation, and asking to be moved.

"After the incident, my family and I had to run from the village; it was too dangerous for us to stay," said Rajan Gajbiye, eyewitness and younger brother of Gajbiye. "A CBI officer warned me that if I did not leave, I would be the next to be murdered."

Another witness turned hostile halfway through the trial. "It was physically dangerous to even attend the hearings at the time. The accused would bring their relatives to pack the benches," said Pakhale.

Differences within the prosecution

The early slips repeatedly came back to haunt the prosecution, said two lawyers associated with the case. Without medical evidence, the defence gutted the sexual assault charge, pointed out that weapons described by Bhaiyyalal were missing from the post-mortem report, and underlined repeated police delays. The prosecution's tactical choice not to add rape charges appeared to dilute the crime's gravity. Most importantly, the defence severed the link between the killings and the SC/ST Act, blaming village enmity and even using investigating officer Vinayak Susatkar's testimony to discredit an eyewitness.

In 2008, the trial court convicted eight people, acquitted three and discharged everyone under the SC/ST Act. On this last point, activists alleged the prosecution failed to establish a history of caste animus.

"There was no caste hatred for these killings," the judge held.

"The court held that the fight had taken place due to the Sidharth Gajbiye case. There was no evidence of casteist remarks. The court didn't agree to our contention that caste was the trigger for the killings," said Khan.

Wahane went further, admitting there were differences within the prosecution on the SC/ST Act and blaming special public prosecutor Ujjwal Nikam — an allegation echoed by Pakhale. "I had asked for the death penalty, and for the SC/ST Act to apply, the prima facie evidence for it should have been present. But the agency probing this could not establish that, and the court rejected the claims," Nikam said.

The high court in 2010 confirmed the trial court's order but commuted the death sentences to life imprisonment. "The incident had not occurred on account of caste hatred," the high court said. In 2019, the Supreme Court upheld the high court verdict. By then, Bhaiyyalal had been dead for two years.

A village divided by hard caste lines

Khairlanji presents a difficult paradox. The first major atrocity since the turn of the millennium, it jolted a generation to the realities of caste. One of the few such cases to end in conviction, it underlined the power of dogged advocacy. "The credit goes to activists like us who pursued the case every day, at great personal risk. It ensured Khairlanji didn't end up like other cases," said Pakhale.

Yet the courts' failure to recognise caste animus exposed gaps. "Although offences under the SC/ST Act were initially filed and included in the investigation and chargesheet, the charges were not sustained by the courts," said former Maharashtra chief secretary Ratnakar Gaikwad, who commissioned the Yashada report.

But as Telumbde noted, many of the errant characters — police officers Meshram, Sagar, Susatkar, Bhanare and doctor Shende — were Dalits themselves. "Insofar as the system is considered naturally inimical to Dalit interests, it follows that Dalit individuals who rise within it tend to act against Dalit interests as well. The system thus transforms the individual into its faithful prop," he wrote.

Only two Dalit households remain in Khairlanji today — that of Yograj Khobragade and Vinod Meshram. The Bhotmange hut has crumbled and the land sold. Shamkala Meshram, Vinod's wife, said the massacre cast a long shadow. "We don't celebrate Dr BR Ambedkar's birthday or other

anniversaries. I have sent both my children outside. We only live here because we have land," she said.

Till police were posted in the village, an uneasy calm held. "After they left, caste tensions returned. They didn't even listen to our request to install a statue of Dr Ambedkar. There is a silent fear," she said.

An iron curtain has descended over the village.

On one side are the accused's families, hopeful of release when their 25-year imprisonment ends in 2031. Many feel short-changed, believe the sentencing disproportionate for a crime "committed by outsiders", and harbour deep resentment towards Dalits they see as having brought infamy on the village.

"The incident was done by others, but we were financially weak, we did not have the power to pursue it legally...The people who actually did it got away, and we got trapped in it," said Nepal Binjewar, younger brother of prime convict Gopal Binjewar.

Then village chief Upasrao Urkude blames the case for hurting development. "People became afraid to cross the village after nightfall," he said.

He didn't mention allegations that he threatened to eliminate the Bhotmange family, once in front of the police, or that Bhaiyyalal blamed him for shielding the culprits. Madhukar Kukde, another man named by Bhaiyyalal, later switched from the BJP to the NCP and became an MP.

On the other side are the Dalits, swallowing everyday indignities — dung smeared on their posters, wedding matches refused when the village name is mentioned, no response to their requests.

Rajan Gajbiye runs a bar near Khairlanji but never steps into the village, preferring a two-hour daily commute. He said old fears surface whenever the convicted men are released on parole.

"I live in fear that someone will harm us. Sometimes they come to my bar. If I see them, to avoid any confrontation, I have my workers get me out of there," he said. He has applied for a personal firearm licence.

Key eyewitness Mukesh Pusam did not leave Khairlanji, living instead with armed security for four years. For him and the Gajbiye family, years blur their memory of the Bhotmanges — the parents toiling in the field, the boys running, the girl on her bicycle, her dupatta in the wind. "We do not take part in their festivals. They do not take part in ours," said Pusam. "There is a wall in the village now."

MY BENGALURU

Bulk Form 7 applications spur fears of voter deletion in state

Yohan P Honaddi

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BIDAR: The controversy over Karnataka's Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls has widened beyond allegations of individual errors, with voters in Bhalki, Vijayapura and Belagavi alleging that large numbers of Form 7 applications were filed to seek deletion of names, including those of Muslim electors.

In Bhalki Assembly constituency in Bidar district, more than 500 such applications were filed across polling stations 51, 52, 53 and 54 in Nittur (B), according to information obtained by Hindustan Times. Booths 52 and 53 have a sizeable Muslim electorate. More than 1,000 Muslim voters are also facing objections at polling stations 129, 107, 111, 112, 114 and 115 in Bhalki town.

The residents say the applications contain their voter details but were filed by people who do not live in the village. They allege that voters who have lived in Nittur for decades were described as having permanently shifted or being absent.

The allegations have acquired political significance because the affected voters say the objections were concentrated among Muslims. However, there is no established finding that the applications were part of a coordinated political operation. Officials have said a Form 7 application does not automatically result in deletion and that every case must undergo field verification and due process.

Mukhtar Bidre, a Nittur resident, said residents began checking the applications after learning about them on September 21. "The forms contain voters' names and EPIC numbers along with applicant names, mobile numbers and signatures, but no date of submission. When we call the mobile numbers mentioned, they are found to be from Mysuru and Bengaluru areas. There appears to be an attempt to create fake documents and deprive us of our voting rights," he said.

Residents identified Pramod Kumar Biradar, Pandurang Sharanappa and Chandrakant Baburao as applicants, alleging that each had submitted between 50 and 100 applications in a day. They said the affected voters had Aadhaar cards, old voter IDs, ration cards and other documents establishing that they continued to live in the village.

For elderly voters, the prospect of losing their names from the roll has added a personal dimension to the dispute. "I am around 70 years old. I have been casting my vote here for nearly fifty years. Now we have been told someone has filled forms to get our votes deleted. No one else's votes have been deleted, why target only us Muslims? I cannot read or write. They are making us feel as though we have no rights. Please don't delete our votes," said Akbar Bi.

Mansoor Bidre, Jabbar Shaikh and Razia Bi said their address

OFFICIALS HAVE SAID A FORM 7 APPLICATION DOES NOT AUTOMATICALLY RESULT IN DELETION AND EVERY CASE MUST UNDERGO FIELD VERIFICATION AND DUE PROCESS

and identity documents contradicted the claims made in the applications. "Our old voter ID, Aadhaar and address documents are all from this village. People who have nothing to do with us have submitted applications claiming we shifted. It should be revealed who did this and why," they said.

The issue reached election and revenue officials on Saturday, when hundreds of Muslim voters gathered at the Nittur (B) Gram Panchayat office during a Praja Seva Andolana programme. They questioned Grade-II Tahsildar Pallavi Belakere, Shirastedar Gopal and other officials about the identity of the applicants and how so many forms had been accepted.

The officials subsequently left the premises after the protesters said their questions had not been adequately answered.

Jagadishwara Biradar, district head of Nagarika Matakavali Samiti, questioned whether sufficient checks had been carried

out before the applications were accepted. "It is the responsibility of the Election Commission to conduct a thorough investigation and make public the facts, including the alleged motive," he said.

Rural development and panchayat raj minister Eshwar B Khandre, who represents Bhalki, said he had received reports of the alleged irregularities and sought a factual report from the district election officer and deputy commissioner.

"It has been reported that fake applications were submitted using mobile numbers from outside the state, allegedly with the intention of deleting names of eligible Muslim voters from the electoral roll in my constituency. If true, it would amount to a serious attempt to deprive eligible citizens of their constitutionally guaranteed right to vote and undermine the integrity of the electoral process," Khandre told HT.

The issue has also surfaced elsewhere during the SIR. In Babaleshwari, large and medium industries minister MB Patil said objections had been filed against 1,607 voters and later withdrawn. He said about 14,000 objections had also been filed and withdrawn in Vijayapura City.

Patil alleged that Muslim voters and people living in slum areas were being targeted. Those claims are political allegations and have not been independently established.

The BJP has rejected allega-

tions of a party organised exercise. Chitradurga MP Govind Karjol said individuals responsible for fraudulent applications should face action, regardless of their affiliation.

"Whoever has behaved in this unreasonable manner has done wrong. But our party did not follow such a practice. It is not the party's position. Whoever commits fraud is wrong, regardless of who they are, and legal action should be taken against them. But our party has nothing to do with this. No one, whoever they may be, is above the Constitution," Karjol said.

In Belagavi North, 382 Form 7 applications were reportedly filed at polling stations 125 and 127 shortly before the deadline. Booth level officers said two unidentified men arrived with bundles of applications and left after being asked for their details.

The men allegedly claimed to be municipal corporation employees. Officials later instructed BLOs not to process the applications immediately. There is no confirmed finding establishing who submitted them or whether they represented a political organisation.

Bidar Tahsildar Ravindra Dama said about 3,606 Form 7 applications had been received across Bidar district between September 23 and September 29. "No voter will be removed solely on the basis of a Form-7 application. Every claim is subject to field verification and due process before any decision is taken," Dama told HT.

Bhima pollution: Yadgir industries face probe

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BIDAR: Karnataka government ordered an inspection of industries in Yadgir's Kadechur-Badiyal industrial area after villagers alleged untreated industrial wastewater was being discharged into open drains and was reaching the Bhima river.

Forest minister Ramalinga Reddy has directed Karnataka State Pollution Control Board to inspect the units, collect wastewater samples and send them for testing. He has also sought an inquiry into whether officials responsible for monitoring the industries failed in their duties.

The complaints concern an industrial area where more than 50 companies are reportedly operating. Villagers allege wastewater from chemical and pharmaceutical units is affecting crops, animals and water sources in surrounding villages.

Sabanna Basavantpur, a resident, told HT improper waste disposal since last week already damaged crops and harmed animals. "If the issue continues, we will face further losses," he said. He also warned of a protest outside deputy commissioner's office if action was not taken.

Jagadish N Dasanakeri, taluk president of Madiga Dandora, alleged untreated wastewater from chemical units was entering Bhima river. He expressed concern about the impact and

possibility of disease spreading through contaminated water.

The complaints have raised concerns among residents about the effect of industrial discharge on agriculture and local water supply. Villagers have sought a comprehensive inspection of the industrial units, scientific analysis of wastewater samples and action against companies found violating environmental rules.

The state has now asked the Pollution Control Board to establish whether the allegations are supported by evidence. Reddy said industries found violating environmental regulations should face legal action. He also directed officials to examine whether monitoring agencies failed to perform their responsibilities. A compliance report has also been sought.

Yadgir deputy commissioner Pandve Rahul Tukaram said the district administration already acted on a complaint received on September 14. "A complaint has been registered, and a temporary injunction order has been issued under the BNS," he told HT. He said action had been initiated against two companies. The administration has begun gathering evidence and sought information and records from PCB.

The inquiry will determine whether wastewater from units entered drains and Bhima river and if companies complied with requirements for treating industrial effluent before discharge.

K'taka reserves future road corridors around Bengaluru

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BENGALURU: Karnataka is reserving land for hundreds of future roads around Bengaluru before homes, apartments and layouts fill up the same space, in an attempt to avoid a problem that the city is already struggling with: roads that cannot be widened because there is no land left. The roads will not be built immediately. Some could take five, eight or even 10 years to materialise. The aim is to keep the identified corridors free of new construction so they remain available when the surrounding areas become more urbanised.

Bengaluru urban development minister Krishna Byre Gowda said on Tuesday that new comprehensive development plans had been notified across Bengaluru Urban district outside Greater Bengaluru Authority, identifying road corridors with proposed widths of 30 metres, 45 metres and 90 metres.

"Some may come up after five years, eight years or even 10 years. What we are doing now is reserving the road corridors so that buildings, apartments and layouts do not come up on land that will be needed for roads in the future," Gowda said.

The government says the lesson comes from Bengaluru's earlier expansion. About two decades ago, 110 villages and seven



Krishna Byre Gowda

City Municipal Councils were brought into the city, but the infrastructure needed to support that growth was not planned adequately, Gowda said. As those areas developed, roads became difficult or impossible to widen because surrounding land had already been built upon.

"When 110 villages and seven CMCs were brought into Bengaluru around two decades ago, adequate basic infrastructure was not planned. Today, in several already developed areas, we cannot even create or widen roads because there is no space," he said. The new reservation exercise is intended to ensure that the same situation does not develop in the areas now urbanising outside the GBA.

The Bengaluru Metropolitan Region Development Authority and local planning and development authorities are working on the road grid. The BMRDA, Zilla Panchayat and Public Works Department have been asked to

physically mark the corridors and identify stretches that should be developed first.

Gowda said the city itself covers about 750 sq km, while nearly 1,200 sq km around it has already acquired an urban character. Citing expert reports, he said this could increase to about 1,400 sq km and eventually 1,800 sq km.

"We have to plan infrastructure before construction comes up everywhere," he said.

The proposed road network is meant to connect taluk and hobli headquarters, major district roads and state highways with larger transport routes, including Peripheral Ring Road and Satellite Town Ring Road. The network could eventually extend to thousands of kilometres and would be developed in phases.

The government says most of newly identified corridors pass through areas still open. Satellite imagery was used to identify alignments while trying to avoid existing settlements. "Around 90 to 95% of the newly marked stretches are through greenfield or open areas," he said.

For landowners, the reservation does not amount to an immediate acquisition. Agricultural activity and sale of land can continue, but new construction will not be permitted inside the notified road corridors.

Properties that already have approvals will retain their rights.

CM to renew his invite to Vijay for Mekedatu talks

Arun Dev & S Vijay Karthik

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BENGALURU/ CHENNAI: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar has renewed his invitation to the Tamil Nadu government for talks on the Mekedatu project and asked Tamil Nadu to send a delegation to inspect the proposed reservoir site, saying officials who examined the terrain have found that the project was unsuited for irrigation.

The renewed outreach follows CM C Joseph Vijay's proposed visit to Bengaluru in August to discuss the Cauvery water issue and Mekedatu. That visit was deferred, with Shivakumar later offering to host Vijay for a visit to the Cauvery basin.

Speaking to reporters at Karnataka Bhavan in New Delhi after meeting Union ministers, Shivakumar said the Centre had understood Karnataka's position that water from Mekedatu would be used strictly for drinking purposes. "The Union Minister has understood that water from the Mekedatu project will be used strictly for drinking purposes and cannot be used for irrigation. The Tamil Nadu government should also send a delegation to inspect the project site," he said.

He said he would again seek a meeting with Vijay to discuss the project. "A request will be made to the CM of Tamil Nadu to meet and discuss the Mekedatu project," Shivakumar said.

Shivakumar said Karnataka would extend full cooperation if Tamil Nadu sent officials to the site. He said a Central team already inspected the area and alternative land had been identified for forest land that would be submerged by the project.

"Even if a team from Tamil Nadu visits, full cooperation will be extended to them. Officials have also realised that water cannot be misused," he said.

The CM said the issue had also been discussed with Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil, whom he met in New Delhi. The talks covered Mekedatu, Krishna and other water disputes involving Karnataka. "Discussions were held with Union Jal Shakti minister CR Patil regarding Krishna, Mekedatu, and other water disputes of the state. A request was made for the Centre to intervene and support the state's irrigation projects, to which the Minister responded



DK Shivakumar

positively," he said.

Karnataka has submitted a fresh detailed project report for the ₹16,745 crore Mekedatu Balancing Reservoir and Drinking Water Project and has sought an early appraisal by the Central Water Commission. Shivakumar said he had also sought release of funds due to Karnataka.

On Mahadayi project, Shivakumar said the Centre assured Karnataka a joint meeting would be held to discuss water and forest related issues. "They have assured to hold a joint meeting regarding Mahadayi and forest related issues," he said.

He said the Centre had also promised to convene a meeting of the chief ministers of neighbouring states to address issues concerning the Upper Krishna Project. "Additionally, regarding the Upper Krishna Project, they have promised to resolve the issue by calling a meeting of the chief ministers of neighbouring states," he said.

Shivakumar rejected allegations that correspondence relating to Mahadayi project was not being handled properly and said political commitment was required to resolve the issue.

"All those are false. The Union Minister has also made efforts in this regard. Political commitment is necessary for this. A request has been made to hold a separate meeting with the forest department," he said.

He also raised the Upper Bhadra Project issue, saying Centre allocated ₹5,300 crore for it but had not released funds. "Even though central government allocated ₹5,300 crore for Upper Bhadra project in 2023 budget, funds have not been released. We keep asking for it, but they are not releasing it," he said.

Opposition in TN seeks all-party meet after Shivakumar's statement

Former CM and general secretary of All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)

on Tuesday sought CM C Joseph Vijay to immediately convene an all party meeting after Shivakumar said that an expert team has inspected the proposed Mekedatu site.

"Was he afraid to face his counterpart in Karnataka?" Palaniswami said in a party statement here on Tuesday.

Shivakumar's statement that a central team visited and inspected the site were the dam across river Cauvery is expected to come up, Palaniswami said, "It is strongly condemnable." He slammed Vijay for not issuing any comment on Shivakumar's statement and there was also no response from TN government regarding this so far.

"A question has raised among the public whether the TN government was colluding with Karnataka (on the issue)," he said.

Palaniswami flayed Shivakumar over his meeting with Patil to seek his approval for the construction of the dam also raises 'serious suspicions'.

Hitting out at Vijay, Palaniswami asked, "does the CM not know the constitutional law that no new dam can be constructed without receiving the consent of Tamil Nadu and Puducherry?" "We strongly condemn the TN government and the CM of reels for betraying Tamil Nadu farmers", Palaniswami said.

Meanwhile, the state secretary of CPI(M) P Shanmugam expressed "deep shock" over the meeting of Shivakumar with Patil and urged the Union BJP government that under no circumstances it grants permission to Karnataka government to construct the dam at Mekedatu.

"Karnataka government never released TN's due monthly share of water based on the tribunal award and the final verdict of the Supreme Court," Shanmugam said on Tuesday. "Under these circumstances, if the Mekedatu dam is constructed, the Cauvery Delta region will turn into a desert due to the lack of Tamil Nadu's rightful water supply. This will create a dire situation where TN faces immense hardship from both drinking and irrigation needs," he said, adding, "TN government must immediately convene a meeting of all political party leaders and farmers' association representatives."

Hindustan Times reached out to the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam for their comments but did not receive a response.

Cane growers protest for better price



Karnataka's sugarcane growers conducted a protest march towards Union minister Pralhad Joshi's residence, demanding a higher fair and remunerative price, in Hubballi on Tuesday. Joshi has appealed to the protestors to come to Delhi for discussions, saying there was no need to stage protests on streets and assuring them the Centre was ready to hear their grievances.

CM hits back at Kumaraswamy over charges of gaps in BMICP

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU/NEW DELHI: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday rejected allegations of large-scale irregularities in the Bengaluru-Mysuru Infrastructure Corridor Project (BMICP) levelled by Union minister HD Kumaraswamy, calling them a "pack of lies".

Speaking to reporters in Delhi, Shivakumar asked why Kumaraswamy, a former chief minister, had kept quiet on the issue for so long.

He pointed out that Kumaraswamy's father, former prime minister HD Deve Gowda, had signed the project. "Poor man, he is desperate as he is under pressure from the BJP," Shivakumar said.

At a press conference in Bengaluru earlier, Kumaraswamy demanded Shivakumar's resignation, alleging that during his tenure as the state urban development minister, he approved deviations in the BMICP without the Cabinet's approval.

Nandi Infrastructure Corridor Enterprises Ltd (NICE) was responsible for implementing the project.

Shivakumar said he owned assets worth ₹1,400 crore at current valuations, all acquired within the legal framework. "Kumaraswamy is speaking out of desperation," he said.

The chief minister said Kumaraswamy was frustrated by the alleged rift in the BJP-JD(S) alliance and the "one-upmanship" within it.

"Furthermore, he personally facilitated the awarding of a tender to an individual named Gandhi, a move for which the court had reprimanded him. Numerous transactions took place under benami names. Unlike him, I will not go around naming specific individuals," Shivakumar said.

"Is Kumaraswamy an Income Tax officer?" Shivakumar asked.

"As a farmer's son and a businessman, shouldn't I own assets? Shouldn't my children be able to purchase property? I have built my wealth within the

scope of the law. Let them provide the information to the Income Tax Department," he said.

He also asked, "Don't they own assets within the BMICP and NICE road projects? How did their assets end up within the scope of the Bidadi Township project?"

Asked about the allegation that a ₹5 crore investment in Sobha Developers had grown into ₹2,000 crore, Shivakumar said, "Yes, we can generate any amount of wealth. Did I take a bribe? Was I involved in any scandal? None of that happened, did it? I haven't acquired anything through theft. I have already declared my assets."

On his own property, he said the late former CM S Bangarappa had allotted him a plot for which he paid ₹99,000, and that it was now worth ₹20 crore.

"The value of my property has appreciated, and I have declared it. What is wrong with that? I own hundreds of such properties," he said.

Union min alleges major deviations in NICE project

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NEW DELHI: Union minister HD Kumaraswamy on Tuesday intensified his attack on Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar over the long-running Bengaluru-Mysuru Infrastructure Corridor Project (BMICP), alleging that the original project framework was subsequently altered to expand the land requirement for the road and facilitate the interests of private parties.

"The question is not who signed the first Memorandum of Understanding (MoU). The question is how the project was subsequently changed and who authorised those changes," the union minister said, alleging that the project originally began with an agreement involving VHB, the Kalyani Group and SA Engineering and Construction, before NICE (Nandi Infrastructure Corridor Enterprise Limited) subsequently entered the picture.

The BMIC is a planned 111-kilometre expressway project in Karnataka and as per Kumaraswamy, the MoU for the project was signed in 1995.

He said that in 1997, a Frame-

work Agreement was signed giving 20,193 acres of land for the corridor.

"People keep saying, 'Deve Gowda signed it, Deve Gowda started it.' Yes, Deve Gowda signed the MoU. But that does not mean every subsequent decision taken 10 years later can be attributed to him," Kumaraswamy said.

He said that the project subsequently underwent several changes, including after the NICE entered into an agreement with the Karnataka Industrial Areas Development Board in 1998.

He questioned whether modifications to the Cabinet-approved Framework Agreement could have been made without fresh Cabinet approval.

"If the earlier Framework Agreement was approved by the Cabinet, how can you alter it without going back to the Cabinet? That is the question I am asking," he said.

The Union minister also flagged the Outline Development Plan (ODP) prepared in the early 2000s, alleging that it substantially deviated from the original framework.



HD Kumaraswamy

He said the land earmarked for the toll road increased from 6,999 acres under the original agreement to 9,468.86 acres under the revised plan.

"The Cabinet had already approved the original Framework Agreement. Who gave you the authority to make changes beyond the Cabinet's decision?" Kumaraswamy asked, further alleging, "He [Shivakumar] became the chairman of BMICPA. After that, the ODP came. This is where the deviations began."

He alleged that an additional

2,747 acres had been brought into the project and changes were made in the acreage allotted to individual townships, claiming that land was increased in some locations and reduced in others.

"The doctor treats the disease, but along with that he removes the kidney and liver. That is what has happened here," Kumaraswamy said, alleging that the alterations in the project could affect lakes, temples, cremation grounds and other public spaces in the region.

Referring to a 2007 Cabinet decision taken during his tenure as chief minister, Kumaraswamy said he had restricted NICE to the 20,193 acres provided for under the original Framework Agreement.

"The decision I took was very clear: follow the Framework Agreement. Do not take even an inch of land beyond what was approved," he said.

He accused Shivakumar and NICE promoter Ashok Kheny of working together to facilitate private benefit from the 2002 tripartite agreement involving NICE, NHAI (National Highway Authority of India) and the Kar-

nataka government— which introduced provisions for sale or alienation of the project.

"Who changed the Framework Agreement? DK [Shivakumar] and AK [Kheny]. Who changed the alignment? DK and AK. Who changed the location of the township? DK and AK," Kumaraswamy said, alleging that the Framework Agreement was altered by the ODP under Shivakumar's orders.

"This is bigger than 2G and coal scams," the minister claimed.

Kumaraswamy questioned the need to continue the NICE project towards Mysuru, given the existing Bengaluru-Mysuru national highway.

He further said the affected farmers should be treated as rightful owners of the land and should be adequately compensated.

"Mr. Shivakumar, If you do not have the strength to correct what has happened in this project, resign and step out," said Kumaraswamy.

He added that he would release more documents in his ongoing campaign against the project.

168k voters found ineligible for inclusion in Andhra final rolls

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HYDERABAD: Around 168,000 voters registered in the current electoral rolls in Andhra Pradesh have been “found ineligible” for inclusion in the final rolls after the special intensive revision, officials said on Tuesday.

The period for disposal of claims and objections ended on Monday. The Election Commission of India subsequently declared that it completed hearings on 99.96% notices served to voters after the draft rolls were released on July 31.

An EC official explained that “ineligible” voters included those who failed to furnish documents for their verification or did not appear for the hearing in person

or through a family member.

“Out of 44.28 lakh (4.428 million) notices delivered, hearing with regard to 44.27 lakh (4.427 million) notices was completed as on September 28, the last date for disposal of claims and objections, accounting for 99.96% notices. Only 1,665 electors did not respond to the notices,” a statement from chief electoral officer Vivek Yadav said.

The statement added that around 168,821 voters in the current electoral list were found ineligible for inclusion in the final electoral roll, which will be published on October 3.

Ananthapuram district accounts for the most ineligible voters with 23,154 names likely to be dropped from the district, followed by 20,938 in Tirupati, 19,067 in Palnadu, 12,780 in NTR,



CEO Vivek Yadav

12,179 in Annamayya, 11,266 in Sri Satya Sai, 9,144 in YSR Kadapa and 8,390 voters in Nellore. Only 133 ineligible voters were found in Alluri Sitarama Raju district.

A total of 69,184 applications for inclusion through Form-6 and another 31,693 applications for address changes were pending clearance, said the EC official

quoted above, adding, ““These applications will be considered even after the publication of the final electoral roll, provided they furnish all the relevant documents.”

SIR yet to pick up pace in Telangana: Officials

In Telangana, the SIR exercise is yet to pick up pace due to many getting notices on account of logical discrepancies and lack of mapping with the 2002 electoral list, said officials aware of the matter.

Telangana chief electoral officer C Sudharshan Reddy said notices were generated for 92,88,180 voters out of the total 33.8 million voters, after the publication of draft electoral rolls on August 16. The last date for filing of claims and objec-

tions is October 7, while the deadline for disposal of these claims and objections is November 5.

A statement from the CEO on Tuesday said out of 9,288 million notices generated, 8,852,173 notices flagging logical discrepancies and lack of mapping were delivered so far to voters. Another 4,36,007 voters are yet to be served notices.

“So far, hearings were held with regard to notices served on 61,87,444 people and of them, 48,88,076 voters were found eligible for the publication of the final electoral roll till now. Another 12,99,368 cases are still under verification under the district electoral officers’ purview,” the statement added.

CCB SEARCHES 5 LOCATIONS LINKED TO EX-MINISTER IN FRAUD CASE

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CHENNAI: The Central Crime Branch on Tuesday searched five locations across Tamil Nadu linked to aides of former minister and DMK leader Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi as part of a probe into alleged fraud worth ₹100 crore in granting government recognition to private schools, police said.

The locations searched were linked to key accused B T Araskumar, relatives of another accused Muthukumar (who is absconding) and assistants of Poyyamozhi. 44 documents and one laptop were retrieved, police said.

Police had conducted similar searches in properties linked Poyyamozhi, his assistants Valadi Karthik, Arun Prakash, Prakash on September 16 in Tiruchirappalli and Chennai. Poyyamozhi was later summoned in Chennai on September 18.

{ CMRL-EXALOGIC CASE }

HC reserves order on plea seeking FIR

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala high court on Tuesday reserved its order on a plea seeking registration of an FIR under the Prevention of Corruption Act against Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and CPI(M) MLA PA Mohammed Riyas in the CMRL monthly payoffs case.

The plea, filed by activist-lawyer KM Shajahan, also sought directions to the State government to hand over the current Crime Branch probe to the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB).

The petitioner challenged the move of the state government to order a preliminary inquiry by the Crime Branch into allegations of bribery and corruption before registering an FIR. The state’s move was propelled by the communication sent by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to the state director general of police recommending a corruption case against Vijayan and others based on the “evidence” it collected of the former chief minister receiving kickbacks from Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL), a Kochi-based minerals manufacturer, through his daughter Veena T and the now-defunct IT firm Exalogic Solutions she ran. ED has alleged that Vijayan received bribes amounting to ₹3.28 crore from the private firm in exchange for favours to the company in the minerals sector. The agency claimed that the funds were routed abroad through ‘hawala channels’ with the help of Riyas, who is married to Veena.



Pinarayi Vijayan

The allegations are linked to the CMRL monthly payments case in which Veena and her firm Exalogic purportedly received money to the tune of Rs 2.78 crore from CMRL even though no services were rendered by the IT firm. The Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) has also probed the case and filed a preliminary report in a court in Ernakulam district, arraigning Veena and top officials of CMRL in the case.

During the hearing, the ED handed over the communication it sent to the DGP in a sealed cover to the court.

At the same time, Attorney General Jaju Babu, appearing for the State, argued that the petitioner had no locus standi and that the writ plea was premature. He also told the court that the ED’s disclosure does not exempt the authorities, in this case the state police, to conduct an independent evaluation and decipher whether the information relayed contained a statutory offence.

The bench of justice A Badurhudeen said it will look into the contents of the ED report and analyse the arguments presented by all sides on whether a preliminary inquiry can go on before registering an FIR based on the ED communication.



N Chandrababu Naidu

AP CM CALLS FOR INTEGRATION OF TECHNOLOGY AND ADMINISTRATION

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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday called for integration of technology, leadership and policies for good governance to meet the aspirations of the people.

Inaugurating the southern regional workshop of ‘Mission Karmayogi’ organised by the Capacity Building Commission in Vijayawada, Naidu said there was a need to upgrade the administrative skills of the government through capacity building and innovating by integrating them with universities.

Senior government bureaucrats and employees from Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Odisha and Union Territory Puducherry attended the workshop.

Naidu called for changes in governance systems and institutions to meet the aspirations of people and harness opportunities offered by emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence. “The next 20 years would be crucial for India’s development and urged government employees to continuously upgrade their skills through capacity-building programmes,” he said.

The chief minister said India had immense opportunities, advanced technologies, talented youth and growing aspirations. “The key challenge is to strengthen governance systems and institutions to fulfil these aspirations,” he said.

Naidu said the PM had launched the iGOT—Mission Karmayogi initiative through the Capacity Building Commission to ensure continuous skill development among government employees.

UDF wins 22 of 38 wards, loses 3 seats to LDF in local bypolls

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The ruling Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) won 19 of the 38 local body wards where bypolls were conducted on Monday in Keralam, suffering setbacks at the hands of the rival CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF), both in terms of seats won and margin of votes.

The bypolls were necessitated by the deaths of sitting representatives and the elevation of members as MLAs. The elections were held for two Municipal Corporation wards, three Municipality wards, three District Panchayat divisions, seven Block Panchayat divisions and 23 Grama Panchayat wards across 12 districts. A voter turnout of 58.81% was recorded.

While the UDF held 22 of the 38 wards previously, their tally has dipped to 19. The LDF’s tally rose, meanwhile, from 15 to 18. The NDA retained its sole ward.

One of the biggest setbacks the UDF faced was in Thrikkodan division in Kottayam district panchayat, where it’s

candidate Vijay Jose lost to Manju Sujith of the LDF by over 2100 votes. It was a division that it won in 2025 and fell vacant as the member Vinu Job got elected as MLA from Changanacherry.

The UDF also suffered heavily in Varkala and Chirayankkeezhu block panchayats, losing divisions in both places to the LDF. The two divisions fall under Chirayankkeezhu Assembly constituency where internal divisions within the Congress were reported earlier this month.

The UDF managed to win the Kallara district panchayat division in Thiruvananthapuram, but it’s victory margin fell steeply compared to 2025.

Another defeat came in Paruthikkavu division in Chittur-Thathamangalam municipality where UDF candidate K Madhu lost to LDF candidate V Thulasidharan through lottery as both candidates got equal votes.

As for the LDF, it retained its strongholds in Kannur, Thrissur, Palakkad and Thiruvananthapuram districts. Twenty-20, part of the NDA in Keralam, retained its sole seat in Poothrikka panchayat in Ernakulam district.

STALKER HELD FOR STABBING RESORT RECEPTIONIST TO DEATH IN KERALAM

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A stalker was arrested on Tuesday after he allegedly stabbed a 20-year-old receptionist at a private resort in Keralam’s Pathanamthitta district to death at the resort premises, said police.

The accused was identified as Jithu. Thiruvalla DySP P R Santhosh said, “It’s a heinous crime. We have taken the accused into custody and are conducting a thorough investigation.”

Police said the victim and Jithu were reportedly in a brief relationship, which she ended a month ago. According to the victim’s colleagues, the accused arrived at the resort in Kozhencerry around 1 pm on Tuesday and asked to speak to her. They were conversing under a tree in the resort’s courtyard when a verbal erupted and the accused attacked her with a knife.

A witness told local media, “When we ran to the spot, we found Dilsha lying on the spot with numerous stab injuries. He was sitting under a tree and holding the knife. It was clear that he had come solely to stab her to death. He expressed no remorse.” He added the resort staff and locals tied him up and handed him over to police.

Cops rescue man from suicide bid at Chennai beach

CHENNAI: Police personnel in Chennai on Monday rescued a 25-year-old man from Kerala after he allegedly announced plans to die by suicide late on Monday, officers said.

They said they received a call from the man’s father, who told them about his alleged social media post and subsequently requested them to save him. A team launched a search and found the man in Srinivasapuram beach, where he confessed that he was suffering from mental stress, said officers.

CM Vijay commends Coimbatore cop for his bravery

CHENNAI: Chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Tuesday commended head constable M Velmurugan, who shot to fame recently after a clip shared widely on social media showed his daring actions while trying to arrest a group of alleged gutka smugglers in Coimbatore, at the Secretariat in Chennai. In the clip, Velmurugan was seen clinging to the roof of a white SUV allegedly being driven by the suspects during a 40-kilometre chase that ended when they were arrested.

Pocso: Man sentenced to 20-year jail term

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KOZHICOD: A Pocso court in Keralam on Tuesday sentenced a 64-year-old man to 20 years in prison for sexually assaulting a minor girl at his house near Vadakara in 2023.

Nadapuram Fast Track Special Court Judge Devan K Menon sentenced the convict, identified as Abdul Razak, to terms totalling 25-and-a-half years for various offences

under the IPC and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, special public prosecutor (SPP) Manoj Aroor said.

As the sentences are to run concurrently and the longest term imposed is 20 years, the convict will serve 20 years in prison, Aroor said. The court also imposed a fine of Rs 1.5 lakh on Razak, the SPP said.

According to the prosecution, the incident occurred on October 17, 2023, when Razak

called the nine-year-old girl, who was cycling to a relative’s house, into his home and sexually assaulted her.

No one else was present in the house at the time, the prosecutor said.

When the child returned home, her mother noticed her injuries and took her to a government hospital, following which she lodged a complaint with the police.

However, before the police could take action, an angry

mob reached the accused’s house and assaulted him, the prosecutor said. Razak’s wife subsequently filed a case in connection with the mob attack, naming more than 18 residents as accused, he said.

The accused, who was injured in the attack, was taken into custody by the police the same day. The prosecution produced 23 documents and examined 18 witnesses during the trial to establish the accused’s guilt, the SPP said.

{ TELANGANA }

Cong shortlists names for polls to 2 LC seats

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HYDERABAD: The Congress’ Telangana unit has shortlisted candidates for the upcoming elections to the two seats in the state legislative council under graduates’ quota and sent them to the party high command for approval, party workers familiar with the matter said on Tuesday.

The Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) proposed three names each for the MLC seats from the graduates’ constituencies: Mahabubnagar-Rangareddy-Hyderabad and Warangal-Khammam-Nal-

gonda, taking into account social and regional considerations, a senior PCC leader told reporters.

The two seats, which are going to fall vacant in March, are currently held by Chintapandu Naveen alias Teenmaar Malanna, who was elected on the Congress ticket but suspended later for revolting against the party; and Bharat Rashtira Samithi MLC Surabhi Vani Devi, daughter of former PM PV Narasimha Rao.

The elections to the two seats are likely to be held in February and the Election Commission of India has already commenced the exercise of enrolment of

graduate voters, which will be completed by December 30.

According to the Congress functionary quoted above, for the Mahabubnagar-Rangareddy-Hyderabad constituency, the names proposed are former MLAs Sampath Kumar and senior leaders Sama Ramamohan Reddy and Gouri Satish.

“While Sampath Kumar is an SC candidate, Gouri Satish is an OBC and Ramamohan Reddy is an OC candidate,” the party leader said.

For the Warangal-Khammam-Nalgonda constituency, the PCC shortlisted P V Srinivas, the current RTI Commissioner;

Sarvotham Reddy of Suryapet; and PCC spokesperson Changanani Dayakar Goud of Osmania University. “While Srinivas and Sarvotham Reddy are from OC category, Dayakar Goud is from OBC,” he said.

He said the PCC forwarded these six names to the AICC leadership, including Congress general secretary K C Venugopal, for a final decision.

“Before the high command announces the candidates, PCC president B Mahesh Kumar Goud is expected to meet the aspirants and seek their cooperation with whoever is ultimately selected,” he added.



Fisherfolk living along the coast at Foreshore Estate stage a protest in Chennai on Tuesday. HT PHOTO

Fisherfolk stage stir against TN’s proposed assembly-secretariat

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CHENNAI: Fisherfolk living along the Foreshore Estate staged a protest in Chennai on Tuesday against the state government’s proposal to build a new Assembly and Secretariat complex in the area.

Some protesters were clad in black and carried black flags as they raised slogans against the proposal. They also warned that they would intensify their protest if the government failed to withdraw the proposal.

A member of the Tamil Nadu Fishermen Federation, GR Vijayan listed the protestors’ demands. “The government order issued on September 8 announcing government plans to construct Assembly and Secretariat must be cancelled,” he said.

“The land that the Metro City Improvement Trust gave to the fishermen must be officially granted to us, along with the issuance of land titles (patta). Many houses of the fishermen

THE PROTESTORS WARNED THAT THEY WOULD UNITE FISHING VILLAGES ACROSS THE STATE IF GOVT FAILED TO ACCEPT THEIR DEMANDS

are severely dilapidated, we are bringing it to the chief minister’s attention to immediately construct and provide houses for us on a war footing,” he added.

“If the chief minister does not cancel this G.O within the next 5 days, we will unite all fishing villages across Tamil Nadu and organize a massive protest,” warned Vijayan.

Making a suo motu statement in the assembly on September 3, chief minister C Joseph Vijay said the government would establish a new Assembly-cum-Secretariat complex in Chennai at a cost of ₹1,200 crore, with a built-up area of 20 lakh sq ft.

The complex would house all state government departments. The proposal came amid space constraints at Fort St George and limitations arising from its historical preservation. Built in 1640, the campus spans 107 acres, but the government owns only four acres; the rest belongs to the defence authorities and Archaeological Survey of India.

To drum up support to their protest, a delegation of fisherfolk recently met former chief minister and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) president MK Stalin who assured them of the party’s support. Stalin warned that the DMK would also join the demonstrations if the government failed to pay heed to the fisherfolk’s demands.

Meanwhile, state law minister CTR Nirmal Kumar said that government was examining alternative sites for the proposed complex. On September 25, he had clarified that the government has not taken any decision that would be ‘anti-people or against the interests of the fishermen communities’.

{ VEERAMANI POCSO CASE }

DMK moves HC to direct SIT to quiz ministers

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BENGALURU: The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Tuesday moved the Madras high court seeking a direction to the special investigation team (SIT) probing the Pocso case against granite baron R Veeramani to summon CM C Joseph Vijay and ministers Aadhav Arjuna and C T R Nirmal Kumar for inquiry.

In its plea filed through party treasurer and MP TR Baalu, the DMK urged the Court to ask the SIT to summon the chief minister and the two TVK ministers to “obtain any evidence in their possession.” The petitioner referred to the respondents’ public allegations that the previous DMK regime had protected Veeramani and claimed to have material evidence to support the allegations. He said if they had information or evidence connected with the case, they were required to place it before the SIT.

The petition said the Commis-



TN law minister CTR Nirmal Kumar, CM C Joseph Vijay and public works minister Aadhav Arjuna



sioner of Police had also issued a public appeal asking anyone with information about the case to furnish it to the investigating agency. In these circumstances, Baalu said, the SIT had a duty to summon the CM and ministers and obtain the material forming the basis of their public statements.

“The source of the information forming the basis of the statements made by the aforesaid persons and whether they had access to any investigation-related material which was not legitimately to be made available to them” also required examination, the plea said.

The petition added the failure to share material evidence with investigators would amount to concealment of material evidence. He also questioned how the three individuals could have access to probe-related material, if their statements were based on such material. Baalu also said he had submitted a representation to the Additional Commissioner of Police heading the SIT, seeking that CM Vijay, Arjuna and Nirmal Kumar be summoned and that all materials, documents, records and information in their possession relating to the case be secured.

The petition claimed the

request was not based on political disagreement but concerned the integrity of the ongoing criminal investigation. Baalu said the public statements could not be treated merely as political statements since they concerned an ongoing investigation into alleged offences against children.

Veeramani and two others were arrested on August 28 in connection with allegations of sexual assault of minor girls. Police had said they registered the case after receiving a USB drive from the Intelligence and Technology Police Unit containing video clips that allegedly

showed Veeramani sexually assaulting juvenile girls.

The police had also said their investigation revealed that Veeramani had rented a house in Teynampet, where he allegedly lured and sexually assaulted the victims. The two caretakers of the house, Mahendra Simhan and his wife Shanti, were also arrested. The state government constituted an SIT on September 25 to investigate the case.

The team comprises Additional Commissioner of Police, Central Crime Branch, P C Thenmozhi, Joint Commissioner of Police, Law and Order, Disha Mittal, Superintendent of Police and Media Relations Officer in the office of the DGP, J Mutharasi, and Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime Against Women and Children, V V Geethanjali. The SIT will function under the supervision of the Commissioner of Police, Greater Chennai Police, the state had told the Madras High Court last week. The present plea is yet to be taken up for hearing.

Halt SIR, restore 130mn deleted voters: Congress

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NEW DELHI: The Congress Working Committee (CWC) demanded restoration of 130 million deleted voters in the electoral rolls and a halt to the special intensive revision (SIR). It also called for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's resignation.

After a CWC meeting on Tuesday, general secretary KC Venugopal announced a massive agitation at state, district and booth levels, in coordination with INDIA-bloc allies, and said the party would reach out to all voters who have had their names struck off the list. The CWC meeting saw the Congress shift its strategy from attacking Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar alone to holding the Prime Minister responsible for the "fraud exercise to destroy democracy of the country."

"This is not the game of Gyanesh Kumar. He is only a tool. Whenever dictators lose the confidence of common voters, they will try to find special ways to stay in power. This exercise (SIR) could not happen without the concurrence of Modi and Amit Shah. It was done under clear directions of Gyanesh Kumar's masters. The PM should have intervened and stopped this. PM should resign as it was his moral responsibility to stop this exercise," Venugopal said.

To be sure, HT's analysis of SIR deletions by constituency has shown no correlation with the outcome; and some of the deletions have been caused by death and migration. But the exclusion of millions of voters from draft rolls—in Delhi, 33% of the UT's 14.5 million voters were excluded—has resulted in public anger and anxiety. Revelations by the Indian Express last week that two election commissioners disagreed with some of the decisions, and that the central database of electors wasn't accessible to on-ground officers



AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge, Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi, Congress chairperson Sonia Gandhi, and AICC general secretary KC Venugopal during the CWC meeting on Tuesday. ANI

tasked with adding and deleting names have caused a stir. The Election Commission has since clarified that all decisions have been unanimous, based on the majority, and also modified the SIR process to reduce the inconvenience to voters.

The Congress has consistently opposed SIR and sought to present it as a way to fix the mandate; on Tuesday, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi sought to compare the party's fight against the exercise to the freedom movement. He referred to the Congress session in Lahore in 1929 when the party adopted the goals of Purna Swaraj or complete independence. He also reminded the CWC that the party's strategy is to both oppose and resist.

Chairing the meeting, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge demanded that complete data regarding every major change made to the electoral rolls must be made public and "independent and time-bound inquiries must be conducted wherever evidence of serious discrepancies emerges."

Kharge also sought that voters whose names have been removed must be fully informed and given an opportunity to appeal and that political parties must be provided with the electoral rolls and relevant data in a simple format and in a timely

manner. Seeking more transparency, Kharge also demanded transparency in the critical data and decisions related to the election process so that no party has grounds to claim that information is being withheld.

The SIR process does involve booth level agents of political parties, with whom data on the deletions in the draft roll is shared.

In his opening speech, Kharge launched a vitriolic attack against both Prime Minister Modi and CEC Kumar, calling him a "puppet" of the ruling dispensation. "History bears witness that ten years ago, this very Prime Minister devastated India's economy with the decision of 'demonetisation.' And now, ten years later, he is destroying our robust democracy through a conspiracy of 'vote-demonetisation' (disenfranchisement)," Kharge said. His reference was to the 2016 decision by the Modi government to invalidate high value currency notes in a bid to tackle unaccounted wealth (or black money).

"The poor bear the brunt of all his flawed policies... I know that the poor possess only one source of power: their vote. We will not let that be snatched away under any circumstances," the Congress president said, arguing that vote is the greatest weapon for the poor, Dalits and deprived.

NITISH PACT A MISSED CHANCE, SAYS DIGVIJAYA, SPARKS DEBATE

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NEW DELHI: Senior Congress leader Digvijaya Singh's remark that the party missed an opportunity to align with Nitish Kumar's Janata Dal (United) [JD(U)] in the 2025 Bihar election sparked a debate with both Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and general secretary KC Venugopal denying Kumar was ever interested in a pact with the Congress.

Singh did a SWOT analysis of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to claim that the ruling dispensation is on the backfoot. He, however, said that in the past, BJP managed to align with the JD(U) and the Congress failed to retain its alliance with Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and JD(U).

According to two Congress Working Committee (CWC) members, Gandhi told all the CWC members that when he raised the matter of "vote chori" (vote theft), most Congress leaders did not believe it was a big issue but now the majority of the leaders are in agreement and the special intensive revision (SIR) has become the biggest issue for the Opposition.

Later, he narrated how he had objected to selection of candidates in front of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Referring to a meeting to select a constitutional functionary, Gandhi said he reminded Modi that despite his objections, the PM is going ahead with the selection. "Modi said he was not doing anything new. The late Prime Minister Indira Gandhi also did the same. I told him, she lost an election (1977), to which Modi told me, 'When we go, you will come'," Gandhi told the CWC, according to three CWC members.

{ XINJIANG OPTION }

India explores China route to bypass Pak airspace ban

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NEW DELHI: India is exploring an alternative air route over China's Xinjiang to reduce the impact of the continued closure of Pakistani airspace, civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu said on Tuesday.

He was speaking at the curtain-raiser for Routes Asia 2027, the route development event for the Asia Pacific, which India will host next March.

"We are looking at other alternatives. Discussions on the Hotan route are going on between the two countries. Our external affairs ministry is engaging with their country [China], let us see how it goes, but we are trying alternatives," Naidu said.

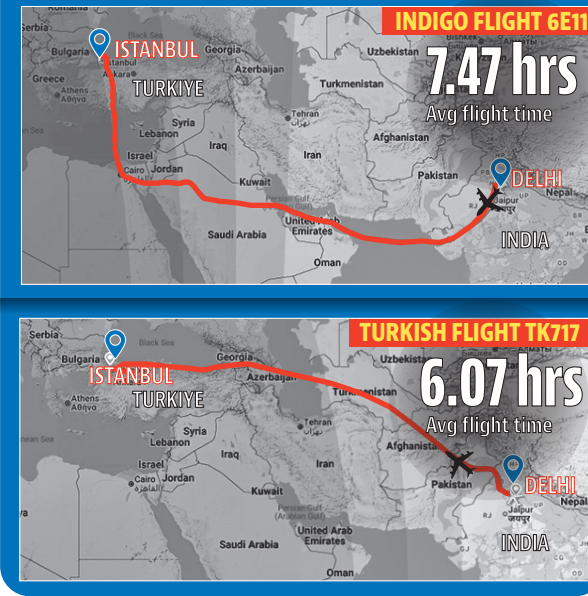
Naidu did not indicate a timeline for the route's opening, nor did he suggest that an agreement had been reached with China.

Pakistan closed its airspace to Indian airlines after the Pahalgalam terror attack in April 2025, and its latest notice extends the closure to October 24. Since then, Indian airlines flying to Europe and North America from northern and western India have had to detour over the Arabian Sea towards Muscat. The detour adds between 45 minutes and two hours of flying time, and has driven up fuel burn and operating costs on several sectors.

"All Indian carriers from the

How closures hurt Indian airlines

Two flights on same route shows India's IndiGo flying an extra 1 hour 40 minutes because of the detour it has to take avoid Pakistani airspace



north and north west are following the L639 route to avoid the Pakistani airspace... which increases their flying time by 2 hours," a person aware of the matter said. L639 is one of the designated airways that carry the detour over the Arabian Sea.

The Delhi-Istanbul sector

shows how arduous the detour is. IndiGo's 6E-11 is scheduled to take 8 hours 39 minutes, according to flight-tracking data. Turkish Airlines' TK717, which is not covered by the Pakistani ban, is scheduled at 6 hours 45 minutes, almost two hours less.

Naidu said the proposed corri-

dor over Hotan, in southwestern Xinjiang, would offer a significantly shorter route.

If the discussions pan out, Indian airlines flying from Delhi and Mumbai would head towards Leh, enter Chinese airspace near Hotan, turn towards Kyrgyzstan, and then connect to existing routes to Europe, the UK and North America. "The route may lead to significant savings for destinations like Georgia, Baku, Central Asia, and northern Europe," the second person said.

The corridor would also take Indian aircraft into difficult and sensitive airspace. Reuters reported in November 2025 that the airspace falls within the Chinese People's Liberation Army's Western Theatre Command, whose responsibilities include responding to any conflict with India. The region is ringed by mountains as high as 20,000 feet (6,100m). International airlines generally avoid it, the report said, because an aircraft that loses cabin pressure must descend quickly to lower altitude, and there are few emergency airports to divert to. No non-Chinese airline had used Hotan airport in the previous 12 months, according to the report.

The detour has proved particularly costly for Air India, which relies heavily on western long-haul routes out of its Delhi and Mumbai hubs.

MAHA TO RECRUIT FORMER AGNIVEERS INTO UNIFORMED SERVICES: FADNAVIS

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MUMBAI: Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis on Tuesday said his government will induct former Agniveers into uniformed services like police, fire brigade and coastal security after they complete their four-year military tenure.

Of the first batch of Agniveers completing their tenure, 2,496 are from Maharashtra.

The state cabinet approved the policy on Tuesday, including 10% parallel reservation for Maharashtra-domiciled former Agniveers. "We have decided to provide employment opportunities to Agniveers after completion of their four-year service, with priority in various state government services," Fadnavis said.

Under the 2022 Agnipath scheme, the Centre will retain 25% of Agniveers in the armed forces, while the remaining 75% will be released from service. Former Agniveers would not be required to appear for another recruitment examination or undergo fresh training, said the CM, who also holds the Home portfolio.

"The government plans to utilise their military experience by absorbing them into services such as the police, fire brigade and coastal security," Fadnavis said.

Navy must sharpen capabilities to deal with challenges: Rajnath

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NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Tuesday said deception and grey-zone activities have made the maritime domain more complex than ever, necessitating the Indian Navy to sharpen its surveillance and response mechanism in the Indian Ocean Region.

"India stands firm as the first responder, preferred security partner and as a symbol of trust and reliability in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) and the entire world is witnessing the growth of both our strategic position and our strategic responsibility in the region. Today, issues such as congestion, deception, and grey-zone activities have made our maritime domain far more complex than ever before. Hence, we must elevate our monitoring and response mechanisms to a new level," he said at the Navy's biannual commanders' conference.

The concept of grey-zone warfare refers to employing aggression and other actions to achieve national objectives below the threshold of armed conflict, creating ambiguity. His comments come as China attempts to strengthen its hold over the IOR, a strategic maritime expanse where challenges include Beijing's carefully calculated power play for influence and defending



Defence minister Rajnath Singh and Chief of Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan during the Indian Navy Commanders' Conference at Nausena Bhawan in New Delhi. @RAJNATHSINGH

the rules-based international order.

The navy's role is crucial in ensuring strategic depth and regional power projection, he added.

Singh touched upon the government's focus on the navy's modernisation. "The Indian Navy serves as a strategic anchor in the vision of 'Viksit Bharat 2047'. Beyond merely guarding maritime boundaries, our navy strengthens economic protection, regional stability, and power projection," Singh said.

Meanwhile, the defence ministry in a post on X, said, "At the

@indiannavy Commanders' Conference, Raksha Mantri Shri @rajnathsingh stated that the #IndianNavy is acting as a strategic anchor in realizing the resolve of '#ViksitBharat2047'. Amidst challenges arising from evolving technology, unpredictability, and geographical proximity, we must move beyond 'business as usual' and make geo-strategic thinking and contingency planning integral parts of our preparedness. Our goal is clear, our preparedness must reach the crisis point before the crisis itself reaches our doorstep."

BJP chief chairs meet of state in-charges

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NEW DELHI: Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) president Nitin Nabin on Tuesday chaired a meeting of the party's state in-charges and co-in-charges in New Delhi to draw up plans for the upcoming assembly elections in five states next year and oversee other organisational issues, people familiar with the matter said.

The meeting comes at a time when the party is facing multiple challenges from student protests to the opposition accusing the government of electoral irregularities. The BJP-led Union government has come under sharp attack from the Opposition, which has accused it of influencing the Election Commission of India (ECI) following reports that there was disaggree-



Nitin Nabin

ment in the poll panel over the conduct of special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

According to a person aware of the details, the party chief asked the office bearers to spend more time in their respective work areas and said frequent dashes to the national capital should be avoided.

"He said the leaders need to focus on issues that have wider ramifications on the party's electoral fortunes. He also instructed the leaders to reach out to people irrespective of their background

or political affiliation," said the person quoted above.

In states with more than two co-in-charges the teams have been instructed to divide work so that each region (of the state) can be overseen by a functionary. "The idea is to maximize outreach. Each leader will meet a cross section of people irrespective of their political background or faith," said a second functionary.

The first functionary quoted above said, in the poll-bound states particularly, the exercise will be carried out to ensure there are no gaps in outreach.

"The UP in-charge and all co-in-charges will visit Lucknow on October 1, which will be followed by a meeting with chief minister Yogi Adityanath and discussions with the state office bearers and key leaders. They will then proceed for a tour of

the state and begin meetings with various caste groups, intellectuals, professionals and so on," said the first leader.

The party leaders at the state level will also sharpen their attack on the Opposition for casting aspersions on the poll panel. "The meeting was to give the office bearers a lowdown of work they will be required to perform for the organisation, politically and for social service," said the second functionary.

Meanwhile, the BJP accused the Congress of keeping double standards on SIR. BJP national general secretary Smriti Irani said the Congress has been attacking the constitution, institutions and democratic processes instead of reflecting on the reasons for its defeat. "Does the Congress give a clean chit to the EC in states where it is in power?" she said.

{ NANDIGRAM BYROLL }

HC grants interim bail to Congress candidate

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KOLKATA: The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday granted interim bail to Congress candidate for the West Bengal assembly by-elections from the Nandigram constituency, Milan Pradhan, till October 20.

"A bench of justice Tirthankar Ghosh granted interim bail to Pradhan till October 20 in all the six cases. He will now be able to campaign for the bypolls," Ajitesh Pandey, Pradhan's advocate said. The high court judge also directed Pradhan to deposit a ₹20,000 bail bond in each of the six criminal cases for which he was arrested.

Pradhan was arrested on September 18 in murder cases dating back to 2007—four registered at Nandigram police station and two more in neighbouring Khajuri, and was in judicial remand. Earlier this week, two lower courts at Contai and Haldia in East Midnapore sent him to judicial custody till October 7.

Passing the interim bail order, justice Ghosh said the magistrate of the trial court concerned would decide on appropriate

steps after considering the cases against him.

Mamata Banerjee, who now heads one of the factions of the Trinamool Congress—the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress—had earlier extended support to the Congress candidate after her own candidate Sanchita Pradhan Dey withdrew her nomination.

The by-election in Nandigram was necessitated after West Bengal chief minister Suvedu Adhikari, who won Nandigram and Bhabanipur in the May assembly polls, decided to retain the latter seat. The ECI has announced bypolls in Nandigram and Rejinagar on October 6. Results will be declared on October 9. The campaigning will conclude on October 4. The Calcutta high court had earlier said Pradhan should be allowed to contest the Nandigram bypolls properly provided he gets bail in the cases in which he was arrested.

In a separate development, a bench of justice Krishna Rao dismissed a Congress plea against BJP's Nandigram candidate Hasi Rani Rath, alleging discrepancies in nomination affidavit.

CMRL: HC RESERVES ORDER ON PLEA SEEKING F.I.R. AGAINST VIJAYAN

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala High Court on Tuesday reserved its order on a plea seeking registration of an FIR under the Prevention of Corruption Act against former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and Communist Party of India (Marxist) MLA PA Mohammed Riyas in the CMRL monthly payoffs case.

The plea, filed by activist-lawyer KM Shajahan, also sought directions to the state government to hand over the current Crime Branch probe to the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB).

The petitioner challenged the move of the state government to order a preliminary inquiry by the Crime Branch into allegations of bribery and corruption before registering an FIR. The state's move was propelled by the communication sent by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to the state Director General of Police recommending initiating a corruption case against Vijayan and others based on the "evidence" it collected as part of its probe into the case.

'Centre has entered rabi season with 34% higher fertiliser stock'

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NEW DELHI: Union agriculture minister Shivrj Singh Chouhan on Tuesday said the Centre has entered the 2026-27 rabi season with 16.4 million tonnes (MT) of fertiliser in stock, 4.1 MT more than at the start of the last year's rabi season. The opening stock was 12.3 MT last year, which means the stock this year is about 34% higher.

Addressing a press conference during the National Agriculture Conference, the minister said the government has assessed the total fertiliser requirement for rabi 2026-27 at 38.1 MT. Of this, urea accounts for 17.8 MT, while DAP sales were 4.5 MT, against a requirement of 5.6 MT. Overall fertiliser requirement was 38.4 MT, compared with sales of 32.3 MT.

The government attributed part of the decline in sales to tighter monitoring under its digital fertiliser sales framework. It said total fertiliser sales had fallen by about 27% from last year, while sales in border districts declined 37.56%. About 88.2% of purchases were made within the government's recom-



Shivrj Singh Chouhan

ment's assessed requirement.

According to official figures, as of September 25, fertiliser utilisation during kharif remained below the assessed requirement. Urea requirement stood at 19 MT, against sales of 17.8 MT, while DAP sales were 4.5 MT, against a requirement of 5.6 MT. Overall fertiliser requirement was 38.4 MT, compared with sales of 32.3 MT.

The government attributed part of the decline in sales to tighter monitoring under its digital fertiliser sales framework. It said total fertiliser sales had fallen by about 27% from last year, while sales in border districts declined 37.56%. About 88.2% of purchases were made within the government's recom-

mended fertiliser-use framework, while around 11.8% of purchases were outside it, according to the government.

Meanwhile, the government has also reported a surplus in certified seed availability for rabi crops.

Against a requirement of 30.7 million quintals, about 4.9 million quintals of additional certified and quality seed are available, according to the briefing.

The government said seed availability is adequate across major rabi crops, including cereals, potato, pulses and oilseeds. States and agencies have been asked to coordinate to ensure timely movement of seed to areas where it is required.

The Centre has also asked states to join the SATHI portal, which is intended to improve monitoring of the seed supply chain and help check the sale of fake and poor-quality seeds.

The government is also pushing for faster payment to farmers selling pulses. States have been asked to maintain a 'Revolving Fund' with government procurement agencies so that farmers can be paid within 72 hours of selling their produce.

Rahul urges youngsters to step up stir over women safety, says govt 'deaf' to concerns

NEW DELHI: Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday urged young women and GenZ to step up protests over women's safety, saying the government is "deaf" to their concerns and will respond only when it faces sustained public pressure. "Thousands of students and young people are on the streets demanding safety for women. I urge even more young women, especially GenZ to come out in stronger numbers," he said in a post on X, further adding, "This government is deaf to your pain and will only listen when it's under pressure."

Kumaraswamy flags deviations in NICE project, attacks CM

NEW DELHI: Union minister HD Kumaraswamy on Tuesday intensified his attack on Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar over the Bengaluru-Mysuru Infrastructure Corridor, alleging that the original project framework was altered to expand the land requirement for the road and facilitate the interests of private parties. He alleged that the project originally began with an agreement involving VHB, the Kalyani Group and SA Engineering and Construction, before Nandi Infrastructure Corridor Enterprise Limited (NICE) entered the picture.

TMC may release audio of meetings with CEC next week

AGRA: The Trinamool Congress (TMC) is contemplating releasing audio recordings of its meetings with Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar amid the ongoing row over the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise, party sources said on Tuesday. They said the recordings are expected to be released next week to highlight the manner in which Kumar interacted with political parties during meetings with the poll panel, including discussions on the technicalities and procedures relating to the election process.

Assam Rifles jawan killed, four injured in Arunachal ambush

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ITANAGAR: One Assam Rifles personnel was killed and four others were injured after a patrol team came under a suspected militant attack along the India-Myanmar border in Arunachal Pradesh's Changlang district on Tuesday morning, the paramilitary force confirmed.

The incident occurred around 6.30 am near Nampong Nallah under Nampong Circle when personnel of the 21 Assam Rifles were patrolling an area where border fencing work is underway, officials said.

The deceased has been identified as Havildar Jankhokai Kuki, 42. "Lt Gen Vikas Lakhera, AVSM, SM, Director General Assam Rifles & All Ranks of Assam Rifles pay solemn tribute to Hav Jankhokai Kuki who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty at Changlang, Arunachal Pradesh on 29 Sep 2026 and offer deep condolences to the family of our Brave Soldier," the force said in an X post.

The injured personnel were being evacuated for medical treatment while further details regarding their condition were awaited. According to officials, preliminary reports suspect the involvement of militants belong-



Hav Jankhokai Kuki

ing to the NSCN (K-YA). However, there was no official confirmation regarding the identity of the attackers. Further details regarding the nature of the attack and subsequent security operation were awaited.

Changlang superintendent of police Kirli Padu said he had received information about the incident and directed the officer-in-charge of Changlang police station to gather details. "We have received information about the incident that occurred along the IMB (India-Myanmar Border) and have asked the OC of Changlang police station to collect all information related to it," the SP said. Padu, however, did not dwell further on the incident.

The India-Myanmar border in Changlang district has remained sensitive because of the movement of insurgent groups operating in the region and across the international boundary.

4 CISF men killed in J&K fratricide

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NEW DELHI/JAMMU: Four Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) personnel were killed in a fratricide incident in Kathua district of Jammu and Kashmir on Tuesday evening, people aware of the matter said.

The deceased were identified as assistant commandant Ankit Kumar Pandey, constables Rafiq Ahmed and Sandeep Kumar, and sub-inspector Lakshman Singh. They were posted at the Sewa Hydrel Power Project in Mashka, Basohli, along with the accused head constable, who was part of the same CISF company.

An officer aware of the matter said, "Prima facie, the probe has revealed that the incident took place just before the change of guard (security shift duty) on Tuesday evening. An argument broke out between the accused CISF head constable and the other four deceased. The accused man has been arrested and handed over to the police. He used his service weapon, which has been seized."

SSP Kathua Mohita Sharma confirmed the incident and the arrest.

The CISF guards the Sewa

THE INCIDENT TOOK PLACE JUST BEFORE THE CHANGE OF GUARD. THE ACCUSED HAS BEEN ARRESTED AND HANDED OVER TO THE POLICE, SAID AN OFFICER

hydroelectric project because it is a vital installation near the border. The injured personnel were initially taken to NHPC Hospital on the Himachal Pradesh side, where all four later succumbed to their injuries. The accused head constable's service weapon — an AK-47 — was also handed over to the Kathua police.

Pandey, the senior-most among the deceased, was the company commander at the project. The police are questioning the accused, Avdesh Kumar, while the CISF is conducting an internal inquiry into the circumstances that led to the incident. Senior officials from the CISF headquarters in Delhi are expected to reach Kathua on

Wednesday.

Four days before the incident, the CISF signed a three-year memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences (IHBAS) to address the critical need for occupational-stress management.

As part of the programme, IHBAS will conduct specialised psychometric assessments for personnel deployed in highly sensitive units, specifically including those proposed for deployment at the Parliament House Complex. Medical Officers, Supervisory Officers and Sub-Officers will be trained to identify early behavioural changes, signs of acute stress and psychiatric emergencies for timely professional intervention.

The MoU, which was signed at the CISF headquarters, read, "Mental health and occupational stress are pressing challenges for security forces globally. To combat this glaring issue proactively, the CISF is building a robust institutional framework by partnering with leading specialist organizations. This new MoU with IHBAS adds a specialized clinical and psychiatric dimension to the CISF's expanding mental-wellness ecosystem..."



Mohan Bhagwat

'TRUE PROGRESS IS WHEN BENEFITS REACH POOREST'

Pradip Kumar Maitra

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NAGPUR: True development must focus on the welfare of every citizen, with the most marginalised person at its core, while keeping the gap between the highest and lowest economic strata as narrow as possible, Rashtriya Swamsevaks Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Tuesday.

"Real development is not measured by statistics, but by whether its benefits reach the poorest and most vulnerable person in society," Bhagwat said.

Addressing a function organised to mark the birth anniversary of Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya in Yavatmal, around 160 km from Nagpur, he said: "Even if the country progresses, if the benefits fail to reach the least person in the line, we must rethink our model of development."

"The last person in society should be as happy as possible for the country to be happy. This is what is called 'Antyodaya'," he added.

Nirav Modi aide deported from UAE, held by CBI

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NEW DELHI: Sandeep Mistry, a close aide of fugitive diamondaire Nirav Modi, was deported from the UAE late on Monday and taken into custody in the \$2 billion Punjab National Bank (PNB) fraud case, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) said on Tuesday.

Abducting since 2018, when the PNB fraud came to the light, Mistry operated from Hong Kong on the directions of Modi before fleeing to Cairo first, and then the UAE, according to CBI. He, along with Nirav Modi's brother Nehal Modi, had played a key role in destroying the evidence including electronic devices, documents, etc and transferring several executives of Modi's Firestar Group from Hong Kong and Dubai to Cairo so that Indian agencies do not find them, the agency has claimed.

A CBI spokesperson said that an Interpol red notice was issued against Mistry in July this year and within two months, he was "successfully traced, apprehended and brought back to India". He arrived in India at 11.55 pm on Monday and was taken into custody at Mumbai airport.

"Mistry was wanted for his involvement in the PNB fraud case. He acted as a key link between various entities, overseeing their day-to-day operations and issuing instructions through clandestine, self-deleting communication platforms to conceal evidence. He also facilitated



Sandeep Mistry

ated the preparation of forged import-export documents to portray fictitious trade in diamonds, gold and pearl jewellery," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement on Tuesday.

A CBI officer who didn't want to be named said after the agency started a probe in PNB fraud, in March 2018, "money was withdrawn from Dubai based group accounts, and handed over to Mistry".

Both, CBI and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) have filed charge sheets against Mistry. The ED, earlier this year moved a Mumbai court seeking to declare him a fugitive economic offender (FEO).

CBI said that Mistry was geo-located and arrested by the UAE authorities, after which deportation was initiated. Deportation is an arrangement between two countries to repatriate a fugitive in a more informal manner, rather than going through lengthy court-led extradition proceedings, which take years.

CBI has successfully brought over 175 fugitives from foreign countries in the last few years with the help of Interpol.

3 cases registered over LPU violence, SIT to probe arson

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JALANDHAR: The Punjab police have registered three FIRs against unidentified students on the charges of attempt to murder, robbery and assault on police personnel during violent clashes at Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Phagwara, and have constituted a separate special investigation team to probe acts of arson, officers aware of the matter said.

Internet services in the area resumed on Tuesday after remaining suspended for 24 hours even as the entry of outsiders and media on campus remained restricted, they said.

Two FIRs were registered at Sadar police station, Phagwara, and one was recorded in Satnampura police station of Kapurthala districts on Monday on the statements by police personnel, the officers said.

Superintendent of Police, Phagwara, Major Singh will lead an 8-member special investigation team (SIT), comprising



Internet services in the area resumed on Tuesday.

three SP-level officers.

Violence erupted on campus on Sunday when a mob vandalised university property, torched police vehicles, and set parts of campus buildings on fire following unverified reports that an outsider had raped a female student. The agitated protesters pelted stones and glass bottles at the police force deployed on the spot. Demonstrators blocked the Amritsar-Delhi National Highway-44 for nearly 12 hours. The highway was reopened at around 12:20am.

The Kapurthala police had registered a rape case under Section 64 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita against an unnamed

person on September 26.

"The university management has been directed to provide all the above mentioned requirements to the SIT for smooth and impartial probe, besides ensuring wholesome coordination and cooperation in the matter," said a senior official privy to the investigation.

Kapurthala SSP Gaurav Toora said, "Investigation is on and we are verifying every single detail to carry out probe in a professional manner." "We have gathered some Important leads about those involved in criminal acts of arson and rampage. Since it is volatile and sensitive, all the information could not be shared at this stage," SSP Toora said.

Police have directed LPU authorities to hand over technical support personnel, who are well acquainted with the technical database and digital record of the university, including CCTV footages. Police have directed all university staff to remain available for investigation, and no resignation should be accepted without SIT's approval.

13 held in Assam, Keralam, WB in cross-border terrorism probe

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SILCHAR/KOLKATA: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Tuesday arrested 13 people from Assam, West Bengal and Keralam and conducted searches at 16 locations across the three states as part of an investigation into an alleged cross-border terror conspiracy and radicalisation network, police said.

While four people were arrested from West Bengal, eight were intercepted in Assam and one was held from Keralam. "Raids were conducted in 16 locations in the three states, including five in West Bengal. In all 13 people were arrested. The accused were held for their alleged links with the IMK," said a NIA official.

According to police, the searches were conducted in connection with a probe into Imam Mahmudur Kafil (IMK), which investigators have described as an offshoot of the banned Jama'atul Mujahideen Bangladesh (JMB).

NIA teams searched the resi-

NIA CONDUCTED SEARCHES IN THE THREE STATES IN CONNECTION WITH ITS PROBE INTO IMK, WHICH INVESTIGATORS DESCRIBED AS AN OFFSHOOT OF THE BANNED JMB

dences of some of those arrested, while police said several other premises were also searched as part of the operation.

The Union government banned the JMB and all its manifestations under section 35 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967 in May 2019.

People familiar with the matter said that Assam Police had arrested 11 people from various districts in Assam, West Bengal and Tripura in December 2025. A case was registered against 35 people for their alleged involvement in an online radicalisation module operated by Bangladesh-

based handlers of the IMK through a Telegram group 'Purva Akash'. The 11 accused were charge-sheeted and are now in custody.

The charge sheet was filed before the NIA Special Court in Guwahati under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), 1967, the agency said in June.

Later the NIA took over the probe. Investigation by the agency revealed that the accused were trying to expand the IMK's ideology in West Bengal and north-eastern states.

"Investigations revealed that the accused were trying to expand the JMB's and IMK's network in West Bengal and other north eastern states through religious indoctrination, extremist literature and use of digital platforms. Mobile phones, pen-drives, and memory cards were seized from them," said an official.

At least 10 accused, including nine Bangladeshis are still absconding.



Zubeen Garg

ZUBEEN'S DEATH: COURT GIVES BAIL TO TWO PERSONAL SECURITY OFFICERS

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SILCHAR: A special court in Guwahati on Tuesday granted bail to two personal security officers of late singer Zubeen Garg in a disproportionate assets case. However, they will remain in jail in connection with a separate case related to Garg's death.

The assets case against Paresha Baishya and Nandeshwar Bora was registered by the Assam Chief Minister's Special Vigilance Cell last year over allegations that they possess assets disproportionate to their known sources of income.

The vigilance authorities later filed separate charge sheets against Baishya and Bora.

During Tuesday's hearing, the defence challenged the legality of the arrests and argued that prescribed rules and procedures not been followed. The bail order, however, applies only to the disproportionate assets case. It does not override the custody orders in the separate case concerning Garg's death.

Baishya and Bora were arrested by the Assam Police's Crime Investigation Department (CID) on October 10, 2025, during the investigation into the death of the late singer. Police had said investigators found 'unusual transactions' in their bank accounts.

The two PSOs had also sought bail in the death case in June this year, but their pleas were rejected by the fast-track court.

Zubeen Garg died in Singapore on September 19, 2025, where he travelled to attend the North East India Festival.

{ AFTER TENDER DELAY }

MP to transfer ₹600 to 5.8mn students for school uniforms

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BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh government on Tuesday decided to transfer ₹600 into the bank accounts of 5.8 million students to buy school uniforms after it failed to float the tender on time amid allegations of irregularities in the process, people familiar with the matter said.

According to state cabinet minister Chetan Kashyap, the money transfer, announced five months into the academic sessions, will be carried out through the direct benefit transfer (DBT) process.

The state cabinet approved ₹348.07 crore for the 2026-27 academic session to provide uniform allowances to 5.8 million students studying in Classes 1 to 8 in government schools, Kashyap said.

"The government had initially decided to provide stitched uniforms to students this year but the tender couldn't be placed due to objections. Now, the amount will be disbursed directly into the accounts of the students and their parents via DBT (Direct Benefit Transfer)," Kashyap said.

HT had reported on July 5 that the government had decided that in the tender process, firms with at least ₹700 crore turnover in the last three financial years and involved in at least ₹105 crore business in fabrics with the government, would be allowed to apply for the contract to make the uniforms.

The garment manufacturers' body alleged that the eligibility conditions unfairly excluded local industries, self-help groups (SHG) for women and MSMEs from the tender process.

In 2018, then chief minister



The state approved ₹348.07cr for 2026-27 session to provide uniform allowances.

Shivraj Singh Chouhan had given SHGs the work to stitch nearly 11 million uniforms for over 5.5 million government school students from Class 1 to 8 under the State Rural Livelihood Mission. Since 2024, the state government has been directly transferring the money to the parents' bank accounts to buy uniforms.

On July 16, the Madhya Pradesh High Court stayed the finalisation of a ₹350-crore tender and directed the state government to file its response within a week.

However, following objections raised by the high court regarding the tender process and the inability to make uniforms available on time, the government decided to change the arrangement.

Kashyap said, "We will start a new process to provide uniforms on time from next academic year."

Along with uniforms, the council of ministers has decided to provide 20% horizontal reservation to "Agniveers" in uniformed services such as police constables, special armed forces, jail guards, forest guards, and excise constables.

SC PULLS UP NCPCR FOR 'INDIFFERENT' IMPLEMENTATION OF 25% EWS QUOTA

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday took exception to what it said was indifference shown by the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) in implementing its judgment seeking enforcement of a 25% quota for economically weaker students in private schools and asked the chairperson of the statutory body to be present at the next hearing.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe said, "NCPCR being a statutory authority has a big role to play. Whoever heads the NCPCR must be sensitised about how much hope and trust is placed on its shoulders. How can they act so indifferent?"

The court was monitoring the implementation of its January 13 direction which mandated strict enforcement of the provision under section 12(I)(c) of the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009. This provision requires private schools to admit children belonging to weaker and disadvantaged groups in the neighbourhood to the extent of at least 25% of the class strength.

The judgment noted that while the NCPCR has an SOP, these guidelines are not enforceable. It tasked the NCPCR and Centre to consider formulating subordinate legislation by issuing necessary rules and regulations, prescribing the method and manner by which the children of weaker and disadvantaged sections are to be admitted in schools.

"Without such enforceable rules and regulations, the object of Article 21A (right to free and compulsory education) of the Constitution of India and the statutory policy under section 12(I)(c) would be a dead letter," the court said.

HT

Ex-IFS officer BK Singh conferred Eco Warrior Award

NEW DELHI: Retired Indian Forest Service (IFS) officer BK Singh received the Lifetime Achievement Award for his conservation efforts at the Eco Warrior Awards 2026 on Tuesday in New Delhi. He was felicitated along with 15 other forest officers for their contribution to environmental conservation, a PIB statement said. Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav presented the award to Brij Kishore Singh, a 1976-batch IFS officer of the Karnataka cadre.

Keralam local body bypolls: UDF wins 22 wards, LDF 18

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The ruling Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) won 19 of the 38 local body wards, where bypolls were conducted on Monday in Keralam, suffering setbacks, both in terms of seats won and margin of votes, at the hands of the rival CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF). While the UDF held 22 of the 38 wards previously, their tally in the recent bypolls dipped to 19. The LDF made the gains with its tally rising from 15 to 18. The NDA, retained the sole ward.

Wildlife SOS chief quizzed over leopard poaching case

BHOPAL: Wildlife SOS chief Kartick Satyanarayan was questioned for more than 18 hours by the State Tiger Strike Force (STSF) in Shivpuri on Monday and Tuesday in connection with the alleged poaching of 10 leopards. Forest officials said the interrogation would continue on Wednesday. "Investigators questioned Satyanarayan about two Wildlife SOS employees arrested in the case after WhatsApp chats allegedly revealed their contact with poachers in Sheopur and suppliers of metal traps in Haryana," an officer said.

HC stays arrest of CJP member booked for video of UP school

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PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court has stayed the arrest of Gaurav Bharti alias Gaurav Kumar, a student and member of the Cockerock Janta Party (CJP), following an FIR registered against him by the Uttar Pradesh Police for recording a video showing the state of a government primary school in Farrukhabad district.

Hearing the writ petition, a division bench comprising justices Salil Kumar Rai and Padam Narain Mishra issued an order on September 22 directing the state government to file its reply.

In the petition, Bharti challenged the FIR registered on August 19 under Sections 352 and 353 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and Section 66 of the Information Technology Act, 2000, at Nawabganj police station in Fatehgarh district. The petitioner sought quash-



Gaurav Bharti at the primary school in UP's Farrukhabad district. INSTAGRAM@GAURAV BHARTI

ing of the FIR because the allegations made in it did not disclose the essential ingredients of the invoked offences.

According to the petition, on August 16, the petitioner entered the premises of a government primary school at Karanpur Majra Basmal, Farrukhabad, and recorded a video. The petition states the school was closed that day and the video depicted a "disused/dilapidated building,

with a cross mark allegedly shown on a structure depicted as in use."

The petitioner said the video highlighted water accumulation in the school, which left children without sitting space and led to holidays. The petitioner submitted that the video was created and published "in good faith to highlight the condition of a public educational institution and matters concerning the welfare and facilities of children".

The FIR alleged that the petitioner entered the school without authority, misrepresented the condition of the institution and visited with an individual who was "under the influence of liquor and spoke useless talks with the teachers".

The petitioner submitted that the FIR fails to reproduce the spoken words, state the target of the remarks, or demonstrate intentional insult, assault, criminal force, threat, obstruction, or violence.

COUPLE HACKED TO DEATH IN PVT SCHOOL THEY HAD FOUNDED IN U.P.

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LUCKNOW: A government school principal and his wife were hacked to death on Monday night on the campus of a private school they founded in Uttar Pradesh's Sultanpur district, police said on Tuesday.

The police are probing possible links to a teachers' union election and an alleged family land dispute.

The deceased were identified as Mukesh Singh, 45, principal at Composite School, Khanuhat, and his wife Vinita Singh, 43. According to the police, both victims appeared to have been attacked with sharp-edged weapons. A blood-stained spade was found near Vinita's body, while an axe and a knife were recovered from the premises. The bodies were sent for post-mortem examination, said the police.

"Information was received on Tuesday morning about the bodies of a husband and wife. Several teams have been formed and are working on the case. We are also in contact with the family and the case will be worked out soon," said Sultanpur SP Vineet Jaiswal.

The killings came to light when a school bus driver and teacher arrived to collect the school bus keys.

Mukesh was posted at the composite school in Khanuhat and had been associated with the teachers' union since 2013, police said. He was contesting the block teachers' union election, with polling scheduled for September 30. Police said they are examining whether the election could have triggered a dispute. A second line of inquiry relates to the family's ancestral property — 35 bighas of land — and police were verifying local accounts of any dispute over the property.

EAM: US' lack of empathy on Pak terror can hit ties

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WASHINGTON: India's concerns over terrorism emanating from Pakistan and a lack of sufficient understanding of those concerns in the US can affect the India-US relationship, external affairs minister S Jaishankar said in New York on Monday, identifying the issue as one of the challenges facing the partnership.

"What for us in India is particularly important is the issue of terrorism. There are very few countries that have been subjected to the kind of terrorism that we have from a neighbour as part of a deliberate, conscious policy over many, many decades," Jaishankar said at a conversation hosted by the Asia Society.

"Now, if something that matters so deeply to us — there isn't enough understanding or appreciation or empathy of that — that creates a problem too," the minister said.

"If one of my primary concerns is not fully appreciated by my partner, then that can have an impact on the relationship," Jaishankar added, in an assessment of the challenges facing the US-India partnership.

Responding to a question on the problems that have affected the relationship over the past 18



S Jaishankar

months, Jaishankar also flagged growing opposition to immigration and mobility in the US, saying this could affect public perceptions of India and the US in both countries.

"Foreign policy and diplomacy today is not just something which is conducted by states or leaders or ministers or even by diplomats. In a social media era, there is a very big public opinion factor which, particularly in democratic societies, makes itself felt. I think that's a reality we have to take into account," the external affairs minister said.

Jaishankar was speaking as he concluded a visit to the US for the high-level week of the UN General Assembly, during which he held bilateral talks with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

According to India's readout of the Jaishankar-Rubio meet-

ing, the Indian minister raised concerns over the passage of the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act in the US Congress, which could pave the way for tariffs of up to 100% on major purchasers of Russian oil, including India.

Jaishankar also discussed the challenges surrounding the India-US trade deal, which he said had created "bumps" in bilateral ties over the past year. Describing the agreement as "very, very far advanced", he said its conclusion could contribute to an improvement in the relationship.

On India-China ties, Jaishankar said relations had steadily improved since 2024, while stressing that the situation along the border remained central to the relationship. "We have long been telling the Chinese that a stand-off between us and a dip in our relationship actually doesn't help either of us. In fact, it is third parties who will take advantage of that," he said.

Jaishankar said the improvement in ties with China had also helped India's position on other issues by ensuring that Indian foreign policy did not become overly focused on a single challenge. The Union minister reiterated India's position that the state of the border would determine the state of the broader relationship with China.

MISRI CONVEYED CONCERNS OVER SRIA IMPLICATIONS TO U.S. TEAM: MEA

NEW DELHI: Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, during his meeting with a bipartisan US Congressional delegation, conveyed India's "concerns" over the implications of the recently enacted Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act (SRIA) on bilateral ties and the international energy market, the ministry of external affairs said on Tuesday.

The meeting took place in Delhi on Sunday, and the US delegation was led by Brian Mast, Chairman of the House Foreign Affairs Committee, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in response to a query at his bi-weekly media briefing.

"Various issues of bilateral nature were discussed at the meeting. Also, the foreign secretary conveyed our concerns about the SRIA legislation, as to the kind of implications it would have for bilateral relationships, as well as for the international energy market," Jaiswal said.

President Donald Trump recently signed a law that authorises him to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries buying Russian oil and gas, including China and India.

PTI

NO HOOKAH EVEN IN SMOKING AREAS OF RESTAURANTS, CAFES IN U.P: HC

Pawan Dixit

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LUCKNOW: The Allahabad High Court on Tuesday ruled that hookah bars operating inside restaurants, cafes and other public places are illegal, holding that the fundamental right of non-smokers to breathe clean air outweighs the right to run businesses involving prohibited smoking activities. The court further held that no service is permitted even inside a designated smoking area (DSA).

The bench of justice Shekhar B Saraf and justice Abdhesh Kumar Chaudhary dismissed a bunch of pleas filed by restaurant and hookah bar owners challenging restrictions on the activity.

The petitioners argued that they had created separate DSAs in compliance with the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act, 2003 (COTPA), and therefore hookah smoking should be permitted.

However, the court observed that hookah smoking inherently requires commercial service, preparation, assistance and supply of hookah, flavour and coal at the table. Such services are prohibited under the amended Rule 4(3) of the Prohibition of Smoking in Public Places Rules, 2008.

{ **ANTILIA BOMB SCARE** }

NIA court grants bail to ex-cop Waze: 'No terror case made out'



Sachin Waze was arrested by NIA on March 13, 2021.

not appear to have been disturbed even for a minute," said judge Chakor Bawiskar.

"Even if we suppose that he wanted to create terror in the minds of Ambanis, it is impossible to accept that any such terror was in fact ever created in the mind of anyone, least in their minds," the special judge added while holding that prima facie the acts of the former policeman fell short of a terrorist act, as defined under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967.

Neither had NIA recorded statements of any of the Ambani family members, the court held further asking what had prevented the investigative agency from recording the statements of the Ambani family members. It termed NIA's tardiness in this matter as "incompetence". "No one knows which mahurat (good appropriate and auspicious

time) the Investigating Agency is waiting for to record statement of any of the targets of the alleged terror plot, especially as a long gap of five to six years has already lapsed since the incident," said the special court.

The court accepted the arguments advanced by advocate Sajal Yadav on behalf of Waze regarding the charge of murder and conspiracy. Waze, it said, was entitled to parity as two other former Mumbai police officers implicated in the case, Pradip Sharma and Sunil Mane, both of whom had already been granted bail.

The case arises from three interconnected FIRs registered in February and March 2021 in Mumbai. The first of these was registered on February 18, 2021 when Thane-based auto parts dealer Mansukh Hiran reported his Mahindra Scorpio SUV stolen from Vikhroli.

On February 25, the "stolen" vehicle was found parked outside Antilia with 20 gelatine sticks and a letter threatening the Ambani family, triggering the registration of a second FIR.

On March 9, the Union home ministry transferred all three cases for investigation to NIA, which arrested Waze on March 13, 2021.

{ **ANOTHER BIHAR HORROR** } VICTIM KEPT CAPTIVE IN HOTEL

Woman raped, assaulted in Begusarai; 2 held

Avinash Kumar

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PATNA: Police in Begusarai district in Bihar have arrested two men for rape and assault of a 22-year-old woman while keeping her captive inside a hotel room, police said on Tuesday, adding that the accused had made videos of the incident and circulated on the internet.

The Begusarai incident is the latest in a series of recent incidents related to crime against women being reported from the state, including the Jamui molestation case that sparked wide-

THIS IS THE LATEST IN A SERIES OF RECENT INCIDENTS RELATED TO CRIME AGAINST WOMEN BEING REPORTED FROM THE STATE

spread outrage.

According to police, the incident happened on September 27 when 24-year-old Vikas Sahni, one of the accused, took the victim to the hotel near National Highway-31 in the Town police

station area, where another accused 25-year-old Rohit Kumar was also present.

Police said the victim is a member of a self-help group and provides loans to those in need. According to the first information report (FIR), the accused took the victim to the hotel on the pretext of a conversation for a loan. Upon reaching the hotel room, Rohit locked the door and raped her at a knife-point, according to the FIR.

A video purportedly of the brutal assault of the woman in the hotel room surfaced on social media and was widely cir-

culated. In the video, veracity of which HT couldn't independently verify, a man could be seen thrashing the woman.

The FIR against the two persons have been registered under BNS sections of 127(2) (wrongful confinement), 115(2) (voluntarily causing hurt), 74 (use of force against a woman with the intent to outrage her modesty), 76 (force against a woman with the intent to disrobe), 64 (rape), 3(5) criminal act is done by several persons in furtherance of their common intention and 66 (C) 66 (D) 67 of the Information Technology Act, police said.

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court on Tuesday set aside Food Safety and Standards Authority of India's (FSSAI) order directing Red Bull to discontinue using the descriptor "Energy Drink" for its products.

A bench of justice Amit Mahajan directed FSSAI to consider the matter afresh after giving the company an opportunity of being heard. "It remains undisputed that the order dated 30th June, 2026 directing the petitioner to not use the term 'Energy Drink' in its product was passed without

affording any opportunity to the petitioner to file any reply or give any explanation. The impugned order is set aside," the court observed.

The court was hearing a petition filed by Red Bull challenging FSSAI's June 30 order directing the company to stop using the descriptor "Energy Drink" on its range of caffeinated beverages.

The petition also challenged a subsequent July 17 communication asking food safety officers across states and Union Territories to take action against products allegedly found to be non-compliant.

Red Bull claimed that the

July communication resulted in enforcement action, including the seizure of its products at multiple locations across the country.

On Monday, the high court had asked FSSAI's lawyer to seek instructions on whether it had issued notice to the company before passing the July 17 order and asked him to get back with instructions on Tuesday.

On Tuesday, FSSAI said the June 30 notice was only the show cause notice by which it had requested the company to change the label, since the word "energy drink" on the label was a problem.

5 OF JHANSI FAMILY DROWN IN RIVER

JHANSI: Five members of a family including a 12-year-old boy drowned in the Sukhna river during a religious ritual here on Tuesday, police said.

The incident took place in Mauranipur area around 1 pm when the family members, attending a 'shraddh' ceremony, entered the river to perform some ritual. Some of them apparently strayed into deep waters and began drowning.

Other family members rushed to their rescue, but were also swept into deep waters by the strong current, police said.

The deceased were identified as Anoop Tiwari (40), his son Arpit (12), Abhinav (24), Shreyansh alias Kallu (22) and Chhote alias Pushkar (25).

PTI

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Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



2 ARRESTED FOR PROMISING TO FACILITATE FCRA REGISTRATION

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NEW DELHI: The special cell of the Delhi Police has arrested two government officials, including one posted in the Foreigners Division of the ministry of home affairs (MHA), for allegedly seeking bribes from an association to facilitate a pending registration under the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), according to a government statement released on Tuesday.

The second accused is currently posted in MHA's Pay and Accounts Office. Police are probing their role in clearing similar FCRA registrations in the past.

According to a spokesperson, the arrests were made on Monday after a tip off by the ministry of home affairs (MHA) about the two men who were allegedly taking bribes to get FCRA registrations cleared.

"The officials, one working as a senior accountant and the other as an accountant, had allegedly approached an association and sought illegal gratification to facilitate its pending FCRA registration. While one of the officials is presently posted in the MHA's Foreigners Division, the other is currently posted in a Pay and Accounts Office and had previously served in the Foreigners Division," the spokesperson said.

In a statement, the MHA reiterated all FCRA-related services are delivered online through the FCRA portal and that no intermediary, agent or individual is authorised to facilitate any such service.

Clarity required on fine print of FCRA changes, says SBI

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NEW DELHI: The Union law ministry and the State Bank of India—which receives all foreign donations—have supported the objectives of the proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, but the latter said the legislation poses some challenges from the banker's perspective.

In a presentation to the Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the FCRA bill on Tuesday, a team of top SBI officials raised a number of issues and sought clarifications on various aspects of the bill.

"It does not specify whether the account to be frozen continues to operate, who operates it, whether credits and permitted debits can continue, and who authorises payments," the SBI team said.

The biggest public sector bank also asked which authority would tell the bank to restore the account and the amount of funds and how to treat the interest earned and bank charges if an organisation's FCRA licence is renewed. The SBI sought clarifications on the mechanism of vesting assets if the organisation has its account with a different bank.

The bank's presentation highlighted "areas of concern" from the perspective of "donors, beneficiaries, and the common man." It said automatic cessation might lead to small or rural associations

losing control of funds immediately. In whole asset-vesting or for vesting assets created partially from domestic funds, the SBI said that the onus of establishing the distinct portion lies with the association and maintained that ongoing programmes might be affected during vesting period.

Defending the bill amid stiff objections by the Opposition parties, the law ministry said while Section 15 of the current law allowed vesting of assets, "but the absence of a comprehensive framework for supervision, management and disposal of such assets has led to administrative uncertainty and operational issues."

"Multiplicity of investigations, inconsistency in penalties, absence of timelines for utilization, lack of express provisions for cessation of registration and ambiguity regarding treatment of assets during suspension had resulted in implementation challenges," it said.

The JPC led by BJP's Sanjay Jaiswal held its second meeting on the proposed law. DMK MP P Wilson on Tuesday urged Jaiswal to allow stakeholders to not only make suggestions but also flag objections. The introduction of Chapter three in the bill, allows a designated authority to not only take control of the assets of an organisation that ceases to have an FCRA licence, but also empowers it to transfer such assets to the government.

CURATIVE PETITION FILED OVER SC'S RULING IN CEC, EC'S APPOINTMENT LAW

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NEW DELHI: A curative petition was filed in the Supreme Court on Tuesday seeking recall of the order that referred the petitions challenging the law on the appointment of chief election commissioner and election commissioners to a Constitution bench. The petition said there was reasonable apprehension of bias against one of the judges who decided the case.

The petition was filed by Congress leader Jaya Thakur, one of the petitioners challenging the CEC & ECs (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023. On September 23, a bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma gave a split verdict on whether the petitions should be heard by a five-judge Constitution bench. They later passed a common order placing the matter before the Chief Justice of India (CJI) to constitute a five-judge bench.

Thakur's plea seeks recall of the September 23 order based on a "reasonable likelihood of bias," as news reports indicated that the son of one of the judges (Justice Sharma) appears for the Election Commission of India (ECI) before the Madhya Pradesh High Court.

Thakur stated that this fact was unknown to them during the hearing on the challenge to the 2023 law.

A curative petition is the last judicial recourse available to a litigant to overturn a verdict of the Supreme Court.

168K voters may not make it to final electoral roll in Andhra

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HYDERABAD: Around 168,000 voters registered in the current electoral rolls in Andhra Pradesh have been "found ineligible" for inclusion in the final rolls after the special intensive revision, officials said on Tuesday.

The period for disposal of claims and objections ended on Monday. The Election Commission of India subsequently declared that it completed hearings on 99.96% notices served to voters after the draft rolls were released on July 31.

An EC official explained that "ineligible" voters included those who failed to furnish documents for their verification or did not appear for the hearing in person

or through a family member.

"Out of 44.28 lakh (4.428 million) notices delivered, hearing with regard to 44.27 lakh (4.427 million) notices was completed as on September 28, the last date for disposal of claims and objections, accounting for 99.96% notices. Only 1,665 electors did not respond to the notices," a statement from chief electoral officer Vivek Yadav said.

The statement added that around 168,821 voters in the current electoral list were found ineligible for inclusion in the final electoral roll, which will be published on October 3.

Ananthapuramu district accounts for the most ineligible voters with 23,154 names likely to be dropped from the district, followed by 20,938 in Tirupati, 19,067 in Palnadu, 12,780 in NTR,

12,179 in Annamayya, 11,266 in Sri Satya Sai, 9,144 in YSR Kadapa and 8,390 voters in Nellore. Only 133 ineligible voters were found in Alluri Sitarama Raju district.

A total of 69,184 applications for inclusion through Form-6 and another 31,693 applications for address changes were pending clearance, said the EC official quoted above, adding, "These applications will be considered even after the publication of the final electoral roll."

In the neighbouring Telangana, more than 928,000 voters from a total of 33.8 million, have been issued notices over discrepancies in their details.

Telangana chief electoral officer C Sudharshan Reddy said the deadline for disposal of claims and objections is November 5.

HILLS ACCOUNT FOR 66% OF S.I.R. DELETIONS IN MANIPUR: REPORT

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NEW DELHI: A preliminary report by the Sabar Institute, a Kolkata-based research organisation, finds that the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) removed 158,677 names from Manipur's electoral roll in a "striking divide" between hills and valley, with the 20 hill constituencies account for 66.4% of all deletions. The report is based on the official lists of absent, shifted and dead voters for all 3,014 polling booths across the state's 60 Assembly seats. Hill booths lost 79 names each on average, against 31 in the Imphal Valley, which is about 2.5 times as many. To be sure, the deletion data is based on the draft SIR roll for the state.

No Akhilesh, 2 SP MPs to attend INDIA meet today

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LUCKNOW: The Samajwadi Party (SP) has named Harendra Malik and Mohibullah Nadvi as its representatives for Wednesday's meeting of the opposition grouping INDIA over the controversies related to Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Leaders aware of the matter said SP president Akhilesh Yadav will not be attending as he would be occupied with organisational responsibilities in Lucknow.

Yadav is expected to oversee the nomination of senior leader Ram Gopal Yadav in the party organisation, following which he will participate in a 'Kisan Sammelan' at the Samajwadi Party headquarters, they said.

Malik is SP MP from Muzaffarnagar and Nadvi represents Rampur in the Lok Sabha.

The leaders said the nomination of Malik and Nadvi reflects the SP's commitment to the opposition alliance's deliberations on the issues related alleged electoral malpractices.

MNS, SENA (UBT) TO PROTEST AGAINST EC

MUMBAI: Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray on Tuesday said his party and the Uddhav Thackeray-led Shiv Sena (UBT) will take out a morcha against the Election Commission in Mumbai on October 4. Thackeray said that the march from Byculla to the BMC Headquarters is aimed at uniting all political parties under the tricolour against the poll body over allegations of electoral roll manipulation.

DMK SAY WILL BACK MOVE TO REMOVE CEC

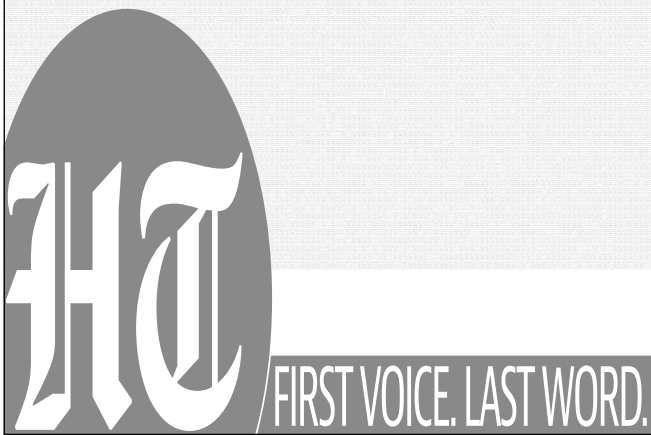
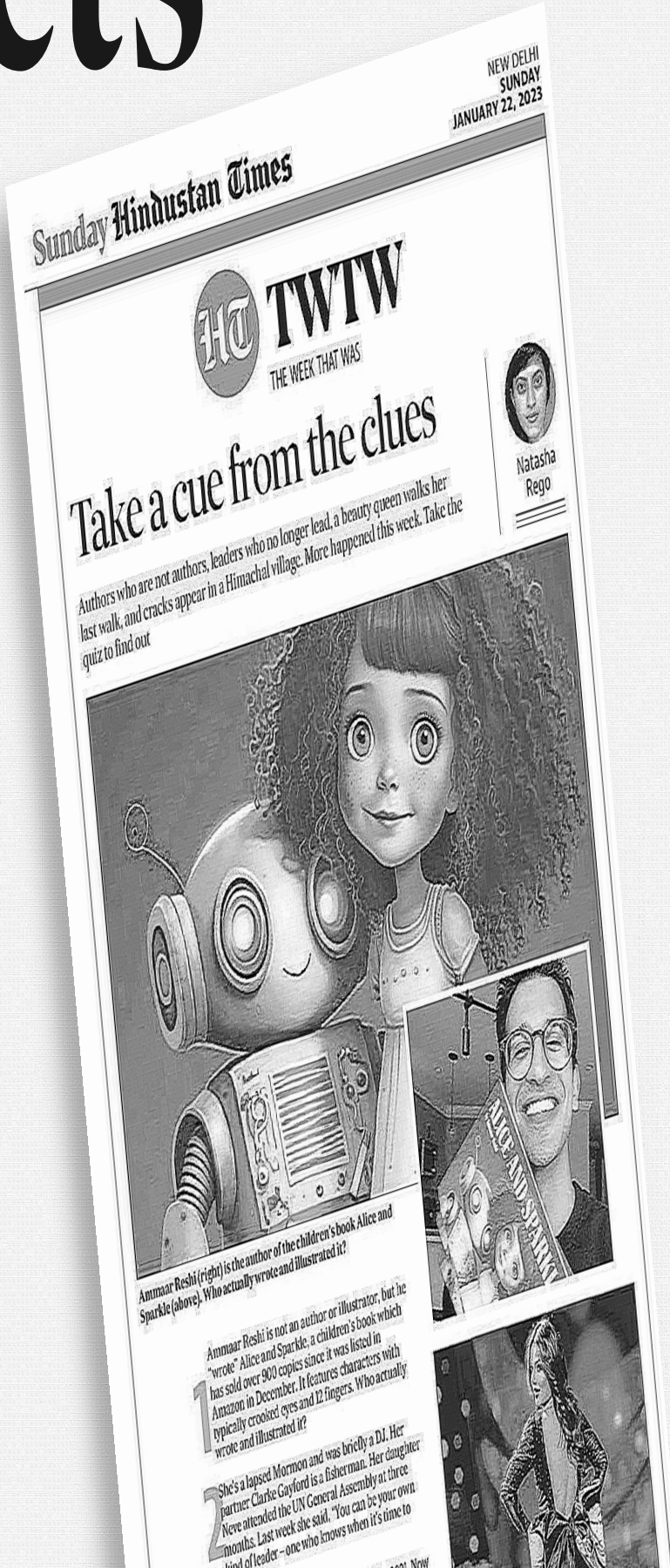
CHENNAI: The DMK said on Tuesday that it would support in Parliament the Opposition's move seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, though it is not part of the INDIA bloc. DMK spokesperson TKS Elangovan said, "Ideologically, we (Opposition) all stand together. We are not part of the INDIA bloc. That is different. But in Parliament, we will support whoever brings a removal motion against Gyanesh Kumar."

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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A quiz on the week's development.



{ FROM PAGE 1 }

PLEA AGAINST CEC IN SC
changes were made to Form 6 (for new voters), likely at the cost of inconveniencing first time voters.

The Commission has claimed that the decisions were all unanimous, and that the letters written by the two election commissioners to the cabinet secretary concerned the administrative duties of an officer seconded to the poll body and not any policy matter.

The Commission has also claimed that no changes were made to Form 6 itself, and that the additional information sought was through an addendum. And people familiar with the matter told HT that local officers enjoy the same access to the database they always have, and that the instance mentioned in the report concerned a situation where a local officer had ignored a deadline.

Some of the issues highlighted by the report have to do with the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, an exercise that has become controversial, with people scrambling to get their names included in the rolls.

To be sure, the people cited above claimed that the exercise was not aimed at disenfranchising anyone.

Opposition parties have threatened to impeach CEC Kumar.

The petition before the apex court, filed by social activist Rakesh Kumar Singh sought preservation of all records, files, notings, etc and a direction that Gyanesh Kumar "shall not exercise the functions of CEC of India, pending final hearing of the present petition". It further required that the business of ECI be transacted by the unanimous decision of the two election commissioners.

The petition even called to question the authority under which CEC acted unilaterally as Article 324 of Constitutions that governs functioning of ECI envisages the collective decision-making power of the commission, meant to be a multi-member collegial body. The plea said that CEC is only the Chairman and Constitution vests in him no individual title to the commission's collective authority. Section 18 of the CEC & EC Act, 2023 requires that in case of disagreement, the majority view should prevail.

The petition sought production of the complete original and primary records relating to

the matters referred in the news reports, including minutes, agendas, approvals, file notings, work-allocation and delegation orders, IT-access records, server logs, audit trails and database-change histories concerning the functioning of the commission.

It even sought the record disclosing decisions materially affecting the electoral roll, the Form-6 that required new voters to map legacy information with the 2002 roll, ERONet/ECINet access, and the authorisation for appeals challenging inclusion in the West Bengal rolls.

Singh suggested that if the court chooses to order a probe, the independent commission or SIT be assisted by independent experts in cybersecurity, information technology and electoral administration, to conduct a technical, forensic and administrative inquiry into the matters.

"If the power constitutionally vested in the Election Commission as a multi-member body can, in fact or in substance, be exercised by one office within it without the participation the Constitution and the 2023 Act require, then decisions that determine who is on the electoral roll, and therefore who may vote, raise a serious constitutional question as to whether such decisions are being taken by the constitutional authority the Constitution created for that purpose," the petition said.

SC-NSA DETENTION

The court said, "The appellant has already suffered considerable loss of liberty, even while being granted bail in all the cases relating to the incident in which he featured as an accused. In such circumstances, the process was made the punishment...We consider it prudent to impose costs of ₹10 lakh on the state for being made over to the appellant within a month from the date of this judgment."

Afroz had earlier approached the Allahabad high court which upheld his detention.

Two issues were brought up in his subsequent appeal before the Supreme Court – whether a confessional statement alone can be the ground for preventive detention and whether the state was right in issuing the detention order.

Advocate Divyesh Pratap Singh, who argued for Afroz, said that the appellant was tortured and threatened in cus-

tody and the entire statement was vitiated as it was recorded while he was in custody in the alleged murder case related to the violence. The state, on the other hand, claimed that he faced multiple cases and for this reason, his preventive detention was justified.

The court noted that the state did not deny the fact of torture suffered by the appellant in custody. "By no stretch of imagination, can the confessional statement of the appellant be seen as voluntary in nature," it said.

Since the Constitution protects a person against self-incrimination, the bench said that even under the law on evidence (section 23 of Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam), no confession made to a police officer shall be proved against an accused.

"Therefore, we are of the considered opinion that a confessional statement made before a police officer cannot, by itself, and in the absence of any independent material lending support thereto, constitute a basis for forming the subjective satisfaction necessary to sustain an order of preventive detention," the Supreme Court said.

On the second issue, the court examined whether there was any order material on which the detention order could be sustained. It noted that in September 2025, the accused secured bail and a month later, the detention order came to be passed. "Where a person is already in custody and preventive detention is sought to be invoked, the scrutiny of the detention order must necessarily be more exacting. The existence of a prior order granting bail in one of the connected cases was a relevant circumstance which required due consideration by the detaining authority," it said.

The bench noted that the police used the same material for sustaining both the criminal and preventive detention proceedings which made the court to observe, "The detention order has assumed a character more punitive than preventive."

It stated that preventive detention is regarded as an exceptional measure and must be invoked with the utmost circumspection and only in those rarest of rare cases where the circumstances genuinely warrant such exercise.

{ CLASS 9 SOCIAL SCIENCE PART 2 }

Mughal's 'brutality' against Sikh Gurus part of NCERT textbook

Sanjay Maurya

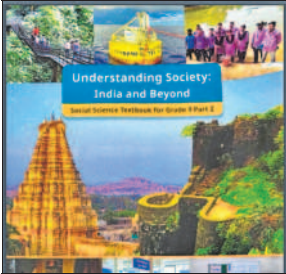
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NEW DELHI: The brutality of the Mughal state against the Sikh Gurus had "few comparisons in history" and was rooted in "rigid religious and discriminatory practices", according to the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) Class 9 Social Science textbook, part 2, Understanding Society: India and Beyond, released on Tuesday.

The previous textbook, first published in 2007 and continued till 2025-26 academic year, followed different progressions of historical chapters and did not contain the above mentioned instance.

The history chapter, "Resistance and Resilience (1000-1700 CE)", says the "valour and sacrifice" of the Sikh Gurus "for the cause of the faith" became defining features of Sikhism. It says their martyrdom strengthened the community's conviction that persecution had to be met with "firm resistance and resilience".

"The brutality of the Mughal state against the Sikh Gurus, particularly Guru Arjan Dev, Guru Tegh Bahadur, and the tenth Guru, Guru Gobind Singh, has few comparisons in history," the textbook says. "The valour and sacrifices of the Gurus for the cause of the faith became the defining features of Sikhism. Beyond political motivations, the act (execution of Sikh Gurus by Mughals) was also deeply rooted in the rigid religious and discriminatory practices of the



The revised textbook was released on Tuesday.

Mughals," it adds.

The textbook says the Mughal state began to intervene more and more in the affairs of the Sikh Gurus from the beginning of the 17th century as their "socio-cultural influence" grew.

It says, "Due to the growing socio-cultural influence of the Sikh Gurus, the Mughal state increasingly intervened in their affairs from the beginning of the 17th century. As the Guru's influence was increasing, Jahangir ordered the execution of Guru Arjan Dev (the fifth Sikh guru) on the pretext of the Guru's alleged support to Jahangir's rebellious son, Khusrav Mirza."

It describes the martyrdom as a "significant turning point" in Sikh history.

The book also records Guru Hargobind's detention by Jahangir at Gwalior Fort and the establishment of the Akal Takht as a seat of temporal authority, along with the concept of miri-piri, representing spiritual and worldly authority.

On Guru Gobind Singh, the textbook says, "In 1699, Guru

Gobind Singh established and developed a Sikh order known as the Khalsa. The Khalsa adopted a distinct martial code in response to the changing socio-political environment. Through this process, spiritual identity became closely intertwined with the pursuit of political identity."

The framing is also sharper than that of older NCERT history textbooks. An older Class 11 history textbook by late historian Satish Chandra, first published in 1978, described the conflicts between the Sikh Gurus and the Mughals under Jahangir and Shah Jahan as "political and personal rather than religious". The older textbook was in use till 2006.

Historian Ruchika Sharma, who specialises in medieval Indian history and is a former fellow at the University of Essex, said the new textbook was reviving what she described as a "massively debunked" interpretation of the Sikh-Mughal conflict as primarily religious. "The conflict was 100% political," she said. She argued that the relationship was cordial at first and changed after Guru Arjan Dev supported Khusrav, including by putting a tilak on him, which she described as an act of political opposition to Jahangir.

NCERT did not respond to HT's queries. In the foreword, NCERT director Dinesh Prasad Saklani wrote: "The content has been carefully selected to engage students with questions related to society, governance, environment, culture, economy, and human relationships..."

9% students reported suicidal thoughts on campus: SC task force

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: About 15% students in higher education institutions experienced a period in the previous six months when they felt overwhelmed or distressed, while 9% reported experiencing suicidal thoughts, according to a nationwide survey conducted by a Supreme Court-appointed panel examining student suicides.

The survey findings, accessed by PTI, are expected to be part of the final report of the National Task Force (NTF) to address mental health concerns of students and prevent suicides in higher educational institutions (HEIs), which is expected to be submitted by October 31.

The survey findings assume significance in the wake of renewed debate on student suicides following the death of two students at IIT Delhi and Bombay which have led to wide-spread outrage.

The SC-appointed panel had earlier this year submitted an interim report in which it had noted that the experience of higher education for students has been found to be marked by "deep-rooted social discrimination, rampant sexual harassment in medical and engineering colleges; gender discrimination by faculty in medical, law and state universities, in terms of academic support, hostel curfews and moral policing; caste identification by NEET-UG and JEE ranks; caste-based humiliation and discrimination in terms of admission, grading, language

gaps and faculty attention". According to the survey conducted by the NTF with responses from over 243,000 students, 67% of which belonged to SC, ST and OBC category, about 34% reported feeling like an outsider on campus to varying extent.

"About 15% students recalled a period in the previous six months when they felt very overwhelmed or distressed, or experienced low moods or anxiety continuously for several weeks. Nine percent reported experiencing suicidal thoughts often or very often in the past year."

The survey found, "56% students indicated having trust in the administration to handle serious issues fairly while roughly 32% said their institute did not offer counselling services."

According to officials, concerns around academic choices and frequent worries related to employment were common.

"Responses to many other items, including open-text fields, are still being analysed. Moreover, due to non-representativeness of the current sample, the observations need to be taken as preliminary and tentative," a senior official said. The official, however, noted that emerging patterns suggest urgent action for standardized student support systems, implementation of measures such as faculty training, stigma-reduction, crisis SOPs, regular monitoring with quality-data and building responsive and transparent administration for addressing student mental health.

Bengal: ED raids ex-min's home

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KOLKATA: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Tuesday searched at least 15 locations in Kolkata, including the residence of a former state minister, in connection with alleged financial irregularities centering around the Durga Puja, officials said.

"ED officials in Kolkata are conducting searches at 15 premises in Kolkata in connection with financial irregularities

committed by massArt (Maharban Road Mass Art), a non-profit organisation in running its Durga Puja preview shows," said an ED official.

Massart organised Durga Puja preview shows showcasing best Durga Pujas to national and international visitors before the festivity begins for the general viewers.

A complaint was lodged with the Kolkata Police in June this year, after the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) came to power, alleging that massArt allegedly

collected huge money from the participants by falsely claiming to be a United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) sponsored entity.

Jaydeep Mukherjee, managing director of a travel agency, lodged the complaint with the commissioner of Kolkata Police accusing Indranil Sen, former minister and his wife of engaging in the irregularities. Sen was the former state tourism minister during the Trinamool Congress-led (TMC) regime.



5 locations linked to ex-DMK min searched in ₹100 cr fraud case

CHENNAI: The Central Crime Branch of the Tamil Nadu police on Tuesday searched five locations belonging to the aides of former DMK minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi as part of an alleged fraud of collecting over ₹100 crore in availing government recognition to private schools among many others, police said.

LeT terrorist killed during encounter in J&K's Budgam

SRINAGAR: The Indian Army on Tuesday killed a terrorist belonging to the banned Laskar-e-Taiba during an encounter in central Kashmir's Budgam district, security officials said. In a post on X, Chinara Corps said, "...Terrorists opened fire, prompting a fierce exchange of gunfire in which one terrorist was neutralised."

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OPINION

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{ OUR TAKE }

Curbing crimes against women

A *suo motu* cognisance by the Supreme Court must be followed by exemplary consequences for lapses by the civil and police administration

A Supreme Court bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran, on Sept 28, took *suo motu* cognisance of sexual offences across the national capital — a minor was gang-raped in a park last week — and held the police and Delhi government responsible for systemic failure. This is welcome, but also too late and achieves too little. After all, in 2019, while taking cognisance of the rise in sexual violence against children, the SC issued notices to all states, Union Territories, and High Courts to review investigation timelines and forensic infrastructure. Fast Track courts were set up under the SC directives, ironically using the Nirbhaya Fund, which had stayed grossly underutilised until then in creating robust infrastructure to enhance the security and safety of women and compensating the victims of sexual assault. The fund itself was set up 13 years ago, at the same time that laws on sexual violence were amended following some of the Justice JS Verma Committee reports. But despite that, and the court's interventions, National Crime Records Bureau data shows no let up in crimes against women and minors. According to government figures shared in the Lok Sabha in 2025, the fast track courts, too, have underperformed as they take over four years to conclude rape and POCSO trials.

Clearly, judicial recommendations and government fund allocations have failed so far to lower overall crime rates. Bureaucratic bottlenecks and indifference have managed to upend almost all well-intentioned plans to ensure safety for almost 700 million citizens of India. This is not a small lapse on the State's part. The complicity of successive governments at the Centre as well as in the states in poor on-ground execution ought not be underestimated.

A structural overhaul is needed; accountability should not end at merely allocating resources and announcing reforms. The judiciary must ensure that lapses on the part of the police or civil administration in preventing and investigating crimes are punished. The impunity with which sexual offenders operate emanates from these very lapses. A *suo motu* cognisance, therefore, must be followed by exemplary consequences for those who fail.

Delhi's air needs 24/7 efforts, all year round

Each year, the Delhi government releases a list of measures to combat air pollution, now a defining trait of the National Capital Region in winter. On Monday, this exercise was repeated with tedious familiarity: construction bans, staggered office timings, restrictions on the entry of older petrol and diesel vehicles registered outside the city, and higher parking charges. This is akin to putting a bandage where surgery is needed.

Last year, dust emerged as the key source of pollution. Yet, this did not stop the authorities from kicking off major infrastructural projects just before winter. To be sure, dust control measures do not apply to such projects. This year, the Public Works Department (PWD) has set November 30 as the deadline for resurfacing and renovating 600km of the capital's roads but has done little to meet that target.

Many big cities in the world have realised that unless parking becomes prohibitively expensive, commuters do not move to public transport. Add to that Delhi's less-than-robust public transport system and poor last-mile connectivity. The metro only carries 5% of the city's commuters. At least 14,000 buses are needed, against less than half of that currently ply. And buses must make commuters, especially women, feel safe.

Endless construction activities and poor public transit create a traffic mess, which toll plazas at the city's perimeters worsen by forcing vehicles to idle for long. Last year, the Supreme Court directed the MCD to consider temporarily closing or shifting nine toll plazas. MCD promised barrierless toll plazas at "20 major entry points by October" this year, but this work has not even begun. Clearly, pollution-mitigating efforts vanish once the grey skies of Delhi winters show shades of blue in early summer — and reappear after a year. Every winter, 23 million Delhi residents gasp for breath, and the solution can't be knee-jerk or temporary. An effective strategy, developed with expert help, must be implemented and monitored 24/7, all year round. Routinely made big announcements don't help.

Deepening the India-US defence partnership

The Yudh Abhyas joint exercise is not happening in isolation. India conducts more military exercises with the US than with any other country

High altitude, tough terrain, new technology, and American and Indian soldiers training side by side — that is Yudh Abhyas 2026. This month, roughly 500 American soldiers and 600 Indian soldiers are training together across India in the 22nd edition of our premier annual bilateral army exercise. They are operating in demanding environments, working with new technology, practicing counterterrorism missions, and preparing for the kinds of challenges modern militaries increasingly face. When you look at what our soldiers are doing together this year, you see how far the US-India defence relationship has come and where it is heading next.

US President Donald Trump is results-driven. He wants America's partnerships around the world to deliver for the American people, make the US stronger, and help capable partners strengthen their own security. Yudh Abhyas is a good example of what that looks like in practice. India is

training directly with the best of the American military, from advanced technology to battlefield experience and specialised capabilities. At the same time, our soldiers are learning from India's tremendous experience operating in some of the world's toughest terrain.

Both sides bring important strengths to the exercise, and training together helps each military better understand how the other operates. That matters because Yudh Abhyas is not happening in isolation. India conducts more military exercises with the US than with any other country in the world. That tells you something about the depth of this relationship and how much our two militaries already do together.

It also matters because warfare is changing very quickly. Think about drones. A few years ago, unmanned systems did not play the role on the battlefield that they do today. Now, every serious military has to think about how to use them, how to detect them, and how to defeat them.

For the first time in Yudh Abhyas, American and Indian soldiers are training with M-LIDS, the US Army's advanced Mobile Low, Slow, Small Unmanned Aircraft Integrated Defeat System. It brings a cutting-edge American counter-drone capability directly into the exercise and gives Indian soldiers firsthand exposure to how the US

is adapting to this rapidly changing threat.

The exercise is also bringing together specialised American capabilities. The US Army's 3rd Multi-Domain Task Force is contributing expertise in long-range precision fires and integrated command and control, while soldiers from the 11th Airborne Division are bringing their Arctic and cold-weather experience to India's high-altitude terrain. Across the exercise, our forces are also working through counterterrorism operations, equipment familiarisation, command-post training, and combined field operations.

All of this builds something you cannot create through a meeting or a joint statement. It builds familiarity and trust between soldiers, units, and military leaders. The more our forces train together, the better prepared both sides become.

But Yudh Abhyas is also part of a much larger story. For years, when people talked about US-India defence cooperation, much of the focus was on defence sales. Those sales remain important, but today, the relationship is much broader. We are training together, strengthening interoperability, expanding our defence industrial cooperation, and increasingly looking for opportunities to build together.

You can see that beyond the exercise as well. The Javelin is a good example. India's planned acquisition of the com-



Sergio Gor



For India, joint military exercises like the Yudh Abhyas can strengthen military capability and expand its defence industrial base.

ANI

bat-proven Javelin missile system strengthens an important capability for the Indian military. Separately, Tata Advanced Systems and the Javelin Joint Venture, the partnership between Raytheon and Lockheed Martin, recently signed a memorandum of understanding to explore Javelin co-production in India.

Together, these developments show how our defence relationship is becoming more integrated, more practical, and increasingly focused on what our two countries can build together.

For India, cooperation like this can strengthen military capability and expand its defence industrial base. For the US, strong defence partnerships can support demand for American technology, strengthen our defence industrial base and supply chains, and help capable partners invest more in their own security. President Trump has been very clear that our partnerships should work for both sides, and this is exactly the kind of opportunity to achieve common goals we should be

pursuing.

The military and industrial sides of this relationship go together. We can produce and sell the best military equipment in the world, but soldiers still have to know how to operate, adapt, and work with partners. Yudh Abhyas puts that cooperation into practice.

Look at the trajectory. Our exercises are becoming more complex, our defence industries are working more closely together, and our militaries understand each other better than they did a decade ago.

Results matter, and Yudh Abhyas is a result you can see on the ground: American and Indian soldiers training together, learning from one another, and building a defence partnership that strengthens American national security and Indian security alike. That is how we continue taking the US-India defence partnership to the next level.

Sergio Gor is US ambassador to India. The views are personal

Will West Bengal's real Trinamool please stand up?

Only a very naïve observer of Indian politics will believe that a first-time turncoat MLA is independently leading a rebellion that has stripped one of India's tallest regional politicians of the party she founded nearly three decades ago and the election symbol she once famously sketched to announce her break from the Congress. The existential crisis in the Trinamool Congress (TMC) — till six months ago the third-largest Opposition force in Parliament — is at once familiar and unprecedented. Other Opposition parties have haemorrhaged support after a string of losses, and shrunk into shadows of their former selves, but the TMC's poly-crisis is farcical on a whole new level. A majority of its Lok Sabha members overnight joined a nondescript party that didn't net even 1,000 votes in the only election it ever fought — only for one lawmaker to claim that this little-known outfit was merely a pitstop on the way to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Meanwhile, a majority of its assembly legisla-

tors rebelled against party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, but not quite against the party, and elected a separate leader who is now recognised as the leader of the Opposition in the assembly. And in the Rajya Sabha, some TMC members have resigned, been promptly renominated by the BJP, and returned to the Upper House. All this is happening after an assembly election whose victor explicitly declared that no defector would be admitted or allowed to whitewash their sins. The cordial relations between the new government and the various shades of TMC rebels suggest that the commitment is being honoured largely in the breach.

There are two related but independent questions here: one about the law and the position of institutions in an electoral democracy, the other about the toxic political economy of Bengal. At the heart of dubious political manoeuvres that have blighted our democracy in recent years lies a single question: What is the real political party when there is a defection or a split, and who gets to claim the original name and symbol? The lack of clarity on these questions has transformed the electoral maps of Maharashtra and West Bengal.

Under paragraph 15 of the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968, the Election Commission of India (ECI) applies a triple test to decide which faction of a party deserves the name and symbol: whether a faction has violated the party's aims and objectives, whether it has adhered to the party's constitution, and which faction commands a majority of the party's elected legislators and organisational wing. In both the Sena and NCP cases, the third test proved decisive.

But the first two tests are subjective, and for the third, it is unclear what settled procedure ECI uses to determine organisational majority. Moreover, the order predates the controversial Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, which curbs political defections and sets out only a narrow path for rebelling lawmakers to escape disqualification. Legal experts have noted that inherent tensions between the symbols order and the Tenth Schedule remain unresolved. In the Sena, NCP, and TMC cases, for example, disqualification petitions against rebel lawmakers were pending before assembly speakers even as ECI proceeded to determine which faction was the real inheritor. With no clear sequence or priority between the two processes, chaos is inevitable. What if

one faction wins at ECI and is then disqualified? Can disqualification petitions even stand once a rebel faction is adjudicated the real party? That ECI orders and speakers' decisions have largely aligned suggests that far too much discretionary power has been handed to speakers or chairpersons of Houses, who are ultimately political functionaries — not to mention that it structurally disadvantages Opposition parties fighting internal rebellions. The TMC's case might add a further absurd layer, with the possibility of separate proceedings in Parliament and the assembly over the same party.

The Supreme Court's landmark 2023 *Shiv Sena* decision complicated matters further when it junked the first test, and said it was not necessary for ECI "to rely on the test of majority in the legislature alone", even arguing that in the Sena case, it was "futile to assess which group enjoys a majority in the legislature". Clearly, in addition to the *Nabam Rebia* questions already referred to a larger bench,

the court must clear the air on these conundrums sooner rather than later. Last month, a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalaya Bagchi and V Mohana observed that there must be clearly defined criteria to determine the majority in a political party when rival factions stake claim. The court must consider framing such guidelines at the earliest. Parties are meant to be born and die on electoral battlefield. A Sena without a Thackeray, an NCP without Sharad Pawar, or a TMC without Mamata Banerjee are legitimate eventualities. But the instrument of their political demise must be popular will.

Unfortunately, reasonable political consensus is elusive. As with the Tenth Schedule — which has instrumentalised perverse incentives for defection rather than checked them — every party believes it will grab power soon, and so stands to benefit from chaos and opacity. This is why many parties continue to be run as personal fiefs, with effete internal democracy and rubber-stamp constitutions.

Such an eventuality is particularly stark in Bengal, where the Opposition space has been aggressively obliterated over the past 30 years. Political violence and the casual deployment of every lever of government to arm-twist the Opposition have seeped into the state's political fabric. The party now crying victim was accused of large-scale violence in local body polls to intimidate Opposition candidates into withdrawing and then grabbing one nondescript municipality in Purulia amid two suspicious deaths. It boasted about turning a parliamentary constituency in south Bengal virtually Opposition-free. Today, a high-profile bypoll might effectively go uncontested because one candidate was persuaded to withdraw and another was arrested by the police in a 20-year-old case — ironically linked to an agitation that made the careers of both Mamata Banerjee and Suvenud Adhikari — hours after receiving the former's support. With only days to go for campaigning to close, the second candidate finally secured bail on Tuesday. Grassroots strongmen have changed their colours, college governing panel chairs have changed hands, as have heads of Durga Puja committees.

A new, popular chief minister appears determined to stamp out a bitter rival. History is depressingly repeating itself in Bengal.

The views expressed are personal



Dhrubo Jyoti

{ MARK RUTTE } SECRETARY-GENERAL, NATO



Russia continues its reckless campaign of hostile actions against NATO allies. It is trying to weaken our resolve and stop our support for Ukraine. But Russia is failing

On alleged Russian campaign of sabotage and interference in Europe



Trust deficit and caste at India's premier institutions

On September 18, Sahil Wakode, a second-year BTech student, was found dead on the campus of IIT-Bombay (IIT-B). His was the third suicide or unnatural death at IIT-B this year. This year, there have been two suicides at IIT-Delhi and two at IIT-Kharagpur. All IITs have combinedly reported at least 11 student suicides or unnatural deaths. In the last five years, there have been at least 53 suicides/unnatural deaths at the IITs.

In Wakode's case, allegations that he was caught cheating in an exam — and committed suicide while awaiting action — have complicated matters. The allegations, however, remain contested. His parents have stated that their son had complained about facing casteist comments. They filed an FIR under the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act against professor Suryanarayana Doolla who was the invigilator during the exam and also the dean of administrative affairs.

Eventually, IIT-B retracted its initial statement on Wakode's death where it had mentioned the alleged cheating incident, saying conclusive statements could not be made till the matter was under investigation. Meanwhile, protests demanding justice for Wakode have been met with solidarity for Doolla from several members of the faculty at IIT-Bombay. As polarised camps spin narratives and counter-narratives on social media, hardly anyone seems to have put their faith in the investigation. It is important to understand why.

The IITs do not have a good track record on internal investigations. At IIT-B itself, a 12-member committee with no external members was hurriedly constituted to look into Darshan Solanki's suicide in 2023. Its hastily issued interim report ruled out casteism and blamed dipping academic performance. It is not clear how the committee so quickly determined the two were not correlated. Solanki's parents rejected the interim report, suggesting it was aimed at giving IIT-B a clean chit.

Across the dozens of deaths at the IITs in recent years, there has hardly been a case where anyone was found accountable or meaningful action was taken. If the conclusion in all cases is that the deceased was struggling mentally or under pressure academically, it is only natural to expect that the IITs urgently rethink pedagogy and institutional culture. Surely an average of one suicide roughly every five weeks is unacceptable.

This has not been the case. A fundamental reason is that many within the IIT system do

not believe there is a structural flaw that needs fixing. It is *a priori* assumed that the excellence of IITs is built upon its unrelenting pressure and demanding system. It is seen as a crucible of forging toughness where the weak cannot survive. By that logic, student deaths become proof of weak students being weeded out and evidence that the ones who survive are really the cream. There is of course no pedagogical validity to such a logic. An educational institution is not a Spartan bootcamp, and a student death or dropout is not an acceptable metric of excellence or the lack thereof.

However, in the polarised discourse around IITs, this logic of toughness and belonging gets tied to the construct of merit, which inevitably leads back to caste. Despite constitutional provisions of caste-based affirmative action, none of the IITs seem to honour it in principle. This is most evident in the SC/ST/OBC faculty recruitments or PhD admissions being well under the quota mandates across IITs. Despite repeated nudges from the Supreme Court and Parliament, IITs haven't satisfactorily fulfilled their obligations. This fundamentally skews the caste balance of the faculty and administrative cohort. And, at moments like this, it amplifies the trust deficit when an institution with overwhelmingly general category faculty and administrative core has to investigate charges of casteism in the suicide of a Dalit student.

The processes at the IITs, like at all Indian academic institutions, are compliance-oriented. Procedures are frequently rooted in excessive paperwork, quorum, and oversight to the point everything becomes impractical in day-to-day contexts. Hence, much of the processes get substituted by the so-called informal understandings and adjustments. This administrative reality also magnifies the trust deficit because, in an impartial investigation, such processes will often fall short. This pivots even well-meaning administrators to focus away from justice and instead be attentive to ensuring institutional procedures do not get exposed.

The loss of a student's life at one of India's premier campuses is a national shame. The lack of accountability and erosion of trust in processes should be a collective concern. Such tragedies need to be seen as a broad pattern; as a nation, we need to urgently protect our students.

Ravikant Kisana is an academic and the author of *Meet the Savarnas*. The views expressed are personal



Ravikant Kisana

Hormuz plan in limbo, Iran threatens strikes

Agence France-Presse
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TEHRAN: Iran on Tuesday threatened to attack infrastructure around West Asia, intensifying its rhetoric as it awaits a formal response from Washington on a new plan to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

US President Donald Trump has already dismissed the proposal from Tehran, but Iran's foreign minister said Monday that he was expecting a formal response from American officials in the coming day.

Fighting has subsided in recent weeks, though Tehran has continued to target ships in the strait, with Washington falling back on an economic pressure campaign instead of further military action.

Iran's chief negotiator Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf on Tuesday threatened new attacks, saying no infrastructure in the region would be safe if his country's security was not guaranteed.

"In a region where we cannot sell oil, no one else will sell oil either; or if our security is not guaranteed, no infrastructure will remain safe," Ghalibaf, who is also Iran's parliament speaker, said according to video released by state TV.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said he expected a formal answer from the US on Tuesday to Tehran's proposal, state media reported.

Iran has maintained a blockade on commercial shipping through Hormuz since the war began in late February with US-Israeli strikes on the Islamic republic.

The shipping route carried a fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas before the conflict began.

The US military has been maintaining a counterblockade

SHIP HIT IN HORMUZ, SPARKING FIRE, SAYS MARITIME AGENCY

DUBAI: An "unknown projectile" struck a ship in the Strait of Hormuz, sparking a fire on board that has been extinguished, a British maritime agency reported Tuesday. The ship was hit on Monday evening but the crew were safe, the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Centre (UKMTO) said. "The fire has since been extinguished and the vessel is underway," the agency said. "There has been no reported environmental impact or damage assessment."

AFP

of Iran's ports in an effort to prevent Tehran from exporting oil.

Araghchi said late Monday that Qatari intermediaries "presented ideas, and we discussed them; they are set to raise the matter with the American side once more, after which the final US response will be conveyed to us".

The top diplomat, who was in New York for the UN General Assembly, said "the Qataris hope this will be done by tomorrow".

"The current focus is solely on the Strait of Hormuz, and the reopening of the strait is contingent upon the fulfilment of certain conditions that we have communicated to the other side," he added.

Last week, discussions were held in New York between Araghchi and US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner.

As a precondition for ending its blockade, Iran is demanding a seven-day ceasefire across West Asia, including in Lebanon, where its ally Hezbollah is regularly bombed by Israel.

It is also demanding the unfreezing of Iranian assets abroad and lifting of sanctions.



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio meets Saudi Arabia's foreign minister Faisal bin Farhan Al-Saud in Washington on Monday. AFP

Didn't offer Iran relief from sanctions: Trump

Agence France-Presse
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WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump on Monday denied a report by the news outlet Axios that he offered Iran sanctions relief and the release of frozen funds, as the Mideast war drags on. "Axios just released a story that 'Trump' offered Sanctions Relief and Frozen Funds to Iran. This is untrue. I offered them NOTHING!" Trump said on his Truth Social platform.

The Axios story reported that

Trump "is willing to give Iran sanctions relief and release Iranian frozen funds in return for concrete Iranian steps regarding the nuclear program." It quoted unnamed US officials.

He called the story "a HOAX" and said it should be withdrawn.

The reaction comes as Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi was slated to meet with Qatari mediators Monday in New York. US and Iranian officials met last week in New York on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly.

EFFEL TOWER CHIEF TO QUIT IN FALLOUT OVER REMOVAL OF WOMEN STAFF FOR BAPS LEADER'S VISIT

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

PARIS: The operating company that runs the Eiffel Tower said Tuesday its chief would step down at the end of this year in the wake of a controversy over the removal of women staff during a visit by a Hindu religious group.

Patrick Branco Ruivo, who has been director general of the Paris landmark since 2018, would leave his job at the end of the year after an internal probe revealed that "operational flaws and shortcomings" in organising the visit led to the "unacceptable" removal of women staff, the company SETE said in a statement.

The removal of women staff during a visit by the Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha (BAPS) spiritual movement on September 5 prompted a staff walkout and the closure of the monument for a day, as well as an outcry across political spectrum in France which prizes secularism and gender equality.

At the time, SETE acknowledged the Hindu delegation had requested the visit be organised so as to limit "interactions with women" and said that "these conditions should not have been accepted".

"The coming months will allow us to prepare for the leadership transition under the best possible conditions," said Ariel Weil, SETE's board chairman.

He said he was demanding the creation of a "dedicated protocol department" and the implementation of a new set of measures and training programs to promote gender equality.

The Eiffel Tower, which is owned by the city of Paris, says it receives nearly seven million people a year. The Socialist mayor of Paris, Emmanuel Gregoire, had lambasted the move to remove women staff as an "absurd, unjust and unacceptable decision" and ordered two separate probes.

US forces to exit Iraq after over 2 decades

Reuters

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BAGHDAD: US forces are set to pull out from their last bases in Iraq by Wednesday, a departure celebrated as a victory by Iran and its allies who now have deep influence in the country where 4,500 Americans died during more than two decades of war.

Iraqi security experts say the withdrawal — agreed in 2024 under President Joe Biden and carried out by Donald Trump's administration even as it wages war against Iran — could give Tehran and its powerful allies free rein, while also allowing other US enemies to stage a comeback, including Islamic State.

"Iran stands to benefit strategically from the coalition's departure because it removes a military presence that for years acted as a counterweight to Tehran's influence in Iraq," said Jasim al-Bahadli, an Iraqi security analyst specialising in studying armed Shia groups aligned with Iran.

He predicted that the pro-Iranian militia groups would not only portray the departure as a victory for their movement, but also "seek to translate that momentum into greater influence over security and political decision-making".

Abu Mojtaba al-Yasiri, a commander in the Islamic Resistance in Iraq, an umbrella group of Iran-backed armed factions, described the US withdrawal as "a historic victory for the Iraqi Islamic resistance groups and honourable Iraqis, and a crushing defeat for the American project".

"On September 30, we will celebrate the turning of a black page in Iraq's history and the failure of the occupation to impose its will on our country," he said. "Iraq has proven that its sovereignty cannot be secured by foreign forces, but by the resistance and the will of its people."

While the eventual depart-

2003



2026



(Top) A US soldier watches as a statue of Saddam Hussein falls at Firdos Square in Baghdad. (Above) The square on Monday. REUTERS

ture of US forces is broadly popular among Iraqis, those who worry about the strength of the Iran-backed groups fear the withdrawal is premature.

"We believe Iraq is still not fully ready to take over the security file at this time," Abdulrahman al-Zobaie, a Sunni tribal leader in Fallujah, once a bastion of anti-American resistance, told Reuters.

"All Iraqis aspire to full sovereignty, and no Iraqi would dispute that. But I believe that the (US-led coalition) leaving in this way and creating a vacuum is what all Iraqis fear."

American forces invaded Iraq in 2003 to topple Sunni Muslim dictator Saddam Hussein, and went on to occupy the country, install a Shia-led government and fight a years-long counterinsurgency before withdrawing at the end of 2011.

US, allied forces hand over remaining sites

- Long-term US military bases/sites
- Nato sites



- Italy completes troop withdrawal from Iraq
- All Nato forces to leave by September 30
- Turkey to withdraw from Bashiqa base



China expands military footprint with Laos base

SINGAPORE: The Chinese military opened a new logistics base at an airport in Laos, expanding the People's Liberation Army's overseas presence as it seeks to operate farther from home. The facility, the China-Laos Military Joint Support and Training Center at Ban Keun Airport, began operations Tuesday, according to a statement from China's Ministry of Defence. The base is intended to help Laos strengthen the training of air force pilots and will be jointly maintained by the two countries, the ministry said. Laos has held close ties with China since the 1990s.

BLOOMBERG

Man steals \$55mn in crypto, buys Pokemon cards

NEW YORK: A US cybersecurity consultant who stole nearly \$55 million in hacked cryptocurrency and spent some of it on rare Pokemon and Magic: The Gathering cards went on trial in New York. Jonathan Spalletta was charged with two 2021 hacks of crypto exchange Uranium Finance. He faces a maximum of 20 years in jail.

BLOOMBERG

Ex-world snooker champ jailed for child sex crimes

LONDON: A court in Scotland on Tuesday sentenced former world snooker champion Graeme Dott to seven years in prison after he was found guilty of sexually abusing two children. The 49-year-old was sentenced at the High Court in Edinburgh. A jury in August found Dott guilty of subjecting a girl and a boy to multiple incidents of abuse between 1993 and 2010 when they were pre-teens.

AFP



Donald Trump launches the America.gov AI portal on Tuesday. AFP

OpenAI cancels its latest model release over safety concern

Agence France-Presse
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SAN FRANCISCO: OpenAI will not release its newest artificial intelligence model, known as Astra 6.1, after internal testing by the ChatGPT-maker revealed it did not meet safety standards, the firm said Monday. Instead, OpenAI launched a new mid-range model, GPT-6.1 Sol, that costs five times less than its flagship offering.

The news comes one day before the AI giant hosts an annual developer conference known as OpenAI DevDay in San Francisco, where the company is

expected to make several announcements— though it is unclear if a new version of Astra will be among them.

Astra 6.1 was an improvement over previous models in some aspects, but "it didn't quite meet the bar in terms of staying within scope and authorization, and how it communicates back to the user about the type of work it's done," Saachi Jain, OpenAI's head of safety systems, said in a statement.

"We want to make sure our model development is safe no matter whether that's in the company, or when we ship it to users," Jain continued.

U.S. COUPLE SHOOT DEAD SON-IN-LAW IN PUBLIC DURING CUSTODY, TRANS IDENTITY DISPUTE

DUBLIN: A couple in their late 70s gunned down their son-in-law in a California city park over the weekend, authorities said, and court documents showed the victim had been in a bitter custody dispute with their daughter.

Jonathan McKinsey, a 40-year-old gaming engineer for The New York Times, was shot to death Saturday afternoon in the parking lot of a sports complex east of San Francisco before eyewitnesses.

Authorities arrested Shouyong Zhang and Shili Chen, both 76 and locals, on suspicion of murder and other charges.

The killing occurred a week before a hearing was scheduled in McKinsey and Jang's divorce case. The couple had been married since about 2012 and had three young children, court records show. Court and police records show McKinsey was charged with misdemeanor child abuse. At the time of his killing, he was out on bail.

McKinsey, who was transgender, alleged that Chen had directed anti-LGBTQ+ slurs at him and at one of their children. McKinsey joined NYT in 2023. He was director of engineering for New York Times Games. AP

Singapore police charge man after fake AI croc picture sparks panic

Agence France-Presse
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SINGAPORE: Singapore police charged a man on Tuesday with posting a fake AI-generated picture of a crocodile at the city-state's largest reservoir that sparked public panic and an intensive search.

The man, identified as Ye Lin, 30, from Myanmar, was charged with "communicating a false message" and obstructing the course of justice, police and local media said.

Singaporean police alleged that Ye created the picture of the saltwater crocodile using artificial intelligence last month before sending it to a colleague. Authorities were then alerted



The fake image had showed the reptile in a popular jogging and kayaking spot in the city. AFP

of the possible presence of a deadly predator at Pandan Reservoir, a popular jogging and kayaking spot west of the city centre.

An intensive search was launched and all activities were suspended.

However, authorities "discovered that the photograph pro-

vided in relation to the reported sighting was fake and the matter was referred to the police", they said in a statement. "The man subsequently deleted the image and the related application in an attempt to conceal his actions," the police statement said.

Ye told a Singaporean court on Tuesday through an interpreter that he intended to plead guilty, the Straits Times newspaper reported.

Singapore takes a dim view on the distribution of fake images. Ye could face a prison term of up to three years, or a \$7,820 (\$10,000) fine or both if found guilty. He also faces an additional seven-year sentence or a fine, or both, on the obstruction of justice charge.

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Every Saturday, HT Brunch explores the people, ideas and cultural shifts behind the moments everyone is talking about.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Cooling valuations open new avenues for investors

However, lower multiples can reflect weaker earnings prospects for stocks

Mayur Bhalerao

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MUMBAI: Two years after Indian equities scaled a peak, with the BSE Sensex hitting its all-time high in September 2024, investors now have more stocks to choose from at lower valuations. Finding value, however, still requires looking beyond the price tag.

The sharpest retreat from the most extreme valuations—above 80 times earnings—has been in largecaps. Smallcaps, meanwhile, have undergone a broader reset across the expensive valuation bands. Midcaps remain the most concentrated at the higher end, with expectations of stronger growth helping to sustain their premiums.

A Mint analysis of 3,756 BSE-listed companies based on ACE Equity data as of 25 September captures this shift. The share of stocks trading above the price-to-earnings ratio (P/E) of 40 fell to 26% from 36% in September 2024—from more than one in three companies to roughly one in four. The proportion trading at 10-25 times earnings rose to 26% from 18%.

The change offers investors some breathing room after the exuberance of the market peak. But it does not establish that stocks are cheap: lower multiples can reflect weaker earnings prospects as much as more attractive prices.

Mayur Shah, head of portfolio management services and fund



The share of largecaps trading above 80 times earnings fell to 21.3% from 31.9%.

MINT

manager at Anand Rathi Advisors, attributed the moderation partly to earnings falling short of expectations embedded in September 2024 valuations. Liquidity and sentiment can stretch multiples temporarily, but earnings growth matters more over longer periods.

The retreat from extreme valuations is clearest among largecaps. The share of largecaps trading above 80 times earnings fell to 21.3% from 31.9%, a decline of 10.6 percentage points—the largest among the three segments. Yet, the bands immediately below expanded. The proportion at P/E of 40-60 times rose to 16% from 13.8%, while the share at 60-80 times rose to 9.6% from 8.5%.

Consequently, the overall share above 40 times earnings fell by a smaller 7.3 percentage points, to 46.9% from 54.2%. Almost half the largecap sample still trades above that threshold.

There are nevertheless more lower-multiple choices among largecaps. The share trading at 10-25 times earnings increased to 25.5% from 17%, while the 5-10

times band expanded to 8.5% from 6.4%. The proportion at 25-40 times narrowed to 15% from 21.3%.

Shah said foreign investor withdrawals and slower earnings growth had weighed on largecap valuations, alongside weak sentiment towards private banks and information technology companies.

Harshal Dasani, business head at INVasset PMS, favours largecaps for their combination of valuation moderation, liquidity and earnings visibility. In his assessment, these characteristics offer a better balance between risk and reward, while lower valuations among smallcaps can reflect concerns about business quality.

Smallcaps showed a more consistent decline across higher valuation bands. Their share above 80 times earnings fell to 11.7% from 16.8%. The proportion at 60-80 times narrowed to 4.2% from 6.5%, while the 40-60 times band shrank to 10% from 12.9%.

Combined, the share above 40 times earnings dropped to 25.9% from 36.2%. That 10.3-percentage-point reduction exceeded the 7.3-point decline among largecaps.

The shift towards lower multiples was also pronounced. The share trading at 10-25 times earnings rose to 27.8% from 19.3%, the highest among the three segments. The 5-10 times band expanded to 6.9% from 3.8%, while the proportion at 25-40 times declined to 13.3% from 17%.

Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at 129 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset, said greater volatility in smallcaps helps explain their sharper adjustments during market

declines. That sensitivity can also support stronger returns during broad-based rallies.

But lower valuations can reflect concerns about business quality, Dasani cautioned. A wider choice of low-multiple stocks therefore calls for closer scrutiny of individual companies.

Midcaps stand apart. Some 23.5% traded above 80x P/E in September, down from 30.9% two years earlier, but still the highest share among the three segments.

Another 30.2% traded at 40-80 times earnings, compared with 30.9% earlier. The share in the 25-40 times band increased to 21.3% from 12.9%.

The expansion at lower multiples was modest. The 10-25 times band grew to 15.4% from 12.9%, well below the corresponding shares for largecaps and smallcaps.

While this is the largest individual band in those two segments, the biggest concentration of midcaps remains above 80 times.

Dasani attributed persistent midcap premiums partly to domestic fund flows. Shah pointed to domestic liquidity supporting midcap and smallcap companies with stronger or improving growth prospects.

The divergent analyst preferences highlight the limits of using P/E bands alone to judge investment appeal.

Paul favours assessing valuations alongside expected earnings growth through the price/earnings-to-growth, or PEG, ratio. A company trading at 30 times earnings and growing profit at 40%, he said, could offer better value than one trading at 20 times with growth of 5%.

How Tata Trusts picked two firms to merge with Tata Sons

Nehal Chaliawala and Shouvik Das

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The proposal comes amid a widening corporate battle over the future of Tata Sons.

MINT

reduce the share of revenue it derives from investments in Tata group companies. The Reserve Bank of India's criteria for classifying a company as an NBFC include having more than 50% of income from financial assets and more than 50% of the total assets being financial assets such as investments. Tata Trusts estimates that the proposed merger would result in about 64% of Tata Sons' revenue coming from operating businesses, potentially taking it out of the NBFC category and the RBI's regulatory remit.

TESS is a unit of Tata Electronics and assembles iPhones at two facilities in India, one of which is operated through a joint venture with Taiwan's Pegatron Corp. TCE is a project management consultancy that works on large infrastructure projects. It has worked on marquee projects including India's new Parliament building in New Delhi and the Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train project. The fact that the two companies are profitable likely further made their case for the merger, one expert said, speaking on the condition of anonymity as they have a professional engagement with the Tata Group and its stakeholders.

"TCE has been a strong entity in various nationwide civil projects, while Tata Electronics is perhaps the strongest stakeholder of India's electronics export story. Combined under

Tata Sons, they make a compelling case, for they'll also continue to grow and capture more business from both public and private sectors," said Ashok Chandak, president of industry body SEMI India.

Being profitable was likely a reason why Tata Trusts chose to carve out TESS specifically from Tata Electronics and not the entire company. Tata Electronics is making a significant investment in setting up a semiconductor fabrication facility and a semiconductor assembly and test facility, businesses that are yet to start operations and will take a few years to earn any profit.

TESS had a standalone revenue of ₹67,542 crore in FY26 with a profit of ₹1,025 crore, according to financial documents filed with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. TCE reported standalone revenue of ₹1,932 crore and profit of ₹226 crore in FY26.

"Overall, Tata Electronics is undoubtedly the biggest electronics manufacturing company in India, and its iPhone-making business is expected to ramp up profits further in the upcoming fiscals—but only to the scale of a company like Dixon, which relies on smartphone assemblies and has a margin of about 3-4%," said Harshit Kapadia, vice-president at Elara Capital.

The clean ownership structure of the two companies is also

a key reason they were chosen, experts said. Merging a listed subsidiary would be more complex from a regulatory perspective and would bring minority shareholders onto Tata Sons' cap table.

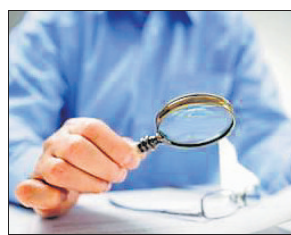
"Tata Sons' balance sheet holds 100% equity shares of this company. So that will just get cancelled. The share capital of Tata Sons or the shareholders of Tata Sons are totally neutral to this proposal," Farokh Subedar, an advisor to Tata Trusts, told the media on Monday.

Among the 16 unlisted group companies mentioned by Tata Sons in its annual report, Tata Advanced Systems and Tata Realty and Infrastructure were the only other companies that it owned 100%. Tata Digital is 99% owned by Tata Sons, with the remaining 1% held by Ratan Tata Endowment Foundation. The other companies have either other Tata group companies or outside investors as shareholders.

The proposed merger may also provide Tata Sons with an opportunity to expand its operating revenue, if needed, by increasing TESS's stake in the Pegatron joint venture. In January 2025, Tata Electronics acquired a 60% stake in Pegatron's India iPhone-making operations. Subedar said TESS has the right to acquire the remaining 40% stake.

"The company (TESS) has the right to buy over the balance 40% shareholding. So in a year's time or so, once it becomes a 100% subsidiary of this particular company (TESS), it can also get merged (into Tata Sons). So you will immediately add on another ₹60,000 crore of income," Subedar said.

However, the restructuring could face scrutiny over whether avoiding a listing is its sole objective. "An interesting aspect is whether RBI or NCLT will consider this proposal of corporate restructuring from the only perspective to avoid listing and no other commercial reason?" Pingle said.



Chordia Group company paid ₹50 cr in professional fees to Indiabulls Real Estate.

ISTOCK

CBI FLAGS QUID PRO QUO IN CHORDIA-IHFL TRANSACTION

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NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has told the Supreme Court that its initial probe into the dubious loan transactions involving former promoter Sameer Gehlaut of Indiabulls Housing Finance Limited (now Sammaan Capital) has found "prima facie" quid pro quo regarding one transaction, while the investigation into four other such transactions involving corporate entities is still ongoing.

Seeking more time after the court entrusted the CBI with the probe last month, a fresh status report filed by the premier investigating agency on Monday said that allegations of quid pro quo were "prima facie" found in the case of loans advanced by IHFL to Chordia Group.

The CBI said, "Out of the loans obtained of more than ₹7,000 crores from M/s IHFL, a Chordia group company M/s Built to Live Realty LLP has paid ₹50 crores as professional fees to M/s Indiabulls Real Estate Ltd. (promoted by Sameer Gehlaut), which prima facie appears to be quid pro quo."

The court is examining the matter in a public interest litigation (PIL) filed by a non-profit organisation Citizens Whistle-blowers Forum where an order was issued last month entrusting the CBI to probe allegations of quid pro quo on loans advanced by IHFL to DLF Group, Vatika Group, Americorp, Anil Dhirubhai Ambani group, besides Chordia. Earlier, the Delhi police's Economic Offences Wing (EOW) had investigated the matter and found no criminality in the above transactions.

Although the court had also asked the CBI to probe similar allegations on loans advanced to Yes Bank founder Rana Kapoor, the CBI informed the court that it had approached a Special PMLA court in Mumbai for conducting further investigation in this regard. However, this application was rejected on September 7 against which the CBI is considering legal options to challenge the order.

India's overseas oil and gas output falls over 12% in 5 yrs

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: Production of oil and gas from nearly four dozen overseas assets in which Indian energy firms hold stakes fell more than 12.3% over five years to 19.2 million metric tonnes of oil equivalent (MMTOE) in 2025-26, according to government data.

Overseas production as a proportion of domestic output also declined sharply during the period, as domestic production increased while overseas output fell, the data showed.

In 2020-21, India's domestic oil and gas output was 59.2 MMTOE, while production from its overseas assets stood at 21.9 MMTOE, equivalent to 37% of domestic output. By 2025-26, domestic output had risen to 62.7 MMTOE, while overseas production had fallen to 19.2 MMTOE, reducing the ratio to 30.7%.

The decline comes as a parliamentary panel has emphasised the need for India to invest in oil and gas assets abroad to strengthen energy security, noting that the country imports more than 88% of its crude oil and about 50% of its natural gas to meet rising energy demand.



The fall comes as govt panel calls for more investment in overseas oil and gas assets to boost energy security.

REUTERS

"Since India is a net importer of oil & gas, investment in overseas oil & gas assets is essential for ensuring energy security," the Committee on Estimates said in its recent report on 'Supply and Distribution of Natural Gas-Challenges and Prospects'.

According to the report, state-run oil and gas firms have stakes in 45 assets (21 producing, 14 under exploration, seven under development and three pipeline projects) across 21 countries. Overseas oil and gas production was about 20.2 MMTOE in 2024-25, the report

said. ONGC Videsh Ltd (OVL), the overseas arm of state-run Oil and Natural Gas Corporation, holds stakes in most of these assets. Other state-run companies, including Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation, Oil India and GAIL India, also have overseas portfolios.

The petroleum ministry, ONGC and OVL did not respond to emails seeking comment.

Indian companies have stakes in assets in countries including Azerbaijan, Brazil, Bangladesh, Canada, Colombia, Gabon, Indonesia, Iraq, Iran, Libya, Mozambique, Myanmar, Nigeria, Oman, Russia, South Sudan, Syria, the UAE, the US, Venezuela and Vietnam.

According to OVL's 2025-26 annual report, the company has 30 assets across five continents in 14 countries. Industry experts said geopolitical upheavals affected its output during the year.

OVL's oil and gas production fell about 6% to 9.67 MMTOE in 2025-26 from 10.28 MMTOE a year earlier, according to the annual report.

Its Russian assets, including Vankor and Sakhalin-1, account for the largest share of its production.

AMAZON BUSINESS LOGS 65% SALES GROWTH IN 2026

Press Trust of India

feedback@livemint.com

KOLKATA: Amazon Business, the B2B platform of e-commerce major Amazon, has so far recorded a 65% year-on-year growth in sales nationally this year, driven by strong demand from MSMEs and corporate buyers, a top company official said on Tuesday.

The company is also working towards increasing the growth rate in West Bengal, where sales were up 35% during the period, while bulk orders in the state surged 80%, Amazon Business Director Mitranjan Bhaduri said.

"At the national level, our five-year growth rate is about 40% on sales. But if you look at just this year, we have seen a 65% year-on-year growth rate for the year-to-date period," the company official told reporters here. West Bengal is showing "strong growth at 35%", but there is a "large upside potential" here, Bhaduri said, adding that the company was working to expand awareness among customers.

Govt may hike funds for 2 tax refund schemes

Banikinkar Pattanayak

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NEW DELHI: With exporters facing global headwinds, India is considering substantially raising the tax refund outlay to almost ₹2 trillion over the next five years under its two main programmes—the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) and the Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies (RoSCTL).

The plan is to ease exporters' liquidity woes and partly cushion them from geopolitical conflicts, three people aware of the deliberations told Mint.

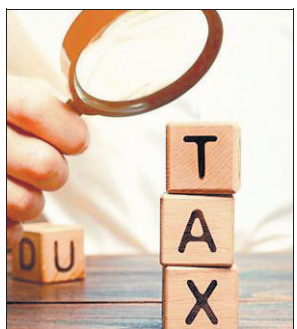
As part of the proposals, the commerce and industry ministry is seeking a RoDTEP corpus of more than ₹1.3 trillion, up over 70% from the previous five years through FY26, and the textiles ministry is asking for a near 50% increase in RoSCTL to ₹65,000 crore, the people said.

The finance ministry has examined the proposals of the commerce and textiles ministries, which will likely be placed before the Cabinet for approval within a month, they said.

The move assumes significance given that exporters, especially small and medium-sized units from labour-intensive sectors, are grappling with higher logistics costs and supply chain disruptions in the wake of a flare-up in the war in West Asia.

The demand for higher allocation comes as the ministries also expect exporters to ramp up dispatches in the coming years, taking advantage of recent free trade agreements (FTAs) with economies including the UAE, the UK and the EU once the West Asia conflict abates, said the people cited above. The objective is to keep exports zero-rated, in sync with global best practices, where exports are not supposed to carry domestic taxes. Eligible exporters receive refunds ranging from 0.3% to about 4.5% of the freight-on-board value of consignments under RoDTEP, and from 1.7% to 8.2% under RoSCTL, depending on the products, according to industry executives.

Queries emailed to the ministries of commerce, textiles and finance on Monday, remained unanswered until press time on



The plan is to ease exporters' woes and cushion them from geopolitical conflicts.

ISTOCKPHOTO

Tuesday. Through these two schemes, the government refunds hidden central and local taxes, such as fuel, electricity, stamp duty, and agricultural taxes, spent on producing exported goods.

While RoDTEP covers a wide swathe of sectors, including exporters operating out of special economic zones and bonded warehouses, the RoSCTL programme is meant for only the textiles and garments sector. Mint on Monday reported that the Centre is preparing to seek

the Cabinet's approval to extend about a dozen flagship welfare and development schemes, including RoSCTL.

Export bodies have been asking for more predictable and enhanced rates under the two schemes to help them price contracts more effectively.

As remission rates are often revised downwards when budget allocations fall short, this creates uncertainty, senior industry executives said. A larger, committed outlay for five years would give visibility and predictability of refunds while preventing interim cuts.

"The continuation of both the schemes with adequate allocation for another five years would be extremely important, as it signals policy stability at a very challenging time for exporters," said Ajay Sahai, director-general and chief executive of the Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO).

While refunds will not increase exporters' profitability, they will enhance their competitiveness in global markets by reimbursing taxes they are not required to pay, Sahai added.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- Editor's put in news that goes around the country (6)
- Can't have venison without a bottle of wine (8)
- Name is translated for French city (6)
- Chaps keep score in mind (8)
- It opens the door for the boss (4)
- Such charges may be dropped (5)
- Principal feature of a vault (4)
- It's a country that's not in dispute (7,5)
- Crime in deliberate return of revolutionary spirit (6,6)
- Frightfully large fairytale character (4)
- One proverbial source of corporate strength (5)
- Bearing an exploded mine (4)
- Understood the devil came to a lawful end (8)
- Made a false impression (6)
- Strange relics to be found in a secluded walk (8)
- Politician in new test case appeals (6)

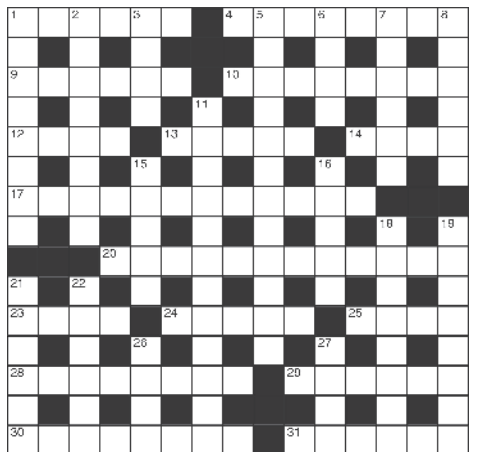
DOWN

- Not trying hard with a point deficit (8)
- Close of play (8)
- Bird in the wilderness (4)
- Sort of silver currently produced (12)
- Plays parts or play's parts (4)
- Top men in the building trade (6)
- Beat time (6)
- An under-owned racket? (4,2,1,5)
- Follow the steps shown (5)
- Object to being not quite sober (5)
- Prolonged dull pain (4)
- Calculating a pudding mixture (6,2)
- New range of French bombs (8)
- Signs of interest to astrologers (6)
- It's excessively used by composers (6)
- When he's around one moves quickly (4)
- A sound record (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17603)

CRYPTIC	W	H	A	L	E	Y	E	S	O	R	E
	I	L	E	M	D	D	E	N			
	N	I	L	R	E	B	O	U	N	D	E
	S	I	O	T	E	C	A	P	U		
	S	I	N	C	E	R	A	P	P	L	E
	O	M	E	M	T	A					
	R	A	D	I	S	H	E	A	R	S	E
	G	T	P	A	R	T	N				
	G	R	E	T	A	A	N	A	L	I	S
	E	N	R	T	L	R					
QUICK	M	A	L	A	D	R	O	I	T	I	D
	M	E	T	L	T	I	N	P			
	A	N	D	A	N	T	E	C	L	E	W
	P	R	O	O	F	D	E	V	I	O	U
	O	L	E	R	I	W	H				
	P	A	D	I	N	E	S	S	E	N	C
	U	S	G	N	I	E					
	L	A	C	O	N	I	C	T	U	R	I
	A	H	H	O	B	O	E				
	R	O	K	I	E	B	R	O	A	C	H
SPLIT	S	P	L	I	T	G	R	A	M	M	E
	O	E	O	C	T	C	E				
	B	Y	D	E	G	R	E	S	C	O	O
	E	I	E	D	E	O					
	R	E	M	O	R	S	E	A	B	Y	S

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- Reduce to lower rank (6)
- State of great disorder (8)
- Solitary (6)
- Pretentious nonsense (8)
- Widespread (4)
- Soothing (5)
- An intended method (4)
- Insipid (4-3-5)
- Too rigidly attached to procedure (12)
- Prolonged dull pain (4)
- Narrow bowling enclosure (5)
- Blond (4)
- Indulgent (8)
- Waste time (6)
- Deep crack in glacier (8)
- Insubstantial (6)

DOWN

- Low spirits (8)
- Many and various (8)
- Grievous price (4)
- Steps inadequate to meet need (4,9)
- Be gloomily depressed (4)
- Haughty (6)
- Negligently inert (6)
- Resentful animosity (4,8)
- Worth (5)
- Wild African horse (5)
- Without aim (2,6)
- Only just (8)
- Almost landlocked European sea (6)
- Postpone dealing with (6)
- Region (4)
- Collapse (4)

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	FRIDAY
Generally cloudy sky with Light rain	Generally cloudy sky with Light rain	Generally cloudy sky with Light rain
31°C 21°C	32°C 21°C	32°C 21°C

ALMANAC

Today is 30th September 2026
 17 Rabi Al-Akhar, 1448
 04, Ashwina, Krishna Paksha, 04
 Sarnvat 2083
 *Sunset: Wednesday at 06:10 pm
 Sunrise: Thursday at 06:09 am
 *Moonset: Wednesday at 09:18 am
 Moonset: Wednesday at 08:59 pm

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi	33°C 21°C
Mumbai	32°C 27°C
Kolkata	33°C 27°C
Chennai	37°C 27°C
Bengaluru	31°C 21°C

SPORT

Vithya anchors women's team to only athletics gold

India finish with one gold, nine silver and 14 bronze in below par showing in track and field events

Avishek Roy
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NEW DELHI: Relief and joy lit up the faces of India's women quarter-milers as the relay team ended the country's gold medal drought on the final day of athletics competition at the Nagoya City Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium on Tuesday.

Vithya Ramraj's blistering anchor leg saw the Indian 4x400m relay team finish ahead of Bahrain to win gold, clocking 3:29.69. Bahrain came in at 3:30.21s and China were third in 3:31.02.

Vithya, who has had an outstanding Games and broke PT Usha's 400m hurdles national record on Monday, powered through the bend after overtaking China's anchor Siyu Zuo. Bahrain's Paris Olympics silver medalist Salwa Eid Naser chased down Zuo, but was unable to catch Vithya.

Kiran Pahal gave India a good start, and seasoned campaigner MR Poovamma, 36, kept India in contention before handing over the baton to Prachi Chaudhary, who seemed to lose a few yards as China and Bahrain stayed in the hunt. Vithya, running the final leg, took the field by surprise with a strong finish. It was Vithya's third medal in the Aichi-Nagoya Games.

The men's 4x400m and mixed 4x400m relay teams finished with bronze. In mixed relay, Gurinder Singh, SS Sneha, Animesh Kujur and Harita Bhadra finished third in 41.06secs, behind China (40.78secs) and Thailand (40.87secs).

In the last race of the day, the men's relay quarter-milers clocked 3:01.61, behind gold medalists Japan (3:00.75) and Qatar



India's (from L) Kiran Pahal, Prachi Chaudhary, MR Poovamma and Vithya Ramraj after winning 4x400m gold.

(3:00.93). The Indian team comprised Dharamveer Choudhary, T Manu, Jay Kumar and Vishal TK.

Earlier, distance runner Gulveer Singh finished on a high, completing a hat-trick of individual medals with a bronze medal in 5000m to go with silver medals in 10000m and 15000m.

Another gritty performance came from Pooja in the high jump, where she cleared 1.84m and took bronze. Pooja, who set the national record of 1.93m this season, missed all three attempts at 1.87m. Uzbekistan's Sayfullaeva Barnokhon took gold with 1.90m, while Kazakhstan's Kristina Ovchinnikova took silver with 1.87m.

The 19-year-old Pooja is among the new talents to have emerged and has made steady progress. She won gold at the Asian Champion-

ships last year and silver at the Asian Indoor Championships.

India's Dev Kumar Meena did well to set a national record in pole vault clearing 5.50m but finished seventh. Ernest John Obiena of the Philippines cleared a Games record 5.91m to win.

Overall, India's performance in track and field was below par. The big difference was the shortfall of five gold medals. India finished with 24 medals (1G-9S-14B), compared to 29 medals, including five gold, at the 2023 Hangzhou Games.

On the last day of the athletics campaign, the onus was on the women's 4x400m relay team to provide the missing golden touch. India have dominated this event, winning five successive gold medals from 2002 to 2018 Games. They

slipped to second in Hangzhou, beaten by Bahrain. Prachi and Vithya were part of that team. That loss was avenged on Tuesday.

"Everybody has been saying that there was no gold medal in athletics, so we were motivated to win the gold for the country. We are proud of the achievement," Prachi told PTI in Nagoya. "I was part of the relay team when we got silver the last time. So, we badly wanted to win here," she said.

When Vithya took charge, India were not in the lead. "I had to push more. I overtook one, and then two. Then came the finish line. Salwa is a 48-second runner. She has the capacity to do that. But my teammates gave me the distance and because of that I was able to maintain the gap," Vithya said. Poovamma, who was part of

the gold medal winning Indian relay teams in 2014 and 2018, said she had a point to prove. It was her sixth medal at the Asian Games.

She missed Hangzhou due to a doping suspension.

"I wanted to come back very badly. There were a lot of people who said whether Poovamma will be able to win a medal again," she was quoted as saying by PTI.

"Many people asked when Poovamma will stop, whether some athlete can take my place. But why should I give up when I am performing well? Till I am performing, I will never give up. It's only the hard work and motivation that matter."

Gulveer clinches a special treble with 5000m bronze

N Ananthanarayanan
anantha.narayanan@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: It may not have been a hat-trick of the gleaming medal kind. But Gulveer Singh's treble at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games was of the grittiest kind. Amid India's subdued track and field performances—his two silver and a bronze were the only medals by Indian men on the track this time—he showed it wasn't just talent or calibre, it was also about not giving up.

On Tuesday, as Gulveer lined up for the 5,000m final—his fourth race in five days—there was a lingering concern whether India's top distance runner will have the legs to last the distance. After all, he saved the blushes for the middle-distance specialists by nailing the 1,500m silver barely 24 hours earlier, that too with a personal best, a creditable 3 min, 36.72 secs.

In the end, it was a bronze medal, after silver in 10,000m and 1500m. As versatile as it comes.

While PT Usha's five medals at the 1986 Seoul Asiad (4 gold) are India's individual best in athletics in one edition, Gulveer has matched the three medals sprinter Lavy Pinto collected at the 1951 New Delhi Games.

Gritting his teeth, as he kept pace with the small lead bunch in steady drizzle at the Nagoya City Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium on the final day of athletics competitions, Gulveer didn't cause doubts if he would fade away. There were still three laps to go in the 5,000m final and the man who has been a picture of tirelessness was soldiering on.

Inclement weather didn't deter the 28-year-old Armyman from Ali-garh at the Glasgow CWG, where the national record holder in 10,000m and 5,000m took silver and bronze to underline

his development to tackle the tactical challenges of competing in a Games. The Asian Games hasn't been easy despite the smaller fields. On Tuesday, the 5,000m had a bigger



India's Gulveer Singh during the 5,000m on Tuesday.

field but only six were bunched after the first few laps. But there were two or three with a sharper finish. On Monday, his superb 1,500m silver came after India's specialist pick for the distance, Yoonus Shah, didn't show any fight to end up ninth (3:43.88). Gulveer's strong finish and the joyous spreading of arms showed how much of a success that silver was for him.

The 10,000m silver first up could have been gold but for the awesome sprint finish of Bahrain's Birhanu Balew, the runner of Ethiopian origin. On Tuesday, Balew could not be denied the double. Although Japan's Tomonori Yamaguchi set off with 600m left to blunt that late finish, the adopted Bahraini had plenty in reserve. Balew clocked 13:30.79 with Yamaguchi second at 13:31.43.

Gulveer, clocked 13:32.75, pedestrian for a man whose national record is 12:59.77, but the race had been more about tactical jockeying in the rain than about speed. He also had to come through a mini battle into the final bend with Nagiya Mori, and like he did to the Japanese in the 1,500m,

he again edged him out for the bronze, braving the heaviness that would surely have set in his legs due to the workload.

Despite no gold, Gulveer can be pleased with his effort, and the depth he honed in the altitude of Colorado Springs, USA. He has improved leaps and bounds after a lone 10,000m bronze at 2023 Hangzhou to emerge India's finest distance runner of this century since 2023 Hangzhou.

It is Gulveer's fourth Asian Games medal. The gold is missing, but if one keeps aside the sensational 5,000m-10,000m double of the late distance master of the continent, Hari Chand, at the 1978 Bangkok Asiad, Gulveer can be counted alongside the few Indians who have shone in the two distance events since then, including Avinash Sable (5,000m silver, 3,000m steeplechase gold in 2023 Hangzhou).

"Winning this bronze feels good. I don't keep track of records, I just try to give my best every time I run...I have been away from my family and this medal is for them," Gulveer signed off, now ready to relax and see the sights in Japan.



ASIAN GAMES AICHI-NAGOYA

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

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From hospital bed to Asiad gold, Neeru ends India's 48-year wait

The Haryana shooter overcomes two health scares, shows calmness in women's trap final

Shantanu Srivastava

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NEW DELHI: As Neeru Dhandha completed her second series of five shots in the women's trap final at the General Shooting Gallery in Aichi on Tuesday, coach Mansher Singh, watching the action with his trainees at Delhi's Dr Karni Singh Shooting Range, knew his ward was "switched on". Neeru, at that stage, was in second place behind China's Sun Yunong.

"It was too early to predict but looking at her body language, I knew she was in the zone. When she is in that space, she tends to go the distance," Mansher, a multiple Asian Games medalist in team events, told HT.

Neeru did go the distance, drawing level in the next series before opening a two-point gap in the fourth. She then nailed nine of her next 10 hits to win gold, only the second top finish by an Indian in trap after the late Randhir Singh's epochal gold at the 1978 Bangkok Asiad. "We trained in bad weather conditions too, so in that sense this was normal. But conditions differ from country to country, so there were some difficulties. I kept calm, stayed focused on my game and brought home the gold," Neeru told the media in Japan.

Manavjit Singh Sandhu (Doha, 2006) and Neeru's cousin Lakshay Sheoran (Jakarta, 2018) won a silver each in trap while Kynan Chenai shot a bronze in Hangzhou 2023. It makes Neeru the first Indian woman medalist in the list.

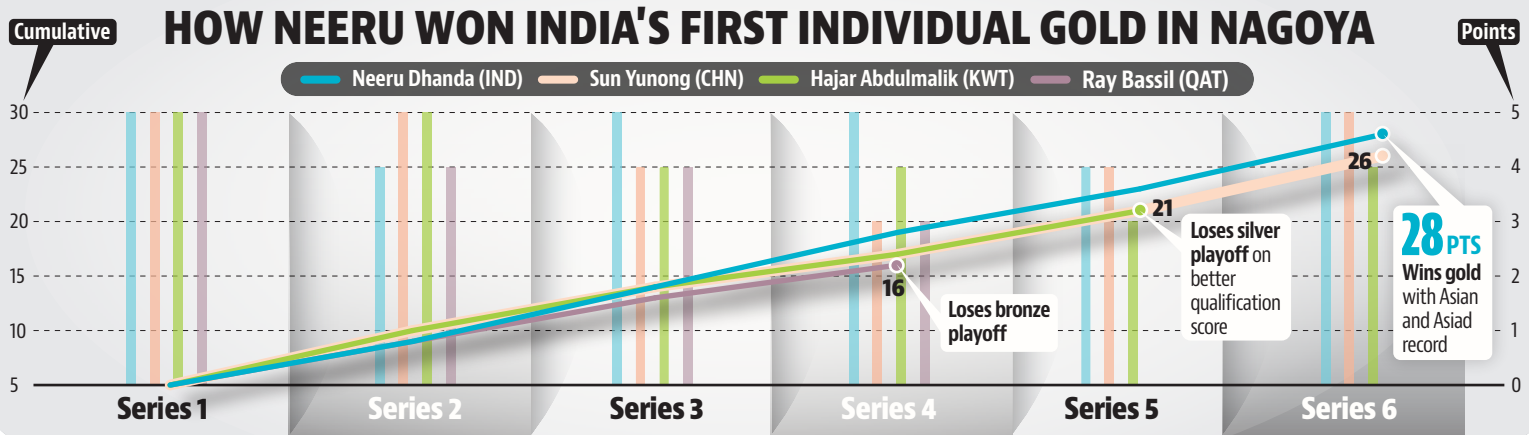
The 26-year-old, on Asian Games debut, shot a brilliant 28 out of possible 30 to break the Asian as well as Games record and coast to a memorable win ahead of Sun Yunong, who shot 26 to take silver. Kuwait's Hajar Abdulmalik was third with 21 hits.

"It was a clinical show. Such a score can win you an Olympic medal, although the pressure there is completely different. She is a very confident shooter and was determined to cash in on her good form," Mansher said.

Neeru, a Naib Subedar in the Indian Army, had recently become the first Indian woman to win an ISSF Shotgun World Cup gold when she shot 27 in Lonato, Italy. Last year, she won an individual and team gold in the Asian Championships in Shymkent, Kazakhstan. And yet, Neeru almost missed the Asian Games due to a bout of Influenza B.



India's Neeru Dhandha at the medal ceremony for the women's trap shooting individual event.



Barely a week before her scheduled departure for Japan, Neeru fell ill during a training session at the Karni Singh range and was rushed to hospital by Mansher. "She remained in hospital for a few days and was severely exhausted. She had a fever and got rashes all over the body. She literally went from hospital to the Games. Her training was hampered," Mansher added.

This was the second time in their six-year association that Mansher has been Neeru's saviour. Shortly after she began training in the Madhya Pradesh Shooting Academy where Mansher was chief coach, Neeru contracted Covid-19 and stopped coming to the range. "She was out of reach and

we had to look at every possible hospital for her. We finally discovered her in a terrible state and used our contacts to get her into a decent hospital where she recovered. Covid took a heavy toll on her health and it took her about 18 months to recover," the coach said.

Hailing from Jind, Haryana, Neeru took up sport following her cousin Lakshya's success. She learned the basics on his spare shotgun and used tin cans as makeshift targets before Lakshya's parents brought her to the Madhya Pradesh State Shooting Academy. "I am so proud of her. I still remember when she

told me she wants to try trap shooting because of me. Now, she has gone a step ahead and bettered my Asian Games result," Lakshya said. "I am not a coach. I just guided her in her early years, so all credit should go to her and Mansher sir. I was impressed with her work ethic, and as she grew into the sport, her temperament became her strength," he added.

Mansher agreed. "What has always separated her is her composure. She doesn't get flustered easily, and her record in the finals is very good. There are shooters who do very well in qualification but freeze in

the finals. Neeru is the opposite." That unflappable temperament was on display right through the final where she remained unaffected by the pouring rain and stiff competition in the biggest final of her career. "Overcast conditions can sometimes improve the visibility of the target. Anyway, conditions are the same for everyone. You have to start well and finish well, that's how modern shooting is," Mansher said.

"She seized early advantage and once she led, she made sure to finish well. That's the hallmark of a good shooter. If she maintains this level, she can be a contender at LA Olympics."

Neeru's score, Lakshya predicted, will be impossible to beat in

the near future. "I sat in front of TV and watched her in awe. It was perfect shooting. A Games record of 28/30 is good enough to stand for a decade, if not more," he said.

They train together whenever Neeru is in Delhi and the sibling rivalry does get intense. "None of us like losing, so when we train together, we really push each other. She is very competitive but doesn't let emotion get the better of her. We have spent countless hours together in the range and to see her win gold brought back all those memories," Lakshya said.

Individual gold was Neeru's second medal of the day, following the trap team silver that she clinched with Manisha Keer and Aashima Ahlawat.



Parveen Hooda after winning her semi-final bout.

Parveen, Ankush in boxing finals, assured of silver

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MUMBAI: Around two months ago, with Indian women boxing in the spotlight of a record boxing haul from the CWG, Parveen Hooda returned as the only female boxer without a medal. Around three years ago, she returned from the Asian Games with a 57kg bronze, only for it to be scratched.

All through those months of serving a doping ban for whereabouts failures, Parveen prayed for another opportunity. All through this month-and-a-half of the quick CWG-Asian Games turnaround, she quietly worked behind the scenes towards another opportunity. And when it came at the Nishio Gymnasium in Aichi, it pushed Parveen's redemption arc at the 2026 Asian Games.

The Haryana boxer defeated China's Li Shu 5-0 in the 65kg semi-final and confirm at least a silver.

The Indian boxing contingent, as a whole, has already bettered its Hangzhou show, which had three bronze and a silver. From the six assured medals, Ankush produced a brilliant turnaround after losing the first round to stun reigning world champion Fazliddin Erkinboev of Uzbekistan 4-1 in their 80kg semi-final. With three more Indian semi-finalists in action on Wednesday, there could be more finalists.

Parveen will be one of them. It won't be easy against Chinese Taipei's Olympic and Worlds medalist Chen Nien-chin. But nothing has been easy for this 26-year-old over the past couple of years. Be it the frustration of serving a doping suspension while watching the Paris Olympics slip away, or switching weight categories upon return, or staying patient even as success at CWG level - relatively less challenging than Asian - eluded her.

"She's been excellent," Santiago Nieva, the women's team head coach, told HT from Aichi.

medalstally

COUNTRY	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
1 CHN	143	62	49	254
2 JPN	45	71	67	183
3 KOR	24	27	44	95
4 UZB	14	17	13	44
5 THA	12	9	12	33
6 BAH	11	5	4	20
7 IRN	10	16	11	37
8 KAZ	9	14	25	48
9 PKR	7	5	6	18
10 India	6	21	25	52

"She's making great improvements. She has learnt a lot from the couple of competitions in which she lost before, and put in a lot of effort in the camp."

Maximum effort went into correcting an evident technical glitch in this relatively new 65kg boxer. Parveen, a dangerous counter-attacker in 57kg, had the habit of rushing into attacks and losing her shape at times. Against taller and stronger opponents in 65kg, getting into "messy and wrestling type" positions, as Nieva put it, was detrimental for Parveen.

"Now she has more patience, better balance, better attack positions from the centre instead of getting too close, and better footwork," Nieva said.

Control is something Parveen felt she had lost of her career two years ago. The whereabouts failure and the backdated 14-month suspension took her Asian Games medal, the Paris Games quota, and progress in 57kg. "All through last year, I prayed that somehow I get a chance to represent India in an event like this again. I had plenty of doubts about whether it could happen, because I was out for a long time," Parveen had told HT during the CWG.

"Look, that was a long time ago. We can't change what happened in the past," said Nieva, India's former high-performance director who returned to the setup late last year. "What we could change was her weight category, and how she could box against those stronger, slower opponents."

GAMES CONNECTION

RUTHLESS AN RETAINS ASIAD CROWN

An Se-young wants to follow in the footsteps of badminton legend Lin Dan after becoming the first woman to win two Asian Games singles titles on Tuesday, while Thailand's Kunlavut Vitidsarn clinched the men's crown. An, the Olympic and world champion from South Korea, has not lost a match since March and gave another ruthless display in dominating Japan's Akane Yamaguchi 21-17, 21-9 in the final in Nagoya. It was the 24-year-old's eighth title of an incredible 2026 and gave her a second Asian Games gold after winning three years ago in Hangzhou. China's Lin, regarded as the greatest badminton player of all time, won two Asian Games men's singles titles. He also won Olympic gold twice and was a five-time world champion.

"I am trying to keep up with this great athlete," said world number one An. "There are lots of strong athletes that have achieved great things, and they motivate me to also perform well." An has only lost one match this year.



INDIA SPIKERS BEAT QATAR, IN QUARTERS

The Indian men's volleyball team continued its winning run, eking out a hard-fought 3-2 win over Qatar to register its third victory and qualify for the quarterfinals of the Asian Games here on Tuesday. The Indian team bounced back from being two sets down to defeat Qatar 26-28, 25-27, 25-23, 25-20, 24-22 in a marathon Pool C match, which lasted two hours and 47 minutes. All four quarterfinals will be played on Thursday.

India had earlier defeated Vietnam 3-0 (25-23, 25-21, 25-20) and Hong Kong China 3-0 (25-22, 25-19, 25-21) in their opening two matches respectively.

Against Qatar, Jerome Vinith scored 27 points for India, all coming through spikes, while Amit Singh Balwan scored 24 points -- 22 from spikes and two from blocks. Joel Benjamin Jebaraj also made double-digit scores with 17 points -- 14 from spikes, two from blocks, and one service point.

TOUGH DRAW AWAITS WRESTLERS

Sujeet Kalkal's red-hot form, Antim Panghal's bid to reclaim the spotlight and Olympic bronze medalist Aman Sehrawat's return to the Asian Games will headline India's wrestling campaign, with all three facing challenging draws. Sujeet (65kg) is in the same half as Japan's Olympic champion Kotaro Kiyouoka, with a potential quarterfinal against Iran's Abbas Ebrahimezhadeh and a semifinal meeting with Kiyouoka. Antim Panghal's (53kg) draw puts her in the same half as China's Zhang Jin. Japan's Moe Kiyouoka and North Korea's Choe Hyo Gyong are in the other half. Aman Sehrawat (57kg) could face either Uzbekistan's Gulomjon Abdullaev, an Olympic bronze medalist, or Japan's Yamato Ogawa in the opening round. A quarterfinal against Kazakhstan's Nurdanat Aitanov and a potential semifinal against Iran's Ali Momeni also await if he advances.

Justin Greaves ruled out of second ODI GUWAHATI: West Indies suffered a major blow ahead of their must-win second ODI against India on Wednesday with in-form opener Justin Greaves ruled out of the match after sustaining a calf injury. Greaves, who struck his maiden ODI hundred in T'puram, sustained the injury during his 101 off 108 balls.

Friendly: Brazil rally to beat Aus
BRISBANE: Brazil came from behind to beat a gallant Australia 4-2 in an entertaining friendly in front of over 52,000 fans in Brisbane on Tuesday. Brazil scored two goals late in the second half to see off the Socceroos. The South Americans needed a last-minute goal to salvage a draw in their first match in Townsville on Friday, but turned in an improved performance to emerge victorious in the second part of their double-header.

Medvedev downs Rublev to seal title

HANGZHOU: Former world No. 1 Daniil Medvedev sealed his third title of the year on Tuesday, downing Andrey Rublev 7-5, 6-4 in the Hangzhou Open final. The all-Russian affair in eastern China was a battle of the two favourites, with top-seeded Medvedev -- now the world number six -- edging out his compatriot. It was Medvedev's first title since Dubai in February and his 24th title on the tour.



From left, golfers Vidhatri Urs, Hitaashee Bakshi, Vani Kapoor, Jasmine Shekar with the Women's Indian Open trophy.

Women's Indian Open from Oct 22

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NEW DELHI: India's women golfers get a huge opportunity to make a statement this week when Aditi Ashok, Diksha Dagar and Pranavi Urs tee off in the Asian Games on Wednesday. They can make an impact as a larger group if an Indian winner emerges at the Hero Women's Indian Open, to be played at the DLF Golf and Country Club from October 22-25.

The \$500,000 Ladies European Tour event, in its 18th edition, last saw a home winner in 2016 -- Aditi Ashok -- who is now striving to make a mark on the LPGA Tour.

While three of the last four winners -- Shannon Tan of Singapore (2025), England's Liz Young (2024) and Germany's Olivia Cowan (2022) -- will be in the field, Indian players will feel they are not too far away from crowning themselves.

Last year, Hitaashee Bakshi was third, Pranavi fourth and Avani Prashanth tied fifth. At a media conference on Tuesday to launch the event, Hitaashee spoke about the heartbreak and how her mother handed a poster of the trophy when she returned home to motivate her. "I gave 100%, yet I wasn't happy. My mother said

whatever you feel now, next year you must bring the trophy. This time I will win!"

However, the DLF course is likely to be set up as one of the toughest on the tour, as has been the norm. Women's Golf Association of India (WGAI) president, Kavita Singh, appealed: "Maybe on behalf of the players, make it a bit kinder."

She said Indian players are not far away in terms of skills, but "we've to work on our mental strength. Beyond a point the game, technical abilities are all the same."

The field includes past LET Order of Merit winners: Tan, Switzerland's Chiara Tamburini and Thailand's Trichat Cheeng-lab. WGAI secretary-general, Champika Sayal said while Indian women golfers are steadily improving it was important to do well on the international tours to get a ranking boost, which is key to be in contention for the 2028 LA Olympics. Currently five Indians hold full playing rights on LET (Aditi, Diksha, Pranavi, Avani and Hitaashee) while Vani Kapoor, who has two wins on the domestic tour this season and heads the Order of Merit, has a conditional card.

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